



BJP women leaders slam INDIA Bloc over women's quota defeat

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

BJP women MPs and leaders, including Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, Hema Malini, Bansuri Swaraj and Kamaljeet Sehrawat, on Saturday led a protest march towards the residence of the leader of opposition in the Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi in Delhi, a day after the 131st Constitution Amendment Bill on women's reservation failed to pass in the House, with the Congress-led INDIA bloc refusing to back the delimitation process linked to it.

The protestors gathered at Moti Lal Nehru Marg, torched an effigy of Rahul Gandhi and tried to reach his residence when the police used water cannon to disperse them and detained several leaders.

Near the Sunehri Masjid



BJP MP Bansuri Swaraj, along with party workers, burnt an effigy of Rahul Gandhi during a protest by opposition parties in New Delhi

at the time of the protest. The Congress leader was attending a poll rally in Tamil Nadu. The protesters, including BJP women MPs Hema Malini, Manju Sharma, and Vatsalya Gupta, slammed the Opposition parties for the defeat of the Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill in the Lok Sabha on Friday, accusing them of "humiliating"

the women of the country. The BJP termed the Congress' stand "anti-women", raising slogans and holding placards after 230 opposition MPs voted against the bill, which required a two-thirds majority to be passed. In contrast, 298 members of the ruling NDA coalition supported it.

The chief minister said that opposition parties collectively stated in Parliament that women should not receive reservations in legislative bodies.

"For the past 30 years, half the population has endured humiliation as the bill has repeatedly been introduced but either torn apart or opposed," she said and asserted that the women of the country will register their strong response to the injustice done to them.

Mathura MP Hema Malini

said Prime Minister Narendra Modi worked hard for the passing of the bill, but the Opposition parties did not allow it. "It's a very sad day for us. It seems the Opposition has no confidence in women's power, and they don't want them to have their rights," she said.

Swaraj, one of the BJP's seven Lok Sabha MPs from Delhi, where the party holds all seven constituencies, accused Rahul and the INDIA bloc of "betraying" women. "The entire opposition, especially LoP Gandhi, betrayed the women of this country yesterday. They backstabbed women. They want women's role to be limited to polling booths. When it came to political representation, they chose their own interests and now face the anger of women," she added.

Sehrawat, another BJP MP

from Delhi, said the government wanted to implement the Women's Reservation Bill on a "priority" basis, but the INDIA bloc voted to defeat the legislation.

The party claimed over 10,000 women participated in the March. Union minister Raksha Khadse, MPs Manoj Tiwari and Ramvir Singh Bidhuri, too, joined the protest.

Sachdeva said that opposition leaders behaved as a "royal family," who cannot see beyond their own families. They have worked to deprive the women, who are half of the country's population, of their rightful share by preventing the bill from being passed, he said.

North East Delhi MP Manoj Tiwari asserted that women will one day get their due rights, if not today, then tomorrow.

Injustice will not go unanswered: CM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Saturday protested the non-passage of the Mahila Shakti Amendment Bill in Parliament by wearing a black armband at a summit here. Terming it a "painful" development, she slammed the Opposition parties for blocking the passage of the 131st Constitutional Amendment Bill in the Lok Sabha on Friday.

Registering a sharp protest, she wore a black band at a summit organised by the Confederation of All India Traders (CAIT), targeting what she termed the Opposition's anti-women politics. The event witnessed intense sloganeering, led by the Chief Minister, in support of women's rights.

She said Prime Minister Narendra Modi had introduced the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhinyam to ensure women's participation in nation-building and bring them into the mainstream of decision-making.

Calling it a historic and transformative reform, the Chief Minister said it was



unfortunate that some parties chose narrow politics over women's empowerment and opposed the move. Every woman in their constituencies will question the "anti-women" stance taken by the Opposition parties, she said at a women's entrepreneurs summit. She, also, led the sloganeering in support of women's rights at the summit.

"As a woman Chief Minister, this is not merely political, it is about dignity and sensitivity," she said, adding that a crucial opportunity to give crores of women a role in decision-making had been taken away.

The chief minister said the arguments put forward by

parties opposing women's reservation lacked substance and reflected a clear anti-women mindset. She warned that women and daughters across the country would demand answers from such leaders in their own constituencies.

The Chief Minister also alleged that this was not the first time the Congress and its allies had obstructed women's empowerment, saying their approach exposed their real intent. "Women are watching and understanding everything. This injustice will not go unanswered," she said, asserting that the country has changed and women will now claim their rights.

MCD to organise heritage walks, seminars across city from May to July

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Municipal Corporation of Delhi is planning to organise a series of heritage walks and seminars across the city likely from May to July, showcasing the national capital's evolution through its prominent sites, officials said.

The initiative, planned as a "Summer Circuit", is likely to feature events on the first and third Saturdays of each month, with a total of six early-morning walks scheduled over the three-month period, they said.

Officials said the walks are likely to be scheduled in the morning hours in view of rising temperatures.

The routes are expected to cover key historical sites, including Lal Kot, regarded as the city's earliest fortified settlement, the Qutub

Complex, Feroz Shah Kotla Fort, and parts of Shahjahanabad, focusing on its surviving gates.

The decision to organise the programme was taken at a recent review meeting of the civic body's heritage initiatives, officials said.

While no separate fee will be charged for the walks and seminars, participants will have to pay entry fees at monuments where applicable, they said.

One of the walks planned for July will focus on remains from the Mauryan period, including rock edicts and pillars attributed to Ashoka, they added.

The civic body had organised a similar series of heritage walks during the winter of 2024, including walks in the Qutub Minar area, covering the city's medieval settlements.



Retail Asset Centre: AXIS Bank Ltd. Axis House, Tower T-2, 2nd Floor, I-14, Sector-128, Noida Expressway, Jaypee Greens Wishtown, Noida U.P., 201301.

Publication of Notice regarding possession of property u/s 13(4) of SARFAESI Act 2002

Notice is hereby given under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 (54 of 2002) and in exercise of powers conferred under section 13 (12) read with rule 9 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002, a demand notice was issued on the dates mentioned against each account and stated herein after calling upon them to repay the amount within 60 days from the date of receipt of said notice. The Borrower having failed to repay the amount, notice is hereby given to the Borrower and the public in general that the undersigned has taken possession of the property described herein below in exercise of power conferred on him/her under section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 9 of the said Act on the dates mentioned against each account. The Borrower in particular and the public in general is hereby cautioned not to deal with the property and any dealings with the property will be subject to the charge of Axis Bank Ltd. for an amount and interest thereon. The borrowers attention is invited to provisions of Sub-section (8) of Section 13 of the Act, in respect of time available to redeem the secured assets.

Name of Borrower/Co-borrower: 1. M/s. Sakshi Lingeries Private Limited Plot No. F-707, F-708, Mussorie Gulawathi Road, Phase I, Dasna, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh- 201015 (Borrower/Mortgagor) 2. Mr. Prateek Gupta R/o. 1603 Tower-1 Ahinsakhand-1, Orange County Indrapuram Ghaziabad Uttar Pradesh-201014 (Co-borrower/ Guarantor) 3. M . Pawan Gupta R/o. 1603 Tower-1 Ahinsakhand-1, Orange County Indrapuram Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh-201014 (Co-borrower/ Guarantor) 4. Mrs. Geeta Gupta R/o. 1603 Tower-1 Ahinsakhand-1, Orange County Indrapuram Ghaziabad Uttar Pradesh- 201014 (Co-borrower/ Guarantor)

Description of mortgaged Property : All That Part And Parcel Of Plot No. F709, Area Admeasuring 714.86 Sq. Mtrs., Upside, MG Road, Industrial Area, Tehsil Dhulana, Hapur, Uttar Pradesh-245101. Together With The Right To Use Common Area Of The Building The Right To Use Water Closets, Drainage, Lavatories And Other Conveniences And Facilities, Amenities In Or Upon Or Pertaining To Or Connected Flat/unit/office Premises Both Present And Future And Easementary Rights And Together With All Fixtures And Fittings Both Present And Future Which Is Binded As Under:- North: Road 18 M Wide, Road No. 20, East : Plot No. F-708, South: Other Land, West : Plot No. F-710

NPA Date:	Date of Demand Notice:	Date of Possession:	Amount in Demand Notice as on
26.01.2026	03.02.2026	17.04.2026	Rs.1,50,80,451.42/-

Place: DHULANA, Date:19.04.2026 Authorized Officer, Axis Bank Ltd.

Retail Asset Centre : Axis Bank Ltd. BF-A-12,3, 1st Floor, Aditya City Centre, Niti Khands-1, Indrapuram, Ghaziabad-201012 Also at Axis Bank Ltd., Axis House, Tower T-2, 2nd Floor, H-14, Sector-128, Noida Expressway, Jaypee Greens Wishtown, Noida (U.P.)-201301 Corporate Office: 'Axis House', Block-B, Bombay Dyeing Mills Compound, Pandurang Budhkar Marg, Worli, Mumbai-400025 Registered Office: 'Trishul', 3rd floor, opposite Samartheshwar Temple, Law garden, Ellisbridge, Ahmedabad-380006

POSSESSION NOTICE UNDER SARFAESI ACT 2002

Whereas The undersigned being the Authorized Officer of Axis Bank Ltd. under the Securitization, Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and in exercise of the powers conferred under section 13 (12) read with Rule 9 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) rules 2002, issued demand notice upon the Borrower(s)/ Co-Borrower(s)/ Guarantor(s)/ Mortgagor(s) mentioned below, to repay the amount mentioned in the notice within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said notice. The Borrower(s)/ Co-Borrower(s)/ Guarantor(s)/ Mortgagor(s) having failed to repay the amount, notice is hereby given to the Borrower(s)/ Co-Borrower(s)/ Guarantor(s)/ Mortgagor(s) and the public in general that the undersigned has taken possession of the property described herein below in exercise of powers conferred on him/ her under Section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the said rules on the below-mentioned dates. The Borrower(s)/ Co-Borrower(s)/ Guarantor(s)/ Mortgagor(s) in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned not to deal with the property and any dealings with the property will be subject to the charge of Axis Bank Ltd. The Borrower(s)/ Co-Borrower(s)/ Guarantor(s)/ Mortgagor(s) attention is invited to provisions of sub-section (8) of section 13 of the Act, in respect of time available, to redeem the secured assets.

Name of Borrower/Co-borrower: 1. Mr. Vineet Prakash R/o. 1705 Tower-'CV-5', On 17th Floor, Having Super Area 930 Sq. Feet (i.e. 86.40 Sq. Meters) With Sanitary, Electrical, And Other Fittings, In The Group Housing Scheme 'Capetown' At Group Housing Plot No. GH-01/A, Sector-74, Noida, District Gautam Budh Nagar, U.P. Bounded As Under:- North: As Per Title Deed, East: As Per Title Deed, South: As Per Title Deed, West: As Per Title Deed			
Date of Demand Notice:	Date of Possession:	Amount in Demand Notice (Rs.) :	Rs. 49,78,644/- (Rupees Forty Nine Lakh Seventy Eight Thousand Six Hundred Forty Four Only)
19-Oct-2023	16-Apr-2026		
The above-mentioned Borrower(s)/ Co-Borrower(s)/ Guarantor(s)/ Mortgagor(s) are hereby given a 30 days' Notice to repay the amount, else the mortgaged properties will be sold on the expiry of 30 days from the date of publication of this Notice, as per the provisions under the Rules 8 and 9 of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002.			
Date: 19.04.2026, Place: Delhi & NCR		Authorized Officer, Axis Bank Ltd.	

BEFORE THE HON'BLE CONSUMER DISTRICT COMMISSION, ERNAKULAM C.C. No. 146 OF 2024

Complainant: Lajimole K.B.,020/515-B, Sivatheertham, Hillpalace road, Kizhakkekkotta Thrippunithura, Ernakulam, Pin: 682301

Opposite party: KLB KOMAKI PVT LTD, Head office: Building No.10, 1st Floor, Rani Jhansi Road, Jhandewalan, New Delhi, Pin: 110055

NOTICE

Whereas the complainant has filed the above consumer complaint, which stands posted to 29/04/2026 at 11.AM for appearance of the opposite party, Notice is hereby given that you are required to appear before the Hon'ble Consumer District Commission, Ernakulam either in person or through your authorized agent, failing which the consumer complaint will be decided in accordance with the law in your absence.

Dated this 17th day of April 2026

By the order of the Commission SD/-

Mishal M. Dasan Counsel for the complainant

Public Notice

This is to inform the general public that Mr. Rama Shanker Bhargava and Mr. Ravi Shanker Bhargava and Dr. Madhuri Bhargava through GPA Mr. Ravi Shanker Bhargava were the owners of the Residential Flat no. 402, on 4th Floor, Block Ferrara, Super Covered area measuring 150 Sq. Ft., type - IKG-3, Block - Ferrara, "Mahagun Mansion Phase - I" Built-on Group Housing Plot no. 15, Situated in the Residential Colony Vaidhuv Khanda Indrapuram, Ghaziabad Tehsil and Distt. Ghaziabad, U.P. through Sale Deed Dated 16.05.2012 as doc. no. 19808 executed by Mr. Vivek Pratap and Mrs. Mona Singh in favour of Rama Shanker Bhargava and Mr. Ravi Shanker Bhargava and Dr. Madhuri Bhargava through GPA Mr. Ravi Shanker Bhargava in respect of said property. Thereafter, Mr. Ravi Shanker Bhargava executed a Regd. will in favour of Mrs. Chitra Bhargava vide dated 27.12.2019 as doc. no. 225. Unfortunately, Mr. Rama Shanker Bhargava and Mr. Ravi Shanker Bhargava both are expired. As per the Regd. will dated 27.12.2019, the share of the property left behind his legal heirs are Mrs. Prabha Bhargava, Mrs. Shanu Bhargava and Mr. Anmol Bhargava & As per the Legal heir Certificate, Mr. Ravi Shanker Bhargava left behind his legal heirs are Mrs. Chitra Bhargava, Mr. Akhil Bhargava and Mrs. Anumita Bhargava. Mrs. Prabha Bhargava, Mrs. Shanu Bhargava and Mr. Anmol Bhargava & Mrs. Chitra Bhargava, Mr. Akhil Bhargava and Mrs. Anumita Bhargava, Mr. Madhuri Bhargava intends to transfer the ownership of above flat property by way of Sale Deed to Mrs. Amarjeet Kaur Sahni. Subsequently, Mrs. Amarjeet Kaur Sahni is in the process of mortgaging the said flat with ICICI Home Finance Co. Ltd. Any objections or concerns regarding this transaction should be raised within a period of 10 days from the date of this public notice. Any objections submitted after the completion of this 10 days period will not be considered binding with respect to the said property or the interests of our client.

If anyone wishes to raise an objection, please do so within the stipulated 10-days period by contacting Law Veritas: North (Advocates & Legal Consultants) at Office No. 11, 1st Floor, Building No. A-44/A, Sector-16, Noida, Uttar Pradesh-201301. +919102 04499711, e-mail: accounts@lvnorth.in

Delhi Congress writes to LG, EC seeking relief for poll workers deployed for SIR

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Congress president Devender Yadav on Saturday urged authorities to reduce the workload of Booth Level Officers (BLOs) carrying out the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls, expressing concern over alleged violations of their rights due to dual responsibilities.

In a letter addressed to Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar, and Delhi's Chief Electoral Officer Ashok Kumar, Yadav said that teachers and government staff assigned BLO duties are under "tremendous pressure" while managing both academic and administrative responsibilities.

"Government employees, especially teachers working as BLOs, are under immense mental stress due to excessive workload and tight deadlines, and their working conditions must be made manageable," Yadav said.

He claimed that several reports have mentioned serious health consequences among the BLOs involved in the exercise across the country, including deaths due to stress.

The Pioneer Classified

Lost & Found

I, VIKRAM SUNDARJI S/O LATE GEN K SUNDARJI, have lost original Share Certificates, Allotment Letter, Possession Letter & other documents issued by AWHO & Som Vihar Co-operative Housing Society in respect of FLAT NO.A-703, SEVENTH FLOOR, BLOCK-A, TYPE-V, SOM VIHAR APARTMENTS, SECTOR-10, R.K. PURAM, NEW DELHI-110022, finder please contact: Mob. 9353181805 PD(907)C

CHANGE OF NAME

I, No. 15799375X Hav (OFC) Bibu VL, R/o- Thannimoodu Thalaniaruputhenveedu, Chembor, Ottasekharamangalam PO, Keezharoor, Thiruvananthapuram, Kerala - 695125, have changed my son's name from Tanishk Angelo B A to Tanishk Angelo B A, vide affidavit dated 18/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi. PD(908)C

I, JC-699928F Sub Dharmendra Dhakar, Serving at- Army Hospital R&R, Delhi Cantt-110010, have changed my father's name in my service record from Raghuvir singh Dhakar to Raghuvar Dayal, vide affidavit dated 18/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi. PD(909)C

I, JC-699928F Sub Dharmendra Dhakar, Serving at- Army Hospital R&R, Delhi Cantt-110010, have changed my mother's name in my service record from Leela Dhakar to Lila Dhakad, vide affidavit dated 18/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi. PD(910)C

PUBLIC NOTICE

My clients Anju Sharma and her husband Neel Kamal Sharma both R/O C-65, Kanti Nagar Extn., Krishna Nagar, Delhi-110051, have debarred (disowned their son namely, Vishal Sharma and his wife Pooja from all their movable and immovable properties and also have broken down all their ties and relations with them. My clients and their family members shall not be responsible in future for any kind of their acts, deeds, liabilities or transactions whether Civil or Criminal. If any person deals with them, he shall do so at his own risk and responsibility.

DEEPAK THAKRAL ADVOCATE Ch. No. D-620, K.K.D. Court, Delhi-110032

DEBTS RECOVERY TRIBUNAL-I, DELHI 4th Floor, Jeevan Tara Building, Parliament Street, New Delhi-110001 OANO.216/2025

INDIAN BANK APPLICANT Vs MS MAHADEV PACKGING GUPTA DEFENDANT

To, (1) M/S MAHADEV PACKAGING OFFICE AT 2ND FLOOR, PLOT NO.17, KHASRA NO. 1313, GALI NO. 14 SAMAPUR BADLI NEW DELHI-110042

(2) MR. SANTOSH GUPTA R/O B-6, 364-365, ROHINI SECTOR-7 DELHI-110085

ALSO AT B4/247 GROUND FLOOR ROHINI SECTOR 8 ROHINI SECTOR-7 NARELANORTH WEST DELHI-110085.

Whereas the above-named applicant has instituted a case for recovery of Rs.1,37,58,229/- (Rupees One Crore Thirteen Seven Lakhs Fifty Eight Thousand Two Hundred Twenty Nine Only) against you and whereas it has been shown to the satisfaction of the Tribunal that it is not possible to serve you in ordinary way. Therefore, this notice is given by advertisement directing you to make appearance before LD. Registrar on 23.04.2026. (for further details kindly visit DRT Website:www.tribunal.gov.in Phone Number: 011-23748473). Take notice that in case of your failure to appear on the above-mentioned day before this Tribunal, the case will be heard and decided in your absence.

(i) All concerned may attend their cases by hybrid mode (by physical appearance In the Court or through CISCO WEBEX VC Link)

(ii) For online appearance through VC all the Advocates/Litigants shall download the Cisco Webex application/software;

(iii) Meeting ID and Password for the next date of hearing qua cases to be taken by Hon'ble Presiding Officer/Registrar/ Recovery Officer-/and Recovery Officer-II shall be a available one day prior to the next date at DRT Official Portal i.e. dvt.gov.in under the Public Notice Head.

(iv) In any exigency qua that, the Advocates/Litigants can contact the concerned official at Ph.No.23748473.

Given under my hand and seal of the Tribunal on this 2ND JAN, 2026.

By order of this Tribunal, Sd/- Debts Recovery Tribunal-I, Delhi

Public Notice

This is to inform the general public that Mr. Jaspreet Singh and Mrs. Sahajpal are the owners of the First Floor, without roof right, "said Floor", Property Bearing no. D-26, area measuring 50 sq. Yds, i.e. 42.83 sq. Mtrs, out of Kharsa no. 155 sq. Yds. Situated in the revenue estate of Village Bindapur, Delhi state, area Abadi known as Colony Vishwas Park, Uttam Nagar, New Delhi - 110059 through Sale Deed dated 19.03.2025 as doc. no. 2025/159/17787 executed by Mrs. Neha Tiwari in favour of Mr. Jaspreet Singh and Mrs. Sahajpal Kaur in respect of said floor. Mr. Jaspreet Singh and Mrs. Sahajpal are in the process of mortgaging the said floor with ICICI Home Finance Co. Ltd. Any objections or concerns regarding this transaction should be raised within a period of 10 days from the date of this public notice. Any objections submitted after the completion of this 10-days period will not be considered binding with respect to the said property or the interests of our client.

If anyone wishes to raise an objection, please do so within the stipulated 10-days period by contacting Law Veritas: North (Advocates & Legal Consultants) at Office No. 11, 1st Floor, Building No. A-44/A, Sector-16, Noida, Uttar Pradesh-201301. +91102 04499711, e-mail: accounts@lvnorth.in

Public Notice

This is to inform general public that Mrs. Rama Chaudhary has acquired incidentally Flat no. 5-1, MIG, on covered floor, with roof rights, having covered area of 60.38 sq. mtrs. i.e. 650 sq. ft., on 4th floor residential Plot no. 155, Block-C situated at Residential Colony, Shalimar Garden Extn-II, Village Pasanda Pargana, Noida Tehsil & Distt. Ghaziabad, U.P. having area 165 sq. yds. Situated in 19.03.2026 registered as Document No. 3278. Document related to the above said property has been misplaced i.e. 17/10/2011 executed by (1) Mrs. Jaspreet Singh and Mrs. Sahajpal are in the process of mortgaging the said floor with ICICI Home Finance Co. Ltd. Any objections or concerns regarding this transaction should be raised within a period of 10 days from the date of this public notice. Any objections submitted after the completion of this 10-days period will not be considered binding with respect to the said property or the interests of our client.

If anyone wishes to raise an objection, please do so within the stipulated 10-days period by contacting Law Veritas: North (Advocates & Legal Consultants) at Office No. 11, 1st Floor, Building No. A-44/A, Sector-16, Noida, Uttar Pradesh-201301. +91102 04499711, e-mail: accounts@lvnorth.in

Public Notice

NAUR is hereby given on behalf of SHRI NIKHIL GAUR who is owned of Eastern Portion of Built-up property Municipal Corporation of New Delhi-333 (except First Floor without roof rights) out of Kharsa no. 1661/709, abadi of Lal Dora 1908-09 admeasuring 69.97 sq. mtrs. (82.5 sq. yds) approx. out of total area 165 sq. yds. Situated in the area of village Madipur, New Delhi-110063, having acquired the same vide Relinquishment Deed dated 17/10/2011 executed by (1) Mrs. Kamlesh, (2) Mrs. Mihlesh Singh, (3) Mrs. Madhu Bala, (4) Mrs. Seema, (5) Mrs. Malti, (6) Deo Chandra Sharma, (7) Mrs. Swati Kum, (8) Neha Gaur in favour of Shri Nikhil Gaur duly registered in the office of SR-II-Punjab Bagh as registration No. 6277, Addl. Book No. 1 Page Nos. 65-68, Volume No. 1903. Dated 17/10/2011 now Shri Nikhil Gaur and Bhawna intend to mortgage the subject property for the financial assistance from Capital India Finance Limited to comply the requirements of BANKNIFC. We give this public notice that if any person having any type of claim/rights/interest/creating mortgage over the said property, may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections, within 15 days from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances, lien etc. Lucien Legal LLP N-161, Ground Floor, Saina Tower, Gautam Nagar Near Yusuf Sarai Community Centre, New Delhi-110449 Contact # 011-40646316 & 41667327

Public Notice

This is to inform the general public that Shri. Piyush mobile no. 8100639993, Shri. Rohit s/o Shri. Sandeep Aggarwal, mobile no. 7302684510 and Sh. Sudhanshu Shrivastava mobile no. 8287076624 Manish Kuma mobile no. 9650533463 have left the services of our company. During their employment, the aforesaid persons were involved in leaking information regarding company policies, signing blank letter Heads, agreements to some third persons in respect of the company projects without any authorization. Any person dealing with the above said Three persons or on the basis of any of the above documents shall be at their own risk. The company shall not be held responsible.

For Milan Earth Infrastructure & Developers Pvt. Ltd Authorized Signatory Director

IED toy car plot foiled: Police arrest four terror suspects

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police has arrested four "radicalised" men from Maharashtra, Odisha and Bihar who allegedly planned terror activities, carried out recce of sensitive locations to target them and attempted to recruit others through encrypted online platforms.

An Improvised Explosive Device (IED) and related material were seized during the operation, police said. Two of the accused were in the process of assembling a remote-controlled toy car fitted with an IED to target crowded places, officials said on Saturday.

The Special Cell apprehended two of the accused from Maharashtra and one each from Odisha and Bihar in a coordinated, intelligence-led operation, the officials said. The four were influenced by

extremist ideology centred around the idea of establishing a caliphate and were promoting narratives such as "Ghazwa-e-Hind", the police alleged.

"They were also allegedly inspired by the concept of a 'Lashkar from Khurasan' carrying black flags, which they used as part of their propaganda to radicalise others," a senior police officer said.

He said the accused were active on closed and encrypted social media groups where content related to jihad, extremist ideology and weapons was shared. These platforms were allegedly used to identify, indoctrinate and recruit new members.

"One of the accused allegedly shared an edited image of the Red Fort with a black flag to radicalise followers and signal symbolic targets," the officer said. The probe revealed that

one of the accused had visited Delhi in December 2025 and conducted reconnaissance of key locations, including the Red Fort and India Gate.

Investigators said the module had also discussed potential strikes on high-value targets such as the Ram temple in Ayodhya, the Parliament House and certain military installations.

Security agencies believe the group intended to target crowded public places and symbolic landmarks to maximise panic and psychological impact. "All four accused — Mosaib Ahmad, Mohammad Hammad, Mohammad Sohail and Sheikh Imran — belong to modest socio-economic backgrounds. A case has been registered, and further investigation is underway to identify their associates, handlers and the broader network," the officer said. Mosaib had previously



worked in Gulf countries as an auto electrician and was allegedly using his technical skills to design a remote-controlled car fitted with an IED.

"Preliminary findings suggest the use of a small remote-controlled device points to a plan to execute a stealth attack in crowded areas," the officer said.

Investigators said the accused had begun collecting materials, conducting reconnaissance and coordinating

their activities through encrypted communication platforms before they were intercepted.

Mosaib Ahmad originally hails from Azamgarh in Uttar Pradesh and studied up to class 10th. He worked in various capacities, including as a welder, auto mechanic and auto electrician, in India and in countries like Saudi Arabia and Qatar. Presently, he was working at a private automobile workshop in

Thane. He was part of multiple online groups where discussions related to "Lashkar of Mahdi and jihad" were held. He assisted co-accused Mohammad Hammad by "opening the circuit of a remote-controlled toy car for IED making and sharing its image within a closed group".

Mohammad Hammad is a resident of Mumbai. He is pursuing class 12th through correspondence. Around January 2026, he joined a closed group in which other active members included Mosaib Ahmad.

In the group, discussions were held on jihad and Ghazwa-e-hind. He shared pictures of ball bearings, nails, a remote-controlled toy car and boxes as material for the preparation of an IED in a closed group, the officials alleged.

He handed them over to co-accused Mosaib Ahmad, who,

being a mechanic by profession, was tasked with assembling the IED, according to security agencies.

Sheikh Imran was born in Bhubaneswar, Odisha, in a lower-class household. He studied up to the 10th standard and, thereafter, worked as a security guard and delivery boy. In 2024, he began listening to lectures/takreers of Tareeq Jameel, Israr Ahmed, Zakir Naik, etc. and gradually developed radical beliefs.

He came across his associates Mohammad Hammad and Mosaib Ahmad through social media and created a closed group where discussions centred on jihad, khilafat and Ghazwa-e-Hind. He discussed targeting "Ram Mandir, Parliament and military installations", they alleged.

He visited Delhi in December 2025 for a recce of the Red Fort and India Gate.

He promised members that he would arrange arms training and physical training, including horse riding, in Odisha and asked them to contribute funds for the same.

Mohammad Sohail is a resident of Katihar, Bihar. He is a plumber by profession. He studied up to Class 10.

"He was influenced by the speeches of Israr Ahmed. He created multiple social media accounts and exhorted youth in the name of jihad. In March 2026, he incited followers of his channel to collect weapons and explosives for Ghazwa-e-Hind. He shared his bank account/QR code to collect money in the name of jihad," the officer alleged.

Multiple mobile phones and digital devices have been seized and are being analysed to uncover the full extent of the conspiracy and any possible links to other modules, police added.

Main accused held for stabbing father-son duo in south Delhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police has arrested the main accused behind the double murder of an elderly man and his son, who were stabbed to death in the south Delhi area.

The deceased were identified as Rakesh Sood (62) and his son Karan Sood (27), while his cousin Rahul suffered injuries and is undergoing treatment, police said.

According to the police, information regarding the incident was received around 9:20 pm on Friday from a private hospital in Saket, where three persons from Tara Apartments at Alaknanda under the CR Park police station in south Delhi were admitted by their relatives.

"Upon examination, Rakesh Sood and Karan Sood were declared brought dead by doctors, while Rahul was found injured," Additional Deputy Commissioner of Police, South, Aishwarya Singh, said. Soon after the incident, a police team rushed to the spot. During the investigation, the police found that the incident took place due to a long-standing financial dispute.

"The accused, Asad Siddiqui, a resident of Tara Apartments, attacked the victims with a



sharp-edged object around 6 pm," Singh said.

Crime and forensic teams inspected the scene and collected evidence, while CCTV footage from the area is being analysed as part of the probe, the police said.

"Based on the survivor's statement, a case was registered, and the accused was arrested," Singh said. The vehicle used by the accused to flee from the crime scene has been seized.

Investigators suspect that the altercation may have escalated following disagreements over monetary dealings between the accused and the victims.

Police said that the mobile phones of the accused and the victims will be examined to establish the last communication exchanged between them. Technical analysis, including call detail records and digital evidence, is expected to play a crucial

role in reconstructing the chain of events leading up to the murders.

Police are questioning the accused to ascertain the exact sequence of events and the nature of the financial dispute that led to the fatal attack. For many in the neighbourhood, the double murder left a lingering sense of disbelief. The elderly man is survived by his wife and two daughters, both aged around 30.

Meanwhile, Aam Aadmi Party leader and Delhi unit president Saurabh Bharadwaj, in a post on X, raised concerns over the law and order situation in the national capital.

Referring to the location, he said Tara Apartments in Alaknanda was considered a safe gated colony where several prominent figures, including former Union minister Sushma Swaraj, had resided, and added that such incidents reflect a worrying situation.

CAN'T BELIEVE THEY ARE GONE: NEIGHBOURS

New Delhi: Sixty-two-year-old Rakesh Sood was known for organising a 'bhandara' to feed the poor every Thursday, making sure that no one left hungry. On Saturday, his house in the upscale Tara Apartments at Alaknanda under the CR Park police station in south Delhi stood broken after he and his 27-year-old son Karan Sood were fatally stabbed on Friday, with family members and neighbours struggling to come to terms with the loss.

"They lost everything in one night, the father and the only son. The house looks so empty that it is hard to describe in words," said a friend of Rakesh, requesting anonymity.

According to police, Rakesh and his son Karan were attacked with a sharp-edged object around 6 pm on Friday inside the apartment complex.

The accused, Asad Siddiqui, a resident of the same society, has been arrested.

Information about the incident was received at 9:20 pm on Friday from a private hospital in Saket, where three men were admitted by their relatives.

While Rakesh and Karan were declared brought dead, their relative, Rahul, sustained injuries and is undergoing treatment, police said.

Police suspect the attack was linked to a long-standing financial dispute.

For those who knew the family, the details of the crime have done little to soften the blow.

"Rakesh Ji was a very religious person. Every Thursday, he would organise a 'bhandara' (community meal) outside his house," a neighbour said. "He would stand there himself and serve food to people. It is difficult to accept what has happened," he said.

The residents of the society described Rakesh, who was in the real estate business, as someone always available at times of need.

"If anyone approached him for help, he never refused. Whether it was financial help or any other support, he would quietly step in. People trusted him," a colleague said.

Karan, the neighbours said, had joined his father in the family business and worked closely with him.

LG participates in DDA's Delhi Heritage Week at Mehrauli park

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Saturday participated in DDA's Delhi Heritage Week at Mehrauli Archaeological Park managed by the Delhi Development Authority (DDA). "Mehrauli Park has been restored by DDA as part of its redevelopment project. We want people to come and see 'ease of living' efforts by the DDA," Sandhu said.

LG Sandhu also said that the traffic situation will be improved in the national Capital.

"A new system will be adopted in Delhi to eliminate the problem of illegal roadside parking. Additionally, modern technology will be used for



better management of street lights and traffic in the capital. Extra steps will be taken to enhance women's safety in Delhi," LG Sandhu said.

LG also said that resident welfare associations (RWAs) will be included to resolve the problem of traffic jams.

"Local-level RWAs will work in coordination with the Delhi Traffic Police.

Wherever there are problems of illegal parking and traffic, emphasis will be placed on implementing this system at those locations first," Sandhu added.

The LG also said that he is continuously meeting with the citizens of Delhi.

"The general public wants that if a road is in poor condition, it should be repaired immediately," he added.

Female wolf dies in Delhi Zoo

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A female wolf brought from Patna Zoo under an exchange animal programme has died at Delhi's National Zoological Park, raising questions over the adherence to quarantine protocols, sources said.

The wolf that allegedly sustained a hind limb fracture during the transfer was under veterinary observation, and she died on Thursday, the source said.

According to the guidelines of the Central Zoo Authority, quarantine is an essential part of the animal exchange process, requiring monitoring the health, stress, and adaptation of newly arrived animals, the source said.

Questions have been raised about whether standard quarantine protocols were followed in this case.



Four wolves were brought from Patna Zoo to Delhi Zoo as part of an exchange programme, he said.

No immediate response was available from zoo authorities.

The Delhi Zoo has faced multiple animal deaths in recent months. In January, four chousinghas (four-horned antelopes) died, and later IVRI toxicology reports detected traces of phosphine in their samples.

Around the same period, a jackal died after entering

a Himalayan black bear enclosure, while a female Sangai deer and a female antelope also died. A male Sangai deer also died later and was under treatment for a hind limb injury.

In February, a 15-year-old jaguar died due to age-related complications, according to zoo authorities.

In March, a two-year-old white tigress named Durga suffered a hind limb fracture while being prepared for transfer to Patna Zoo.

5 held for ₹1 cr burglary in Madhu Vihar area; jewellery, cash recovered

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police has cracked a burglary case involving theft of valuables worth around ₹1 crore in east Delhi's Madhu Vihar area, arresting five people, including a goldsmith who allegedly received the stolen property, an official said on Saturday.

The case pertains to a burglary reported at Arya Nagar Apartment in the Madhu Vihar area earlier this month, he said.

A complaint was received on April 1, in which the victim said that the house had been locked on the evening of March 31, but upon returning the next day, "the locks were found broken and gold, diamond and silver jewellery, along with cash, were missing", a senior police officer said.

The total value of stolen items was estimated at around ₹1 crore, including nearly ₹12 lakh in cash, the officer said, adding that the police registered an FIR and an investigation was taken up.

"The team mapped the movement of the accused over a stretch of nearly 10 km, which proved crucial

in identifying them. Police conducted a raid on April 8 and arrested two accused, identified as Babloo alias Kalua and Rampal alias Ramkumar," the officer said.

During interrogation, they revealed the involvement of their associate Vishal alias Vikku, who was subsequently apprehended on April 10, the officer added.

Further questioning led to the identification of Pinky, an associate, and Ravi Soni, a goldsmith who allegedly received the stolen jewellery. Both were later arrested, police said.

The police recovered a substantial portion of the stolen item, including around 70 per cent of gold and diamond jewellery, 80 per cent of silver articles, and ₹8 lakh in cash. Tools used in the crime were also seized, the officer said.

During the investigation, it was found that the accused conducted a recce of residential colonies during the daytime to identify locked houses and carried out burglaries at night. Police said the accused are habitual offenders and were involved in several previous criminal cases. Further investigation is underway.



CM Rekha reviews Phase 4 construction work at RK Ashram Marg

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi chief minister Rekha Gupta inspected the ongoing construction work at RK Ashram Marg Metro Station on Saturday, being developed under Phase 4 of the Delhi Metro project. During the visit, she also reviewed the progress with officials from the Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC).

She directed officials to ensure strict adherence to timelines, high construction quality and uncompromising safety standards.

During the inspection, the Chief Minister said the RK Ashram Marg station is being developed as a key interchange hub that will connect

the operational Blue Line with the Magenta Line.

The station will be a crucial node on the 28.92 km Line-8 corridor extending from Janakpuri West to RK Ashram Marg. Sharing an update on Phase-4 progress, she said stretches between Janakpuri West and Krishna Park Extension and from Deepali Chowk to Majlis Park have already been opened for commuters, while work on the remaining sections is progressing at a rapid pace.

The corridor will pass through densely populated residential and commercial areas across West, North and Central Delhi, significantly reducing travel time, easing traffic congestion and helping bring down



pollution levels.

A major portion of the project falls under the technically complex contract package, which includes the construction of nearly 7 km of twin tunnels and six major underground stations, Derawal Nagar, Ghanta Ghar, Pulbangash, Sadar Bazar,

Nabi Karim and RK Ashram Marg. Praising the engineering effort, the Chief Minister noted that challenging tasks, such as building an underground station in the congested Sadar Bazar area and executing tunnel boring beneath active railway lines near Sabzi Mandi station,

the Rani Jhansi flyover and the Red Line corridor, have been successfully completed.

She added that despite difficult geological conditions, including hard rock strata and waterlogged soil, construction is being carried out using advanced technologies and strict safety protocols, without disrupting surface traffic or existing transport services.

Highlighting the strategic importance of the station, Gupta said RK Ashram Marg will not only function as a major interchange hub but will also serve as a foundation for future expansion of the metro network.

To ease congestion in Central Delhi and strengthen connectivity to key adminis-

trative zones, including Central Vista, the Magenta Line will be extended from RK Ashram Marg to Inderlok via Indraprastha station.

The extension will include a 9.91 km stretch from RK Ashram Marg to Indraprastha and an 11.9 km stretch from Indraprastha to Inderlok. Once all phases are completed, the Magenta Line will run from Botanical Garden to Inderlok, covering around 88.4 km with 65 stations, making it the longest corridor in the Delhi Metro network and fully driverless.

Calling the Delhi Metro the 'lifeline' of the capital, the Chief Minister said millions depend on it daily, making quality, safety and timely completion non-negotiable.



IN FOCUS



People gathering as members of the Agri-Koli community climb and balance on Devkathis, sacred bamboo poles, during the annual Aai Raibadevi Jatra at Rave village in Raigad district, Maharashtra

PTI

₹7 crore cyber heist at Co-operative Bank busted

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Bhavnagar

In a major breakthrough, police have exposed a cyber-fraud of nearly ₹7 crore at the Bhavnagar District Co-operative Bank, arresting four accused involved in hacking the bank's system and syphoning funds from multiple accounts.

The cyber robbery, described as one of the largest in the region, was carried out during the Holi holidays, when the accused allegedly exploited a technical flaw in the bank's Core Banking Solution (CBS).

Investigations revealed that the hackers identified a system "bug" and used it to gain unauthorised access.

According to officials, the accused targeted around 135 accounts, primarily those with smaller balances, to avoid immediate detection. Funds were then discreetly transferred to multiple



accounts in a manner that did not raise suspicion through large transactions. The fraud came to light during a routine audit, triggering alarm within the bank and prompting swift action by authorities.

A specialised team from the Cyber Center of Excellence launched a technical investigation, leading to the identification and arrest of the four suspects. Police officials stated that further investigation is underway to trace the diverted funds and identify any additional links in the cybercrime network. The case has raised serious concerns about cybersecurity vulnerabilities in cooperative banking systems.

SDM Kajal Meena suspended after arrest in Rajasthan corruption case

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Jaipur

The Rajasthan Government on Saturday suspended Sub-Divisional Magistrate (SDM) Kajal Meena following her arrest in a corruption case.

Meena, posted as SDM in Karauli, was arrested by the Anti-Corruption Bureau (ACB) on April 16 after being prima facie found involved in an offence punishable under the Prevention of Corruption Act. The department of personnel issued the suspension



order on Saturday. She was suspended under Rule 13 of the Rajasthan Civil Services (Classification, Control and Appeal) Rules, 1958, from the date of her arrest.

The ACB arrested Meena, her reader and another employee

Gujarat emerges as a model of growth: CM Patel

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Gandhinagar

Gujarat Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel inaugurated the second annual trade expo of the Gujarat Chamber of Commerce and Industry in Gandhinagar, highlighting the state's rise as a national model of development driven by the integration of tradition and modern commerce.

Addressing the gathering, Patel said that under the leadership of Narendra Modi, Gujarat has successfully blended trade with tradition, commerce with culture,



Gujarat CM Bhupendra Patel inaugurates GCCI trade expo in Gandhinagar

CJI Surya Kant pitches for energy justice as moral architecture for India's growth

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Bengaluru

Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant on Saturday emphasised that the only defensible development is one that is environmentally responsible and stressed that India's growth must be aligned with ecological sustainability and the principles of energy justice.

He said that the country must be prepared and equipped to undertake a delicate balancing exercise between "our pursuit of development and our fidelity to a greener future". Addressing the International Conference on Sustainable Energy: An agenda for India @2047, he stressed that India's vision for 2047 must be grounded in justice. "The way I see it, must synchronise economic growth with ecological sensibility. This is because, as a nation, we are still very much on our development journey, and therefore we cannot afford to treat environmental protection and economic progress as a binary choice."

Stressing that energy justice is not an "alien concept" imported from the developed world, the Chief Justice of India said, "It is the moral architecture that allows a rising nation such as ours to grow without compromising what belongs to every citizen: clean air, clean water, and a livable future."

Highlighting the constitutional basis for this balance, the CJI said both development and environmental protection are embedded within Article 21, and "the genius of our constitutional framework lies in its insistence that development and environmental protection must proceed together." He said that he has been emphasising with



Chief Justice of India Justice Surya Kant during the 22nd Biennial State-Level Conference of Judicial Officers on 'Reimagining the Judiciary in the Era of Artificial Intelligence', organised by the Karnataka State Judicial Officers Association in Bengaluru

PTI

increasing conviction that the only defensible development is one that is environmentally responsible. Courts cannot afford to look through a narrow keyhole that treats every project as suspect, but nor can they adopt a complacent approach that treats environmental safeguards as negotiable.

"Our task is to move from a purely reactive model to one that integrates environmental protection into the very design of development — not as an afterthought, but as a foundation," Justice Kant said.

The CJI pointed to the doctrine of continuing mandamus as a key procedural innovation enabling courts to monitor environmental compliance over time, citing the MC Mehta cases as examples of sustained judicial intervention in issues ranging from air pollution and river cleaning to forest and wildlife protection.

ISRO plans G20 satellite launch 2027

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Hyderabad

ISRO Chairman V Narayanan said on Saturday that the G20 satellite, designed to study climate, air pollution and monitor weather, is expected to be launched in 2027.

Addressing scientists from DRDO, ISRO, and the Aeronautical Society of India at the Engineering Staff College of India, Dr Narayanan also said India is the first country to succeed in placing 104 satellites, more than 100 satellites using a single rocket without any collision.

"Right now we are also working on a G20 satellite for G-20 countries, India is taking the lead role, and we



ISRO Chairman V Narayanan

are going to have the launch by the 2027 timeframe," he said.

The ISRO chief further said a lot of commercial missions were carried out, including 433 satellites of 34

countries launched, and the heaviest satellite lifted from India was again a commercial satellite.

Narayanan said ISRO is working towards sending a human to the moon by 2040.

"If we make it happen by 2040, we will be on par with any other space-faring nation in terms of launcher technology, satellite technology, application area, and human space flight program. And we are working towards the Viksit Bharat-2024," he said. According to him, ISRO is in the process of making a 2.2 m diameter with 100 mm thickness titanium vessel for Samudrayaan, a project for the Deep Ocean Mission.

PM to inaugurate Ganga Expressway in Hardoi on April 29

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Lucknow

Prime Minister Narendra Modi will inaugurate the Ganga Expressway in Uttar Pradesh on April 29 in Hardoi district, an official statement announced on Saturday. The 594-km-long expressway, one of the flagship projects of the Yogi Adityanath Government, will connect Meerut to Prayagraj.

According to the statement, the project received cabinet approval in 2020 and was implemented as a priority. The expressway originates from Bijoli village in Meerut and terminates near Judapur Dandu village in Prayagraj, linking western and eastern Uttar Pradesh.

The project is expected to reduce logistics costs, facilitate faster movement of goods and act as an industrial corridor, attracting investments and generating employment opportunities. It is also likely to benefit farmers by enabling quicker transportation of agricultural produce to markets, thereby improving returns.



urban areas. Officials noted that Uttar Pradesh currently accounts for about 55 per cent of the country's expressway network, and with the addition of the Ganga Expressway, the share is projected to rise to nearly 60 per cent.

Separatist Shabir Shah sent to 10-day NIA remand in terror case

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Jammu

Separatist leader Shabir Ahmad Shah was arrested by the NIA in connection with a three-decade-old terror case and remanded in the agency's custody for 10 days by a special court on Saturday, officials said.

Shah was arrested by the Srinagar branch of the National Investigation Agency (NIA) on Friday in the 1996 case involving a terrorist attack on policemen during a militant's funeral, and was produced before the Patiala House Court in Delhi, which allowed a three-day transit remand.

The separatist leader, who was recently released on bail after nearly seven years of imprisonment in other cases, was produced before the special NIA court in Jammu on Saturday, where the agency sought his custodial interrogation, the officials said. After hearing the submissions, the officials said, the court sent him to a 10-day NIA remand, allowing investigators to question him in the 1996 case.

Shah, 72, was granted bail by the Supreme Court in a terror-funding case on March 12 and by a Delhi court in a money laundering case on March 28.



India raises incident of firing on Indian vessels...

authorities in Tehran and to resume, at the earliest, the process of ensuring safe transit for ships headed to India.

The Iranian envoy assured that India's concerns would be communicated to the relevant authorities. The diplomatic move follows reports that Indian-flagged vessels were caught in escalating tensions in the Strait of Hormuz, one of the world's busiest and most sensitive maritime corridors. Government sources indicated that New Delhi has expressed "serious concerns and displeasure" over the incident, seeking clarity on the circumstances under which Iranian forces engaged civilian shipping.

While no injuries or damage have been reported, at least one Indian-flagged vessel was forced to alter its course after coming under fire. Reports suggest that multiple vessels encountered disruptions near a detour point controlled by Iranian forces, with some ships turning back as a precaution.

Out of eight India-flagged or India-bound vessels that approached the strait on Saturday, only one — Desh Garima — was able to complete its passage successfully. The remaining ships were forced to retreat amid heightened tensions.

Authorities said the Directorate General of Shipping is closely monitoring the situation and taking necessary steps to safeguard Indian vessels and crew operating in the region. The Government reiterated that ensuring the safety of Indian seafarers remains its top priority.

Ghaziabad-Sitapur railway expansion...

The construction of these new lines will also provide a boost to the tourism sector as they will improve rail connectivity to several prominent destinations, including the Dudheshwarnath temple, Garhmukteshwar Ghat, Dargah Shah Wilayat Jama Masjid (Amroha), Naimisharanya

(Sitapur), Annavaram, Antarvedi, Draksharamam, etc., the statement said.

The Ghaziabad-Sitapur is an existing double-line section forming a key part of the Delhi-Guwahati high-density network. Talking about the benefits of the line, the Government said the project is crucial for improving connectivity between the northern and eastern regions of the country because the existing line capacity utilisation of the section is at 168 per cent, and is projected to go up to 207 per cent in case the project is not taken up.

The Rajahmundry-Visakhapatnam section forms part of the Howrah-Chennai high-density network, and the proposed project is part of a quadrupling initiative for the route. The Government said the project passes through the East Godavari, Konaseema, Kakinada, Anakapalle, and Visakhapatnam districts of Andhra Pradesh.

"Visakhapatnam is identified as an aspirational district. It provides connectivity to some major ports along the east coast, such as Visakhapatnam, Gangavaram, Machilipatnam and Kakinada," the statement said.

Iran shuts Hormuz again over US blockade

It warned that it would continue to block transit through the strait as long as the US blockade of Iranian ports remained in effect.

Revolutionary Guard gunboats on Saturday opened fire on a tanker transiting the strait and an unknown projectile hit a container vessel, damaging some of the containers, the British military's United Kingdom Maritime Trade Operations center said without identifying the vessels. TankerTrackers.com reported that two Indian-flagged vessels were forced to turn around after being fired on by Iran, including a supertanker carrying Iraqi oil.

The renewed escalation resulted from attempts by both sides to maintain leverage amid negotiations over an ultimate deal to end the war and address Iran's nuclear program.

For the United States, the blockade is a key tool

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to keep up pressure on Iran, short of resuming bombardment. By cutting off much of Iran's exports and imports, it could strangle an already crippled economy.

For Iran, closure of the strait — imposed after the US and Israel launched their surprise war on the country on Feb 28 — has proven to be perhaps its most powerful weapon in the confrontation, causing oil prices to spike, threatening the world economy and inflicting political pain on Trump.

Progress threatens to unravel: On Friday, Iran announced the reopening of the strait to commercial vessels after a 10-day truce was sealed between Israel and the Iranian-backed Hezbollah militant group in Lebanon. The reopening triggered a fall in oil prices. Iran's closure of the strait since has triggered an energy crisis that has roiled the global economy.

US President Donald Trump, however, said that even with the reopening, the American blockade "will remain in full force" until Tehran reaches a deal with the US Trump imposed the blockade, halting all shipping to and from Iranian ports as the ceasefire between Iran and the US was announced last week to keep pressure on Iran to make a deal in Pakistan-brokered talks to end almost seven weeks of war.

His comments triggered immediate outcry from Iranian officials, calling the blockade a violation that would prompt a re-closure of the strait. "Americans are risking the international community, risking the global economy through these, I can say, miscalculations," referring to the blockade, Iranian Deputy Foreign Minister Saeed Khatibzadeh told the Associated Press on Saturday.

"Everybody must understand to what extent American side is risking the whole ceasefire package," he said, speaking after a diplomatic forum in Antalya, Turkey.

Ebrahim Azizi, head of the Iranian parliament's National Security Commission, said that the strait was "returning to the status quo," which he had earlier described as ships requiring Iranian naval authorization and toll payment before transiting. A data firm, Kpler, said movement

through the strait remained confined to corridors requiring Iran's approval.

US forces have sent 21 ships back to Iran since the blockade began on Monday, US Central Command said on X.

Pakistan pushing for progress toward new deal: The renewed standoff over the strait came hours after Pakistani Foreign Minister Ishaq Dar told the forum in Antalya that his country's diplomats were working to "bridge" differences between the US and Iran.

Pakistani officials were fanning out for talks with senior players. Its army chief met senior Iranian officials in Tehran while its prime minister held talks in Antalya with Turkey's president and Qatar's emir. Pakistan is expected to host a second round of negotiations between Iran and the US early next week. (AP)

Allahabad HC restrains FIR order against Rahul...

The development came after the bench, before signing its dictated order, came across a full court verdict mandating that notice be issued to the proposed accused in such matters.

The court noted that none of the counsel raised this legal requirement at the earlier hearing. The bench has posted the matter for April 20. The order was passed on a plea filed by Karnataka-based BJP worker S Vignesh Shishir.

Govt approves maritime insurance pool

The scheme aims to address rising insurance premiums and tighter approvals for shipping cover, which are currently being granted on a case-by-case basis.

This will also ensure that Indian trade continues to have access to affordable insurance for vessels carrying cargo from any international origin to Indian ports and vice versa, even when transiting through volatile maritime corridors. "With increased global volatil-

ity and geopolitical instability, maritime trade has been impacted with increased risk of losses for cargo and vessels, resulting in increased insurance costs and uncertainty in the continuous availability of insurance.

Further, Indian vessels depend heavily on the International Group of Protection and Indemnity (IGP&I) Club for P&I insurance covering third-party liabilities such as oil pollution liability, Wreck removal, Cargo damage, Crew injury and repatriation, Collision liabilities, and so on. Accordingly, there was a need for a domestic maritime risk coverage pool to maintain sovereignty and continuity of trade in the face of withdrawal of coverage due to sanctions or due to geopolitical tensions," the Government said in a statement.

The pool will cover major maritime risks, including hull and machinery, cargo, protection and indemnity (P&I), and war risks. The policies will be issued by pool members, leveraging the Pool's combined underwriting capacity of around ₹950 crore. Coverage will apply to India-flagged vessels, India-controlled ships, and vessels with India as the origin or destination. The proposed framework will run for 10 years, with provision for extension up to 15 years.

Opp shattered women's dreams: PM

delimitation, adopting an "anti-reform" approach, and pursuing "negative politics" that harms the national interest. He said the Congress is following a policy of divide and rule, which he alleged it inherited from the British, and is spreading misinformation that delimitation would adversely impact certain states.

PM Modi said the issue is not limited to a single piece of legislation but part of a broader political contest against what he described as dynastic parties that are anti-reform, adding that the struggle would continue. Modi described opposition parties' intention as committing "foeticide" against the 'Nari Shakti Vandan' Amendment.

Parliament adjourned sine die

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Parliament on Saturday adjourned sine die, drawing curtains on a stormy Budget session that saw the defeat of a crucial bills to implement increase number of Lok Sabha MPs from 543 to 850 and a change in the Delimitation Act. The session, which began on January 28, saw the passage of the Union Budget and Demands for Grants.

As soon as the Lok Sabha met at 11 am, Speaker Om Birla read out his concluding remarks, following which he adjourned the House sine die (for an indefinite period). The session concluded with a rendition of 'Vande Mataram'. In a first, all six stanzas of the national song were played in the House. The Government has mandated singing of all six stanzas of 'Vande Mataram' at official functions, public events and in school assemblies. In the Rajya Sabha, announc-



Members leave after the Lok Sabha was adjourned sine die during the Special session of Parliament in New Delhi on Saturday

PTI

ing a sine die motion, Chairman CP Radhakrishnan said that the House functioned for 157 hours and 40 minutes, achieving a productivity of around 110 per cent during the session. He said that during the special three-day sitting of the House from April 16 to 18, it elected Harivansh as the Deputy Chairman.

Later, Speaker Birla convened a meeting of floor leaders, attended by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Home Minister Amit Shah, and Congress leader

Priyanka Gandhi. Vice President and Rajya Sabha Chairman P Radhakrishnan met several members of Parliament in his office after both the Houses were adjourned sine die. Rajya Sabha Deputy Chairman Harivansh, Leader of the House in the Rajya Sabha JP Nadda, Leader of Opposition in the Rajya Sabha Mallikarjun Kharge, besides Congress Parliamentary Party chairperson Sonia Gandhi, BJP president and MP Nitin Nabin, were present.

Government's conspiracy to change federal structure defeated: Priyanka

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Congress leader Priyanka Gandhi Vadra on Saturday accused the Centre of conspiring to change the federal structure of the country in the garb of women's reservation and asserted that the defeat of the bill to amend the women's quota law in the Lok Sabha was a victory of democracy and Opposition unity.

Addressing a press conference in New Delhi, the Congress general secretary underlined that the Opposition was not against reservation for women and would support the Women's Reservation Act, 2023, if the Government sought to implement it on the current strength of the Lok Sabha.

The sole aim of the Government behind bringing the Constitution amendment bill was to remain in power permanently, Priyanka Gandhi charged, adding that the people of the country could see through its intentions. She claimed that the Government wanted to use the bill for its benefit in the 2029 elections. This was not about the women's reservation but was related to delimitation, she said.

"What happened yesterday was a very significant victory for democracy. The



General Secretary of the All India Congress Committee (AICC) Priyanka Gandhi Vadra, and Jairam Ramesh addressing a press conference at the party's headquarters in New Delhi

PANKAJ KUMAR

Government's conspiracy to alter the federal structure and weaken democracy was defeated and stopped.

"It was a victory for the Constitution, the country and the unity of the Opposition. This was clearly visible on the faces of leaders from the ruling side," the Congress general secretary told reporters at the press conference.

She said it was a "black day" for the Government, which saw a bill defeated in Parliament for the first time, and demanded that it implement the 2023 women's reservation law.

Journalist-turned politician Balbir Punj passes away

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Balbir Punj, a senior leader of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and its former vice president, passed away on Saturday evening.

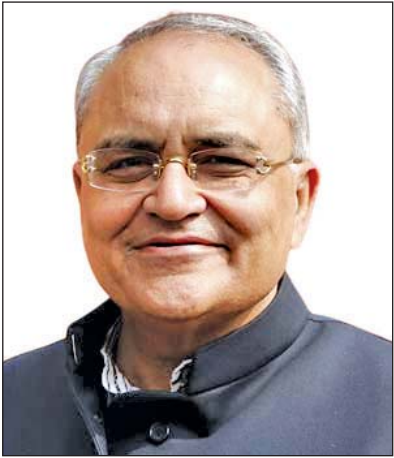
His demise marked the end of a long and influential career in politics, journalism, and public thought.

Punj was a columnist of *The Pioneer* and his articles were regular on every Thursdays including the one which was published on April 16, 2026.

According to family members his cremation will take place on Sunday.

Punj started his career in journalism for the publication Motherland in 1971 went on to work for several publications including Financial Express amongst others.

He later joined BJP and served in



various capacities including Vice President also got elected twice in Rajya Sabha.

Expose Opposition's anti-women mindset: PM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday said the Congress and other parties will have to pay a price for not supporting the bill for the early implementation of the women's reservation and asked Union ministers to expose the opposition's "anti-women" mindset before the people, according to sources.

At a Cabinet meeting, the prime minister reaffirmed his Government's support and commitment to get the women's reservation implemented in the 2029 Lok Sabha elections.

The sources also said that the Prime Minister stated that the opposition has committed a big mistake by not voting in favour of early implementation of the women's quota and will have to



Prime Minister Narendra Modi in the Lok Sabha during the Special session of Parliament in New Delhi on Saturday

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pay a price for not supporting it. Prime Minister Modi is understood to have told his cabinet colleagues to take the message to the grassroots and every village and expose the opposition's "anti-women" mindset.

The sources said Modi told the

ministers to put out messages against the Opposition's stand on their social media handles.

The Constitution amendment bill to implement the women's reservation law failed to garner a two-thirds majority in the Lok Sabha on Friday.

Congress is anti-women: Rijiju slams Opposition

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Union minister Kiren Rijiju on Saturday termed the Congress "anti-women" for "foiling" the efforts to pass the women's reservation bill in Lok Sabha, and said the Government's attempts to give women their rightful place in decision-making will continue.

Addressing a press conference at the conclusion of the Budget session, the parliamentary affairs minister also said that while the Government and the ruling alliance were sad that the women's reservation bill did not get the Lok Sabha's approval, they didn't consider it a failure.

He said the Congress was "celebrating" after "depriv-



Union Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju addressing a press conference after the conclusion of the Budget Session of the Parliament in New Delhi on Saturday

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ing" women of their rights, for which the women of the country will teach them a good lesson.

"It has been established that Congress is anti-women. It will have to face the wrath of the women of the country.

The Opposition considers it a victory after depriving women of their rights. But the women of the country will teach them a good lesson," Rijiju said. The minister also said that the "anti-women mentality" of the Congress

has been exposed, which was a "black spot" for the party. "We are sad, but we don't consider it a failure of the party and the Government. They have hurt the women of the country. We wanted to give honour to women, empower them... We will continue to do so," he said.

Rijiju also said the Government and the ruling alliance tried their best to get the bill passed, but could not do so.

"We can't force the opposition physically to vote in favour of a bill. The votes were cast democratically," he said. The Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill was defeated in the Lok Sabha on Friday night after the Opposition parties voted against it.

Smriti Irani accuses Congress of crushing women's aspirations

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Senior BJP leaders on Saturday launched a scathing attack on the Congress, accusing it of "betraying" women and celebrating the defeat of their political aspirations after a Constitution Amendment Bill to implement reservation for women in legislatures from 2029 and increase the strength of the Lok Sabha was defeated in the Lower House.

Addressing a press conference in New Delhi, former Union minister Smriti Irani accused the Congress and its allies of rejoicing over the denial of 33 per cent reservation to women in legislatures, despite decades of demand by women leaders



BJP leaders Ravi Shankar Prasad and Smriti Irani addressing a press conference at party headquarters in New Delhi on Saturday

PANKAJ KUMAR

across parties.

"The Congress party smiled smugly, thumped desks and celebrated the crushing of the political aspirations of ordinary women. The Congress and its supporting allies celebrated the fact that women who have struggled for years in politics, and who were only demand-

ing 33 per cent reservation in

Parliament, were denied their rights, she alleged. The Constitution Amendment Bill, which sought to operationalise women's reservation and increase the strength of the Lok Sabha, was defeated in the Lower House on Friday after failing to secure the required two-thirds majority.

While 298 members voted

in favour of the bill, 230 voted against it. Out of 528 members who voted, the bill required 352 votes for passage.

She claimed that the Congress, in a recent media briefing, claimed credit for nurturing for nearly 98 years a vision of granting political rights to women. However, she questioned the outcome of that claim, saying the events in the Parliament have exposed the party's intent.

"During the press conference, it was presented as if the party had done a 98-year-long favour to the women of this nation. But what has been the fate of that intention over 98 years? The women of this country saw it on Friday in Parliament," she told reporters.

Ladakh LG Saxena lays foundation stone for India's first Petroglyph Park

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

In a landmark initiative to preserve Ladakh's ancient heritage, the Lieutenant Governor of the Union Territory of Ladakh, Vinai Kumar Saxena, on Saturday laid the foundation stone for India's first Petroglyph Conservation Park, on the banks of the Indus River in Leh, on World Heritage Day.

The Petroglyph Park aims to serve as a dedicated conservation space for centuries-old rock carvings (petroglyphs) that are increasingly under threat due to unregulated tourism, rapid infrastructure development, and a lack of awareness.

The park will house petroglyphs collected from vulnerable and isolated locations across Ladakh, ensuring their preservation for future generations while also making them accessible to visitors in a curated and educational setting.

Notably, Petroglyphs are prehistoric images, symbols, or carvings etched, pecked, or engraved directly onto rock surfaces. On this occasion, a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) was signed between the



Department of Archives, Archaeology and Museums and the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) for the preservation of heritage for future generations through joint intervention.

Officials informed that nearly 400 sites across Ladakh contain petroglyphs, found either in clusters or in isolation. While cluster sites are relatively easier to conserve, isolated petroglyphs — especially those along the banks of the Indus River and Zaskar River — face significant risk of damage due to construction activities and lack of awareness among people.

These endangered arte-

facts will be carefully relocated to the Petroglyph Conservation Park for protection and display. Officials said some of the oldest petroglyphs have inscriptions in Chinese, Arabic, Sanskrit and other ancient languages.

The Lieutenant Governor emphasised that the Petroglyph Conservation Park would serve as a vital step towards preserving the region's ancient art and history for generations to come. He termed Ladakh as a "repository of ancient heritage" and said the region hosts one of the most extensive collections of prehistoric rock art in South and Central Asia.

Nashik Police warn against rumours in TCS harassment case

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi/Mumbai

Nashik City Police has issued a strong advisory amid TCS Nashik harassment and conversion allegations. The police have warned the public against unverified and speculative reports surrounding the ongoing investigation.

This advisory is a direct response to the intense social media buzz, rumours, and unverified claims that have exploded around a high-profile case involving Tata Consultancy Services (TCS) in Nashik.

The police aim to protect the integrity of the probe,



prevent misinformation from influencing public perception, and shield the investigation from external pressure or panic. Such statements are standard when a sensitive case involving corporate India, workplace safety and religious angles gains national traction.

The Nashik Police advisory underscores a critical point. While the allegations are grave and the undercover operation reflects proactive policing, the case remains under active investigation. Speculation on social media risks prejudicing the probe or causing

undue harm. Official channels remain the only reliable source for verified updates.

The case centres on serious allegations of sexual harassment, coercion, rape under false pretences, stalking, outraging modesty, and attempts at forcible religious conversion at TCS's BPO unit in Nashik with a 147-employee facility. It first surfaced in the last week of March, following a complaint from the family of a young Hindu woman, an employee who allegedly began adopting Islamic practices, such as observing Ramzan fasts due to workplace influence.

Nine FIRs have been registered across two police sta-

tions. Charges include rape, sexual harassment, mental coercion, hurting religious sentiments and deliberate acts to outrage religious feelings. One FIR also invokes the SC/ST (Prevention of Atrocities) Act. Police have described some accused male employees as operating like an organised gang targeting colleagues.

Nashik Police had launched a discreet probe and conducted a month-long undercover operation (roughly mid-February to early April 2026). Six to seven women police officers were posed as housekeeping/cleaning staff inside the office.

Sultan Palace: Demolition fears grow over non-heritage tag

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Patna/New Delhi

On September 10, 2024, the Bihar Cabinet approved a proposal to build a five-star heritage hotel under a PPP model at the site of the iconic Sultan Palace in the heart of Patna, while preserving its over a century-old historic structure.

A top official of the State Government announced this decision the same day in a media briefing following the



Cabinet meeting, a move that was welcomed by heritage lovers and resi-

dents of Patna. While not much progress has been made on this long-stalled

project, first made public by the State Government authorities in early 2017, and whose fruition would have made it Bihar's first heritage hotel, a "committee" headed by secretary of the art and culture department of the State Government, then led by Nitish Kumar, was established "about five months ago" in connection with it.

However, a report published in a leading Hindi daily in Patna on April 16,

days before World Heritage Day (April 18), has claimed that the panel has "found" that the Sultan Palace — built in 1922 by legendary barrister Sir Sultan Ahmed as his residence — is "not listed as a heritage building".

The report, which has triggered outrage among heritage lovers, has also conjectured that the famed place might have to "face the wrecking ball" to make way for the five-star hotel project.



States Focus



MANIPUR LAW & ORDER SENSITIVE BUT UNDER CONTROL, SAYS CM

Manipur CM Y Khemchand Singh on Saturday said that law and order in the State remains sensitive but under control. Singh made the remarks after he held a meeting with the Assam Rifles IGAR (South) at the State secretariat. “The briefing by IGAR (South) Major General Gaurav Sharma at the secretariat on Saturday reaffirmed that the law and order situation in the State is sensitive but under control, with security forces responding to all disturbances with utmost care and restraint,” the chief minister said in a Facebook post. He urged all citizens to remain cautious against rumours and misinformation that may incite unrest. A series of protests and clashes with security forces were reported in five Imphal valley districts after the April 7 bomb attack at Tronglaobi in Bishnupur, in which two children were killed.



CM FADNAVIS REVIEWS NASHIK TCS, ASHOK KHARAT CASE

Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis on Saturday reviewed key cases with the Home department and directed the police to ensure thorough investigation and strong prosecution, officials said. At a high-level meeting attended by the Director General of Police, Additional Chief Secretary (Home), SIT chief and other senior officers, the CM took stock of probes into cases pertaining to the Nashik unit of TCS, self-styled godman Ashok Kharat, sexual exploitation of minors and women in Amravati as well as the drug overdose deaths at a concert in Goregaon in Mumbai, they added.

DMK’s policy is by the family, for the family, alleges PM Modi

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Coimbatore (Tamil Nadu)

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday targeted Tamil Nadu’s ruling DMK by alleging that its policy is “by the family, for the family,” and claimed that a competition was on within the family to loot.

Addressing an election rally of the NDA in Coimbatore, Modi said that over the past five years, two things have increased to record levels in Tamil Nadu, and the first is one family’s wealth and the second is Tamil Nadu’s debt.

The DMK’s top family is becoming richer and richer while the debt on each person in Tamil Nadu is increasing more and more.

The DMK’s policy is “by the family, of the family, and for the family.” The chief minis-



Prime Minister Narendra Modi addressing a public meeting ahead of the Tamil Nadu Assembly elections in Coimbatore

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ter, deputy CM and a prominent MP in Delhi all belong to the same family. Even the film industry, media houses, and so on are controlled by one family. Even senior leaders of DMK have to bend before juniors of a family.

“Whenever I meet people from Tamil Nadu, they tell me that there is a big competition in the family here. The competition is between the

son and the son-in-law. They are competing on who will loot more,” he alleged.

Tamil Nadu needs vision in governance, not son or son-in-law loot. On a connected note, he said the DMK and its ally in Delhi have one thing in common. In both, the son-in-law has done “wonders.” And India is fed up with one son-in-law, and Tamil Nadu is fed up with another son-in-

law, and people are concerned about the corruption of these two families.

Look at the contrast between the BJP and the NDA. CP Radhakrishnan from the Coimbatore region had no political background, and he grew through honesty and hard work. When Radhakrishnan was in the Coir Board, he took exports to record levels, and today, he serves as our Vice President.

Underscoring that Tamil Nadu is an important growth engine, PM Modi underlined the Centre’s contribution to Tamil Nadu’s growth.

“In the last eleven years, the Centre has provided more than ₹14 lakh crore to Tamil Nadu through tax devolution, infrastructure (including highways, airport and railways) and welfare schemes,” he said.

Remove Mamata or infiltrators will snatch Bengal: Himanta

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Saturday accused the Mamata Banerjee Government in West Bengal of diverting the State’s resources for “Bangladeshi Muslim infiltrators”, and said she has to be removed from power “else we will lose Bengal”.

Addressing a rally in Kalimpong, the BJP leader claimed that his party’s Governments in Assam and Tripura have prevented the entry of “Bangladeshi Muslims” into India, while infiltration of illegal immigrants continues in Bengal.

“Mamata Banerjee has earmarked the entire treasury of Bengal for Bangladeshi Muslim infiltrators. She sold this land to Bangladeshi Muslims for votes,” he alleged.

Alleging the TMC supremo has destroyed the entire Bengal since she became the chief minister, Sarma said,



“We have to remove Mamata Banerjee as Bengal CM, else one day Bangladeshi Muslims will take away the State from us.”

The BJP leader claimed that there has been no development in north Bengal under her tenure and pitched for a change in Government while promising

that “once the BJP forms a Government in Bengal, we will kick out all Bangladeshi infiltrators from this region.”

He also said the BJP would seek a constitutional solution to the Gorkhaland issue and “ensure justice for Gorkhas” if voted to power.

Speaking at another rally in Cooch Behar district’s Dinhat, Sarma referred to the Trinamool Congress lodging a complaint against him with the Election Commission, accusing him of making “communally charged, inciteful and divisive” remarks against the Bengal chief minister. He said that such a move by the TMC would not scare him.

The BJP leader also referred to former TMC MLA and Aam Janata Unnayan Party (AJUP) founder Humayun Kabir’s attempt to build a Babri Masjid in Bengal, and said that had there been such an attempt in Assam, he would have taken strict measures and put the person behind bars.

CM Yogi holds grand roadshow in West Bengal, slams TMC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bankura (WB)

The streets of Bankura witnessed a massive surge of saffron on Saturday as Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath, popularly known as ‘Bulldozer Baba’, held a high-decibel roadshow in support of BJP candidate and sitting ML A Niladri Shekhar Dana.

Amidst deafening chants of ‘Jai Shri Ram’ and ‘Sher Aya, Sher Aya’ (The lion has arrived), Yogi Adityanath traversed the town, greeted by thousands of people who



UP CM Yogi Adityanath greeting the gathering during an election campaign, ahead of the West Bengal Assembly elections in the Cooch Behar district

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lined the roads and crowded rooftops to catch a glimpse of the firebrand leader.

Expressing his gratitude for the rapturous reception, the Chief Minister took a sharp dig at the ruling

Trinamool Congress (TMC). “The enthusiasm across the State indicates that the BJP’s lotus will bloom on May 4. We want an ‘Amar Sonar Bangla’ that is TMC-free,” he asserted.

Voting for any party other than TMC is a vote for BJP: Abhishek

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Murshidabad

“One vote for any party other than the TMC is a vote for the BJP,” Trinamool Congress leader Abhishek Banerjee said at a poll rally on Saturday in a bid to consolidate votes in this district, which historically has been a strong base of the Congress.

Addressing a gathering after a roadshow in Farakka, he claimed that while the BJP was “breaking the Congress”, the TMC was “thwarting the BJP’s influence on the ground.”

Targeting the Congress, the de facto number two in the TMC claimed that no MP or any representative of the



grand old party stood by the people in the past two years to address their demands.

Banerjee claimed that the Congress, Aam Janata Unnayan Party founder Humayun Kabir and central agencies were the “three agencies of the BJP” that

were active in the region. While attempts were being made to delete the names of the poor and minority voters from the electoral rolls, the Opposition parties were “playing with the emotions of the community”, the TMC leader said. “I urge people — Hindus, Muslims, Sikhs and Christians — not to be misled. Those trying to divide you must be given a befitting reply on polling day. If you want to defeat the BJP, the only way is to vote for the TMC,” he said.

About the BJP-led NDA failing to pass the Constitution amendment bill to give women quota in 2029 in Parliament, he alleged the Centre was trying to bring in

the delimitation exercise “to divide our country.”

“We will not allow any change to the Constitution by force,” he said.

Claiming that “lakhs of minorities as well as Hindus were sent to detention camps in Assam through the NRC exercise”, Banerjee said, “We had said in 2020 that NRC would not be allowed in Bengal, and we have stood by that. As long as Mamata Banerjee is here, people will not be forced to prove citizenship by standing in lines.”

Raising the issue of riverine erosion, he said, “The chief minister has written to the Centre to declare Ganga erosion a national disaster, but no steps have been taken.”

TMC Govt living fossil, existing on borrowed time: Bengal BJP chief Samik Bhattacharya

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kolkata

The BJP’s West Bengal unit chief Samik Bhattacharya on Saturday threw a “living fossil” barb at the Trinamool Congress Government in the State, asserting that it was on “borrowed time” and has been virtually rejected by people.

Alleging the TMC regime has crushed democracy while law and order has collapsed, he claimed that political violence reached alarming heights in the past few years, while police looked the other way.



West Bengal BJP President Samik Bhattacharya addressing a press conference ahead of the State Assembly elections in Kolkata on Saturday

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“People of the State want restoration of democracy. There has been a total absence of law and order in

West Bengal, where 253 BJP office-bearers were killed by the TMC after the 2021 elections.

“Hundreds of women were raped and tortured. Democracy came under attack as TMC’s goons were involved in mayhem,” he said. Reminding the gathering that in 2011, Mamata Banerjee ended the 34-year-old Left Front reign with the slogan ‘Restoring Democracy’.

“Soon after, her party appropriated the CPI(M)’s goondaim and muscle power, and unleashed a reign of terror for the next two terms. She tried to intimidate people and opposition parties so that no one could stand up to them.”

Debabrata Saikia alleges lapses in strongroom security post Assam polls

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Guwahati

Leader of Opposition in the outgoing Assam Assembly, Debabrata Saikia, on Saturday, alleged security lapses in the strongroom where election materials of three constituencies — Demow, Sivasagar and Nazira — are stored.

Saikia, in a letter to Election Observer Narasimhaguri T L Reddy, said that security arrangements currently in place at Room Nos 12 and 15



of Sivasagar Government Boys HS and MP School constitute “direct violations” of core guidelines mandated by the Election Commission of India (ECI).

Elections to the State’s 126 Assembly constituencies were held on April 9, and the counting will take place on

May 4. The “photographic evidence”, which Saikia attached along with the letter, shows that two doors of the rooms are secured by only a single padlock on one side, which has been sealed, while the other door appears to be merely shut from the inside, he alleged.

“This physical State is in direct and alarming contravention of the ECI’s strict directives designed to prevent unilateral or unauthorised access to sensitive election materials,” Saikia said.

Court sentences 10 CPI(M) cadres to 25 years in bomb attack case

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kannur (Kerala)

A sessions court in Kannur on Saturday sentenced 10 CPI(M) cadres for varying jail terms under different sections for a total of 25 years for attempting to murder RSS-BJP workers by throwing a bomb at their vehicle back in November 2011.

Taliparamba Additional District and Sessions Judge Prasanth KN sentenced the 10 to varying jail terms under various provisions of the IPC and the Explosives Act, public prosecutor U Rameshan said.



The court directed that the second accused, TV Binu, also known as Urumban

Binu, will have to serve the sentences consecutively, as he was the one who threw

the bomb, and therefore, he will remain in jail for 25 years, the prosecutor said.

The remaining nine accused - MK Pradeepkumar, PP Sathyan, PV Baburaj - a CPI(M) panchayat member, EV Vinod Kumar, Vijayan, KP Suresh, Toby, Janardhanan KV and Sivaprakash — will have to serve only 10 years, the highest of the varying punishments, as their sentences will run concurrently, the prosecutor said.

A fine of ₹2.6 lakh was imposed on each of the convicts by the court, the prosecutor added.

The incident occurred on November 27, 2011, when a bomb was thrown at the vehicle carrying RSS-BJP workers near Thimiri College here, the prosecutor said.

The bomb was thrown following heated arguments over the opening of an RSS branch in the area, he said, adding that a clash had taken place in the area between the two sides a day before the incident. According to the prosecution, there were 30 workers in the vehicle, and nine of them were seriously injured in the attack.

PROSPECT



BJP leader Vinay Sahasrabudhe attending celebrations of birth anniversary of former Prime Minister Chandrasekhar on Friday. The program was organised by Gyani Sandip Singh Head Granthi Gurudwara Mata Sundri Delhi. Gurbani Path Jap Sahib, Anand Sahib & Sukhmani Sahib done by Bhai Sarwan Singh and Bhai Shaam Singh Granthi Gurdwara mata Sundari. Kirtan is done by Bhai Gurnam Singh Hazoori Ragi Gurdwara Bangla Sahib. Most renowned Ragi in the USA, Austria and Norway followed by Ardaas and Hukumnama by Gyani Sandeep Singh. After the program unlimited Guru ka langar was served to Sangat.

Young innovators shine at VIT-AP’s V-Launch Pad event



With the aim of promoting innovation and start up culture, V-Launch Pad 2026 was organised with great grandeur at VIT-AP University. The event, jointly organized by the VIT-AP School of Business and the Innovation, Incubation and Entrepreneurship Cell (IIEC), served as a platform for students, faculty, and industry leaders. The guests inaugurated stalls showcasing creative and innovative projects set up at the Student Activity Center. The guests for the event–Rajeev Sharma (CEO, AgVysor Innovations LLP), Sandal Kotawala (CEO, Alfaleus Technology Pvt. Ltd.), and Krishnan G (CEO, Ratan Tata Innovation Hub, Vijayawada)– Chandrasekhar Kupperi –Founder of ANOVA Corporate services addressed the students. In their speeches, they emphasised the importance of entrepreneurial thinking focused on problem-solving. They expressed that research should not remain limited to papers but should evolve into commercially viable products. They also praised the role of innovation hubs and incubation centers in the growth of start-ups.

Vice-Chancellor Dr P Arulmozhi Varman stated that the university is moving forward with the goal of “One Student, One Innovation.” He noted that the competition received 620 registrations from 42 prestigious institutions across the country, including IITs, IIMs, and NTIs, and that 51 shortlisted teams presented their innovative prototypes in the final round.

Registrar Dr Jagadish Chandra Mudiganti highlighted that higher education institutions have a significant responsibility in building a strong start up ecosystem in the country and described V-Launch Pad as an excellent platform for young innovators.

World Parkinson’s Day sees new treatment options

Gurugram celebrated World Parkinson’s Day by launching a specialised centre for functional neurosurgery and a unique movement-based dance therapy programme for Parkinson’s patients.

Dr Praveen Gupta, Chairman, Marengo Asia Hospitals, said, “Parkinson’s disease is often diagnosed late in India. With strong scientific evidence supporting Deep Brain Stimulation (DBS), there has been a paradigm shift in managing advanced Parkinson’s disease.”

Dr Himanshu Champaneri said, “Most of the people are scared when it comes to brain surgeries. However, significant progress has been made.”

According to Harpreet Singh, goal is to educate people about neurological disorders and make state-of-the-art treatment methods available in their localities.



From rights to duties: Path to Viksit Bharat drawn

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The role of citizens as active participants in nation-building took centre stage at the latest session of Mantrana, the flagship discussion series by Bharat Ki Soch. Centred on the theme “Duties of a Citizen for a Viksit Bharat,” the session on April 16, 2026 brought together thought leaders, policymakers, diplomats and engaged participants to deliberate on the duties of citizenry that must underpin India’s developmental aspirations.

The panel, comprising Justice Arjan Kumar Sikri, Former Judge, Supreme Court of India; Meenakshi Lekhi, Former Minister of State for External Affairs of India; Anil Rajput, Chairman, Bharat Ki Soch; RK Pachnanda, Director, Bharat Ki Soch; and Raghvendra Singh, Advisor, Bharat Ki Soch shared their insights on the relevance of public responsibility in today’s evolving national and global landscape.

India’s oldest national daily since 1865, *The Pioneer*, is the media partner of the Bharat



Justice Arjan Kumar Sikri, former Union minister Meenakshi Lekhi, Chairman, Bharat Ki Soch Anil Rajput; Director, Bharat Ki Soch R K Pachnanda and Advisor, Bharat Ki Soch Raghvendra Singh at the Bharat Ki Soch Mantrana held in the national Capital last week

Ki Soch, a think tank dedicated to fostering indigenous perspectives on governance, economy and commerce, health and wellbeing, agriculture and food security, environment and sustainability, and national security.

Drawing upon decades of judicial experience, Justice Sikri highlighted the evolution and inclusion of fundamental duties within the

Indian Constitution. “In India’s ancient civilisational context, there existed a deeply ingrained sense of duty, where societal behaviour was guided by established norms and a collective responsibility towards the larger good. Over time, this alignment between societal conduct and collective responsibility has eroded. The idea of fundamental

duties reinforces that democracy cannot function through rights alone. It requires citizens who are conscious of their obligations towards the nation, society, environment and future generations. These duties are not merely a constitutional provision, but a reminder that nation-building depends on an aware, responsible and enlightened citizenry committed to the common good. In today’s uncertain and volatile environment, India, drawing from its civilisational values, also has the potential to play a larger role in shaping and stabilising the global order,” Justice Sikri said.

Building on this and her experience across law, public policy and diplomacy, Meenakshi Lekhi contextualised fundamental duties through the lens of the Constitution’s preamble, emphasising their integral relationship with rights and their relevance to India’s 2047 vision of Viksit Bharat.

“The preamble defines the goals of justice, liberty, equality and fraternity, and fundamental rights and duties are two sides of the same coin in

achieving these principles. One person’s right is another person’s duty. While rights are enforceable against the state, duties ensure that the same system is sustained by citizens.

For instance, while the right to education guarantees access to schooling, it is equally the responsibility of parents to ensure that children are sent to schools. A nation cannot progress if its citizens weaken the very systems they are part of, and the journey towards Viksit Bharat requires all stakeholders to move in the same direction with a shared sense of purpose,” she said.

In his address, Anil Rajput highlighted that the idea of citizen responsibility is deeply rooted in India’s scriptures and must be central to how India envisions its future. “A Viksit Bharat is not merely an economic milestone, but a collective expression of responsible citizenship. Development is not only engineered through policy, but co-created by citizens through their everyday actions. Our civilisational texts have long emphasised

duty as a foundational principle, and development must be understood as a collective effort where citizens play an active role. What is required is a cultural awakening of responsibilities, where the mindset shifts from ‘what do I get’ to ‘what can I give,’ he said.

RK Pachnanda, Director, Bharat Ki Soch, emphasised that the vision of a Viksit Bharat requires the foundational element of the Praja Dharma. Dharma demands a Praja (citizenry) that is vigilant against the divisive allure of misinformation and unwavering in upholding Indian unity and integrity. It calls for a shift from a mindset of entitlement – constantly asking what the nation can provide – to a mindset of contribution – asking what we can bring to the national table.

Raghvendra Singh moderated a discussion, including an interactive session with the audience, exploring diverse perspectives on civic responsibility, governance, and social cohesion to be brought into the conversation.

Sesame, Abbott launch Sehatmand Aadatein on Chalo App for kids’ nutrition



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Sesame Workshop India, in partnership with global healthcare major Abbott, on Saturday unveiled Sehatmand Aadatein – on the popular Chalo! Sesame Street app, bringing play-based nutrition education to children’s fingertips. Developed under the Healthy Habits programme—launched earlier this year with Abbott’s funding—the digital module targets children aged 4-7, helping families instill routines around balanced diets, physical activity, and sleep through interactive storytelling, music, and familiar Sesame Street characters.

The content offers over 40 minutes of engaging videos paired with 55 gamified assessments, transforming passive screen time into active learning. Designed for everyday use, it encourages small, sustainable steps towards lifelong well-being, extending on-ground efforts at Anganwadi centres to homes via Hindi-language resources.

The launch taps into the Chalo! Sesame Street app’s growing footprint, with nearly 1.58 lakh installs since inception. A pedagogically robust platform aligned with the NIPUN Bharat Mission, it fosters foundational literacy,

numeracy, social-emotional skills, and life habits through YouTube-wrapped videos, progress trackers, and WhatsApp sharing for teachers and parents.

Features like screen-time timers promote mindful media use, addressing concerns over packaged foods and excessive gadget time. “Today, many children are eating more packaged and sugary foods and spending more time in front of the screen,” said Sonali Khan, Managing Trustee, Sesame Workshop India Trust. “With Sehatmand Aadatein, we make it easier for children and caregivers to learn and practice healthy habits like good nutrition, regular physical activity, and proper sleep in a fun way.”

Building on community outreach, the app bridges mass media reach with measurable outcomes, supporting holistic growth. Sesame Workshop India combines on-ground interventions with digital tools to equip children to grow “smarter, stronger, and kinder,” reinforcing behaviours for physical and emotional health.

Abbott’s support underscores a commitment to early intervention, making trusted content accessible beyond classrooms.

Indian Army conducts Jal Rahat: Flood relief joint exercise

TONY DAS
■ Guwahati

The Red Horns Division of Gajraj Corps on behalf of Indian Army conducted a Joint Flood Relief Exercise, Exercise Jal Rahat at IIT, Guwahati demonstrating inter agency coordination and disaster preparedness by flood relief columns of Army, NDRF, SDRF & SSB.

The exercise showcased modalities of conduct of flood relief operations, role of various agencies, use of high end technology and innovative means for conduct of rescue operations during floods.

Exercise JAL RAHAT was conceptualised and designed with an aim to enhance response capability in the event of severe flooding.

A specialist team from Indian Army, supported by other State Agencies depicted rescue missions incorporating and simulating actual scenarios, employment of drones for surveillance and



logistic outreach of stranded villagers and evacuation of drowning individuals.

Apart from this specialist teams of Army, NDRF & SDRF showcased their skills in deep water rescue operations. It effectively exercised all stakeholders in conduct of relief operations in an effectively synchronised manner showcasing inter agency synergy and interoperability at challenging times of natural calamities.

The exercise was witnessed by General Officer Commanding, Gajraj Corps, senior officials from Army,

State Administration, SSB, CAPFs and disaster relief organisations and approximately 800 audience to include flood relief columns of Indian Army, cadets from NCC and NSS and students from various schools and colleges of Guwahati. The operational readiness state of flood relief columns was overseen by Lt Gen Neeraj Shukla, AVSM, SM**, General Officer Commanding of Gajraj Corps.

He also addressed the august gathering and exhorted all ranks of Army, SSB, NDRF, SDRF and NCC Cadets

AIAI, WTC Mumbai welcome reopening of Strait of Hormuz

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The All India Association of Industries and World Trade Center Mumbai, in a significant and welcome development for global trade and energy security, welcome the recent announcement by the Iranian Ports and Maritime Organisation regarding the reopening of the Strait of Hormuz for commercial navigation during the ongoing ceasefire period.

Dr Vijay Kalantri, President, All India Association of Industries (AIAI) and Chairman, World Trade Center Mumbai, said, “We welcome the recent announcement by the Iranian Ports and Maritime Organization regarding the reopening of the Strait of Hormuz for commercial navigation during the ongoing ceasefire period.

This timely and constructive development is a positive step towards restoring confidence in global maritime trade and ensuring the smooth flow of critical energy



Dr Vijay Kalantri, President, All India Association of Industries and Chairman, World Trade Center Mumbai

supplies. It highlights the value of sustained dialogue, prudent coordination, and mutual restraint in addressing complex regional challenges.

He further added, “The resumption of commercial navigation through this vital waterway is expected to significantly ease pressures on the global energy market, offering much-needed relief to trade and industry, while also benefiting consumers worldwide. It is likely to contribute to moderating prevailing inflationary trends and enhancing overall economic stability.

BHEL registers strong revenue growth in FY 2025–26

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Bharat Heavy Electricals Limited (BHEL), India’s foremost engineering and manufacturing enterprise in the power and infrastructure sector, has registered a turnover of around ₹32,350 crore (provisional and unaudited) for FY 2025–26, marking a growth of 18 per cent over the previous year.

The company secured total order inflows of around ₹75,000 crore during the year. With this, BHEL’s total outstanding order book at the end of FY 2025–26 stands at around ₹2.4 lakh crore. Key highlights of the year include:

- In the power sector, BHEL continued to maintain a strong market position with significant order wins of around ₹59,000 crore during the year.

- The industrial segment recorded fresh orders of around ₹16,000 crore across



diverse sectors such as transportation, transmission, defence, process industries, and industrial equipment, reflecting the company’s broad-based presence.

- On the execution front, BHEL commissioned/synchronised around 8.9 GW of power capacity, demonstrating its continued focus on project delivery and operational efficiency. With healthy revenue growth, a strong order book, and a sustained execution pipeline, BHEL enters FY 2026–27 with solid momentum. The company remains committed to delivering high-impact infrastructure, driving industrialisation, and enhancing stakeholder value.

Postcard released on People of India at PMML

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Department of Posts, Ministry of Communication in collaboration with Pradhanmantri Sangrahalaya, PMML have released a new postcard on “People of India”, on Saturday.

This unique event is in continuation of the recently launched Philatelic Exhibition “Ek Bharat, Shresth Bharat: Celebrating India’s Unity and Democracy through Postage Stamps” from 14 April to 17



April at the Sangrahalaya premises.

Ashwani Lohani, Director, PMML has graced the occasion in presence of Priyanka

Mishra, CEO, Pradhanmantri Sangrahalaya and officials from the Postal department. Speaking on this occasion, Director, PMML, said “Pradhan

Mantri Sangrahalaya is actively organising events through which people can better relate to the apex leadership of the nation and appreciate the deep roots of democracy in the country. This release of picture postcards on the people of India is a step in this direction”.

The exhibition features sections like Tribal Resistance, Women of Freedom, Festivals of India, and The People of India, and remains open to the public at Teen Murti Bhawan.

COUNCIL OF ARCHITECTURE
A Statutory Authority of Government of India
India Habitat Centre, Core 6A, 1st Floor, Lodhi Road, New Delhi – 110003
Ref. No.CA/28/2026/PGETA
PGETA 2026
ANNOUNCEMENT OF CONDUCT OF
POST GRADUATE ENTRANCE TEST IN ARCHITECTURE (PGETA 2026)
All candidates, institutions, authorities and other stakeholders are hereby informed that the Council of Architecture shall be conducting Postgraduate Entrance Test in Architecture (PGETA-2026) at national level for admission to 2-year Postgraduate programmes being imparted at the architectural Institutions, approved by the Council for the academic session 2026-2027, in terms of Council of Architecture (Minimum Standards of Architectural Education for Postgraduate Degree Programme) Guidelines, 2022.
PGETA-2026 shall be conducted thrice during the year 2026 on May 31, June 14 and June 28, 2026 respectively. The PGETA 2026 brochure containing relevant details of the Test and the eligibility criteria for admission to Post Graduate Programme is available at www.pgeta.in. A list of institutions imparting Postgraduate programmes in Architecture duly approved by the Council in the country is available at the website of the Council - www.coa.gov.in.
The candidates desirous to take admission into Postgraduate Programmes in Architecture are advised to register themselves for PGETA-2026 at www.pgeta.in. The registration for PGETA-2026 shall commence from April 21, 2026.
The Council is also pleased to announce Scholarships for Top 100 qualified candidates in PGETA-2026, taking admission into PG Programmes at COA approved Architectural Institutions.
New Delhi
Registrar

कार्यालय नगर निगम, देहरादून
(ई-निविदा सूचना)
पत्रांक-457 दिनांक 18 अप्रैल, 2026
नगर निगम, देहरादून में वित्तीय वर्ष 2026-27 हेतु स्वास्थ्य स्टर के प्रयोग आने वाली सफाई उपकरण आपूर्ति करने हेतु निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है तथा निविदा से सम्बन्धित समस्त विवरण ई-निविदा पोर्टल www.uktenders.gov.in से प्राप्त किये जा सकते हैं।
कार्य का विवरण निविदा शुल्क (18% जीएसटी सहित) घरोहर राशि निक्षेप निविदा डाले जाने की तिथि निविदा खोलने की तिथि एवं समय
सफाई उपकरण क्रय किये जाने हेतु। 5000 /- 2,00,000 /- 20.04.2026 से 03.05.2026 अपराह्न 05:00 बजे 04.05.2026 को पूर्वाह्न 11:00 बजे
नगर आयुक्त नगर निगम, देहरादून

Rangli Baisakhi 3.0 – Celebrating Punjabi spirit

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

New Delhi is all set to once again immerse itself in the vibrant colors, rich culture, and festive spirit of Baisakhi. “Rangli Baisakhi,” which began in 2024 and quickly became one of the city’s most loved cultural celebrations, is now returning with its third edition - Rangli Baisakhi 3.0, bigger, grander, and more energetic.

The event will be organised on 26th April at Sri Guru Gobind Singh College of Commerce, New Delhi, from 11.00 am to 8.00 pm. Rangli Baisakhi 3.0 will showcase the true essence of Punjabi culture. The biggest attraction of the event will be the “Bhangra King and Giddha Queen” competition.



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FROM THE WORLD

INDIA

Indian group wins 2 awards

Two public outreach initiatives of US-based advocacy group Hindu American Foundation have won awards of excellence from an association of communication professionals working for faith-based organisations. The Hindu American Foundation's (HAF) fundraising campaign video "Back to the (Hindu) Future" and podcast "All about Hinduism Series 2" were presented with a 2026 DeRose-Hinkhouse Award of Excellence by the Religion Communicators Council. The "Back to the (Hindu) Future" was produced by the HAF marketing team. It was filmed and edited by Todd Lewis. "...we're thrilled that the Religion Communicators Council has recognised the creativity and quality of this fundraising campaign, which has succeeded in both that primary goal.

PAKISTAN

Gunmen kill polio worker

Unidentified gunmen killed a polio worker on the outskirts of Peshawar, the capital of Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province in northwest Pakistan, police said on Saturday. The incident occurred in Urmar village of Peshawar suburb on Friday during an ongoing polio eradication campaign when the assailants targeted the polio worker. The deceased polio worker, identified as 35-year-old Shoaib Ali, died on the spot in the attack, police said, adding, the attackers managed to flee the scene. An FIR regarding the incident has been lodged at the Urmar police station. Earlier on Wednesday, suspected militants abducted three polio workers in the Bannu district of the province. On Monday, a police constable was killed, and four others were injured when militants fired at a security contingent deployed to protect a polio vaccination team in the Hangu district of the province.

French soldier killed, three injured in Lebanon: Macron

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Paris

French President Emmanuel Macron said a French soldier was killed and three others injured on Saturday morning during an attack on UN peacekeepers in southern Lebanon.

Macron identified the soldier as Staff Sergeant Florian Montorio of the 17th Parachute Engineer Regiment from Montauban.

"Everything suggests that responsibility for this attack lies with Hezbollah," Macron wrote on social media. "France demands that the Lebanese authorities immediately arrest

Iranian navy prepared to defeat enemies: Mojtaba

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Cairo

Iran's "valiant navy" is "ready to inflict new bitter defeats on its enemies," Iran's Supreme Leader Ayatollah Mojtaba Khamenei said. Iran's supreme leader sent the defiant message on Saturday as Iran swiftly reimposed restrictions on the Strait of Hormuz.

In a message celebrating the anniversary of the establishment of Iran's army, he hailed Iran's drone strikes that targeted Israel and the US interests across the region during the war.

Iranian Deputy Foreign Minister Saeed Khatibzadeh dismissed claims from U.S. President Donald Trump over the uranium and

sounded a note of caution with regard to future talks between the two countries.

Speaking to *the Associated Press* in the Turkish city of Antalya, Khatibzadeh said the Iranians were not ready for a new round of face-to-face talks with the US because the Americans "have not abandoned their maximalist position."

On Friday, Trump said the US will go into Iran and "get all the nuclear dust," referring to the 970 pounds (440 kilograms) of enriched uranium believed to be buried under nuclear sites badly damaged by US military strikes last year.

Iran has announced a partial reopening of its



A man riding a scooter past the rubble of buildings destroyed in Israeli airstrikes in Jibchit, southern Lebanon

airspace after a seven-week hiatus because of the war, state media reported.

The Civil Aviation Organization said air routes over eastern Iran were reopened at 7 am (0330 GMT), according to the state-owned IRAN newspaper. It said flights at the country's airports would gradually resume but did not give a timeframe. Iran's airspace had been closed since the US and Israel began striking Iran on February 28.

Munir concludes three-day Iran visit

Pakistan's Chief of Defence Forces Field Marshal Syed Asim Munir has concluded his three-day visit to Iran as part of Islamabad's efforts to

resolve the conflict between the US and Iran.

Munir, who was heading a high-level delegation to Iran, landed in Tehran on Wednesday, becoming the first foreign military leader to visit the country since a two-week ceasefire was agreed between Iran and the US on April 8.

During the visit, Munir held discussions with Iran President Masoud Pezeshkian and also met with Parliament Speaker Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf and Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi, the military's media wing said on Saturday. He also met the Commander of Khatam ul Anbiya Headquarters Major General Ali Abdollahi.

Iran refuses to hand over enriched uranium

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Cairo

Iranian Deputy Foreign Minister Saeed Khatibzadeh dismissed claims from US President Donald Trump over the uranium and sounded a note of caution with regard to future talks between the two countries.

Speaking to the Associated Press in the Turkish city of Antalya, Khatibzadeh said the Iranians were not ready for a new round of face-to-face talks with the US because the Americans "have not abandoned their maximalist position."

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uranium believed to be buried under nuclear sites badly damaged by US military strikes last year.

US-Iran negotiations will take time to conclude: VC Yilmaz

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Cairo

Turkish Vice President Cevdet Yilmaz, whose country has been supporting Pakistan's efforts to bring the sides together, told The Associated Press there are many "complex issues" on the table.

Yilmaz said he still believes talks between Iran and the United States would continue. "We would all like these talks to end all at once, in a very short time. But we need to be realistic. These comprehensive negotiations will take some time," Yilmaz said. The vice president also said that a



Turkish Vice President Cevdet Yilmaz

comprehensive settlement between Iran and the United States would be a prerequisite for free navigation through the Strait of

Hormuz. "What is the root cause here? The ongoing war. Therefore, the end of this war will provide the greatest guarantee," he said.

Eyewitnesses recount three deadly Israeli strikes on medics in Lebanon

ISABEL DEBRE ■ Nabatiyeh

It was late morning when two ambulances slowed to a stop outside of the village of Mayfadoun in southern Lebanon.

Having heard minutes earlier on Wednesday that Israel had attacked two other ambulances, hitting one and then the other after it showed up to help the first, they didn't hesitate before rushing to the scene. They knew the danger, and they found a hellscene.

The first two ambulances were destroyed, their tires blown and windows shattered. Six of their eight crew members were covered in blood and lying in the road or the back of one vehicle. A paramedic in one of the driver's seats, blood pulsing from his abdomen, was cradling a colleague in his lap, pleading with him to stay conscious. "I felt sick. I couldn't believe



my eyes," Mohammed Jaber, 43, told The Associated Press on Friday from his emergency team's headquarters in Nabatiyeh, where team members dozed on foam mattresses. A 10-day truce in the Israel-Hezbollah war, as Israel accused Hezbollah, as it did Hamas in Gaza, of using Lebanese hospitals as cover for militant activities - a claim denied by Hezbollah and the Lebanese Health Ministry.

The attacks haven't slowed, as humanitarian agencies report that an average of two health workers have been killed every day in this war before a truce took hold Friday.

too, were attacked.

The three strikes, which killed four paramedics and wounded six others, is the latest example of Israel's willingness to target Lebanon's health sector.

Such attacks became a contentious issue during the 2024 Israel-Hezbollah war, as Israel accused Hezbollah, as it did Hamas in Gaza, of using Lebanese hospitals as cover for militant activities - a claim denied by Hezbollah and the Lebanese Health Ministry.

The attacks haven't slowed, as humanitarian agencies report that an average of two health workers have been killed every day in this war before a truce took hold Friday.

Back-to-back-to-back strikes

In response to questions about the Mayfadoun strikes, the Israeli army did not repeat its previous accusations about Hezbollah's use of

health facilities. Instead, it said it was aware of reports about the ambulance attacks and "the incident is under review."

The attack on the third team of ambulances to make a rescue attempt Wednesday happened as they were still assessing the first two crews' injuries, less than six minutes after their arrival. An Israeli drone smashed the vehicles' windows and struck 30-year-old Abu Zaid, throwing him to the ground, his colleagues told the AP. Abu Zaid, who had a 4-year-old son and sold spices and nuts when he wasn't volunteering as a paramedic, was later proclaimed dead on arrival at al-Najda Hospital.

Their accounts of what happened match footage captured by a GoPro camera that was strapped on one of the paramedics. The video shows a barrage of fire hitting the ambulance as medical

workers administered first aid to two colleagues in blood-soaked clothes, one taking shallow breaths through an oxygen mask.

After the third attack, a fourth team of rescuers finally managed to reach the stranded medics and evacuate the wounded without being targeted.

The attacks on the ambulances have drawn condemnation, including from the United Nations' human rights office, which said it was "shocked" and warned that intentionally targeting medics constituted a war crime.

For the emergency workers involved, it was the latest example of Israel's efforts to wreck southern Lebanon's health system as its army extends security control to the Litani River, some 20 miles (30 kilometers) into Lebanese territory, in a bid to protect its northern towns from Iran-backed Hezbollah. (AP)

Deal is only done when it is done: Pak official

SAJJAD HUSSAIN ■ Islamabad

Pakistan's efforts to resolve the conflict between the US and Iran have been going on with a "realistic and positively optimistic" approach, official sources said on Saturday, while emphasising "a deal is only done when it's done".

As Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif and Chief of Defence Forces Field Marshal Asim Munir wrapped up their respective visits to West Asia, reports began to circulate about the second round of talks in Islamabad.

It is not yet clear when the next round of talks will take place. "As all eyes are set on the next round of Peace Talks in Islamabad, there is a need to remain realistic



and positively optimistic. However, what also must be understood is that a deal is only done when it's done," an official source said.

According to sources, ever since President Trump announced his intention to travel to Islamabad for the signing of the peace deal, there has been a media frenzy bordering on hyper optimism as if the deal is

already done and only signing is left.

"This line of reporting stems from either a lack of knowledge of the current status of talks or the complications of the conflict and the decades-old antagonistic relationship between belligerents," he said.

Pakistan has played a monumental role as the mediator in the peace process and achieved the impossible by getting warring parties in the same room for direct talks, but it must be clearly understood that the "job is not done yet", even though tremendous progress has been made, he added. The process requires step-by-step, point-by-point negotiation, messaging and agreement, which is an

unimaginably tedious process that takes time, great patience and a mediator trusted by both, another official said.

"This is exactly what is taking place, and while there is agreement by both sides on most points, the process of negotiation on the more contentious issues is a work in progress," he added. Officials said that Pakistan remains hopeful and committed to a positive outcome, but at the end of the day, it is the two warring parties who have to agree to the terms.

They also warned of the spectre of domestic compulsions and the role of spoilers, which they said is also always lurking in the shadows. (PTI)

Russian attacks on Ukraine kill one, wound dozens; Ukraine targets Russian industrial areas

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Kyiv

A civilian was killed and dozens more wounded in overnight Russian attacks across Ukraine, local officials said on Saturday.

One person was killed in a strike on Mykolaivka in Ukraine's eastern Donetsk region, local leader Vadym Filashkin said in a post on social media. Other officials reported at least 26 people had been hurt in attacks across northern and eastern Ukraine, including a strike on port infrastructure in the city of Odesa.

Elsewhere, a Ukrainian drone strike targeted industrial areas in Novokuibyshevsk and Syzran in Russia's Samara region, Governor Vyacheslav Fedorishchev said Saturday. He did not give further details, but the General Staff of Ukraine's Armed Forces said in



a statement that it had hit major oil refineries in both cities. It also said that its attacks had sparked fires at the Vystok oil terminal in Russia's northwestern Leningrad region and an oil refinery in the southern Krasnodar region, with the blazes later confirmed by Russian officials.

Russia's Ministry of Defence said that its forces destroyed 258 Ukrainian drones overnight over 16 Russian regions, as well as over the annexed Ukrainian peninsula of Crimea and the Black and Azov seas.

Ukraine increasingly targeting Russian oil

Ukraine has repeatedly targeted Russian oil facilities in the past, but the strategy has gained more attention since the Trump administration gave Russian oil a temporary waiver from sanctions

to ease supply constraints.

The US Treasury Department extended its pause on sanctions on Russian oil shipments on Friday, despite complaints from Kyiv officials that Russia will use the additional revenue on new weapons to hit Ukraine harder.

The so-called general license means US sanctions will not apply for 30 days on deliveries of Russian oil that has been loaded on tankers as of Friday. It extended a similar 30-day license issued in March for Russian oil that had been loaded by March 11.

Ukraine seeks to strengthen air defences

Strengthening Ukraine's air defences has been a key priority for Kyiv since the start of Russia's invasion of Ukraine more than four years ago, resurfacing again on the global stage as US-led

peace talks have ground to a halt. In the worst aerial attack in weeks, Russia hammered civilian areas across Ukraine on Thursday, killing at least 16 people and wounding more than 100 others, Ukrainian authorities said.

Ukraine has developed a significant domestic arms industry, especially in the production of drones and missiles, but cannot yet match the sophistication of US Patriot air defence systems.

Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy travelled to Germany, Norway and Italy earlier this week to discuss the issue, while Andrii Sybiha said Saturday that he had discussed "steps to enhance protection" with the Deputy Secretary General of NATO, Radmila Shekerinska, at the Antalya Diplomatic Forum.

"Amid intensified Russian air terror, our priority number one is to strengthen our air defence," he said.



4 Muslim nation deepens strategic ties

SAJJAD HUSSAIN ■ Islamabad

Foreign Ministers of Pakistan, Saudi Arabia, Turkiye, and Egypt have discussed ways to enhance cooperation in “key areas of mutual interest” in a third consultative meeting held in Antalya.

The meeting between Pakistan’s Foreign Minister Ishaq Dar, Saudi Arabia Foreign Minister Prince Faisal bin Farhan Al Saud, Turkiye Foreign Minister Hakan Fidan and Egyptian Foreign Minister Badr Abdelatty was held on the sidelines of the Antalya Diplomacy Forum on Friday, according to a statement issued by the Foreign Office (FO) on Saturday.

“The Foreign Ministers expressed a shared commitment to advancing this partnership, deepening coordination and expanding collaboration across key areas of mutual interest,” it said. They also



Foreign Ministers of Egypt, Pakistan, Turkiye and Saudi Arabia in Antalya

exchanged views on evolving regional dynamics, reaffirming the vital role of dialogue and diplomacy in promoting peace, stability, and shared prosperity.

The meeting comes as Pakistan prepares to host the second round

of high-stakes talks between the US and Iran to resolve the West Asia conflict, which caused significant economic strain and threatened regional stability.

The US and Iran held rare direct talks in Pakistan last week aimed at

ending their conflict, but the talks ended without any agreement.

The group held the first meeting last month in Saudi Arabia, followed by a second one in Pakistan.

Earlier, the senior diplomats from the four countries met in Islamabad on April 14 for the inaugural Senior Officials’ Meeting.

They also met Ishaq Dar, also the Deputy Prime Minister, who urged them to devise a “cooperative framework” among Egypt, Pakistan, Saudi Arabia and Turkiye.

Dar had appreciated the close, brotherly relations and convergence of views on important regional and global matters among the four brotherly countries, the FO said. “He called for devising a cooperative framework among the four countries, focusing on the shared goals of peace, prosperity and economic development,” the FO added. (PTI)

Pak minister urges quick IMF funding release

SAJJAD HUSSAIN ■ Islamabad

Pakistan is keen for an early approval for the next tranche from the IMF as a team of the global lender will visit the country next month for consultations on the upcoming review, Finance Minister Aurangzeb has said. Aurangzeb, who is in Washington for the World Bank-IMF Spring Meetings, was referring to the approval of an estimated \$1.2 billion, including \$1 billion under the ongoing 37-month Extended Fund Facility and another \$200 million under 28-month Resilience and Sustainability Facility.

A staff-level agreement (SLA) was signed last year at the completion of the International Monetary Fund (IMF) second review of the economy under EFF which was agreed in 2024.

Aurangzeb also said responsible borrowing remained central to Government policy, adding that international financial platforms should be used for knowledge-sharing and peer learning rather than debt relief advocacy. (PTI)



Sri Lanka sees drop in tourist arrivals due to West Asia war



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Colombo

Tourist arrivals in Sri Lanka fell significantly in March due to the war in West Asia, the Sri Lanka Tourism Development Authority (SLTDA) said on Saturday. January and February recorded 277,327 and 279,328 arrivals respectively, however this positive trend was disrupted in March as arrivals dropped significantly to 183,979, the SLTDA said. “The sudden dip can be largely attributed to the ongoing conflict in the Gulf/Middle East regions,” it added. The war had disrupted Sri Lanka’s key transit hubs and affected travel plans leading to reduced arrivals, the SLTDA said. In March, India again emerged as Sri

Lanka’s largest inbound market with 47,533 arrivals with a market share of 25.8 per cent. British tourists were placed second with 18,092 arrivals with 9.8 per cent share of the market. Russian and Chinese tourists were placed third and fourth. “India has overtaken all other markets to become Sri Lanka’s undisputed largest source market, growing by over 21 per cent year on year,” SLTDA said. India’s proximity, extensive air connectivity and flights between Sri Lanka and India not having to transit through Middle Eastern hubs have insulated the market, it added. “For Sri Lanka, India now represents a stable high volume short haul anchor that can partially offset losses from Europe,” the release said.

Progressive leaders meet in Barcelona to defend liberal order



JOSEPH WILSON ■ Barcelona

Progressive and traditional democratic leaders gathered in Barcelona on Saturday to discuss how to restore faith in the liberal order threatened by a world drifting toward far-right extremism and torn by conflict.

Spanish Prime Minister Pedro Sanchez, an outspoken critic of President Donald Trump and the US-Israeli war against Iran, is hosting two overlapping events about democracy and progressive politics.

The IV Meeting in Defence of Democracy brought together Brazilian President Luiz Inacio Lula da Silva, Mexican President Claudia Sheinbaum, South African President Cyril Ramaphosa and Colombian President Gustavo, among the leaders or high-ranking officials of 10 other countries. British Deputy Prime Minister David also attended.

While no leader mentioned Trump in the small part of the meeting open to the press, the staunchly unilateral position of the American president that breaks with decades of US foreign policy. (AP)

SEC, Adanis jointly seek extension; propose new briefing schedule in civil securities case

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New York

The US Securities and Exchange Commission (SEC) and Indian businessmen Gautam Adani and Sagar Adani have jointly requested a US court for more time to file key submissions in a civil securities case, proposing a revised schedule for motions and responses.

In a filing before the US District Court for the Eastern District of New York, the parties said they had conferred in line with the court’s April 7 directive and agreed on a new timeline, which has been submitted for



approval to Judge Nicholas G Garaufis.

The SEC had sued Adani Group founder Gautam Adani and his nephew, Sagar, in November 2024, alleging they had misled investors by failing to dis-

close an alleged bribery scheme tied to Indian state officials, framing the case under US securities laws.

Denying all allegations, the two, through their lawyers, on April 7, filed a pre-motion letter ahead of

a planned April 30 motion, seeking dismissal of a fraud lawsuit, arguing the case represents an impermissible extraterritorial application of US law and fails for lack of personal jurisdiction.

Under the proposed schedule, the defendant’s (Adanis) motion to dismiss would be due by June 8, the SEC’s amended complaint or opposition by August 7, and the defendants’ reply by September 21. The parties also suggested May 20, May 22 or May 29 as potential dates for a pre-motion conference, subject to the court’s availability.

Australia and Japan sign \$6.5 billion deal for new warship fleet

ROD MCGUIRK ■ Melbourne

Australia and Japan signed contracts on Saturday to deliver the first three of a 10 billion Australian dollar (\$ 6.5 billion) fleet of Japanese-designed warships, with the first due for delivery in three years.

Mitsubishi Heavy Industries will build the first three Mogami-class frigates in Japan. Australia plans to build another eight in a shipyard in Western Australia. Japanese Defence Minister Shinjiro Koizumi and his Australian counterpart Richard Marles attended a signing ceremony aboard the Mogami-class frigate JS Kumano, which is part of the Japan Maritime

Self-Defence Force, docked off the Australian city of Melbourne.

The Kumano had taken part in the recent Exercise Kakadu, biennial multinational maritime drills hosted by Australia.

Australia announced in August last year that the Japanese bid had won the contract to provide Australia’s next generation of general-purpose frigates over Germany’s MEKO A-200 from Thyssenkrupp Marine Systems.

The deal gave a major boost to Japan’s still-underdeveloped defence industry after it lost out on Australia’s submarine contract to a French company in 2016.

The Japanese-designed



Defence Ministers Marles and Koizumi sign Mogami-class warship deal in Melbourne for Australia’s fleet

fleet will replace Australia’s ageing ANZAC-class frigates that are considered increasingly vulnerable to modern missile and drone attack.

Marles said the Japanese frigates were a major step toward delivering Australia a larger and more lethal

surface combat fleet. The first of the Mogami-class frigates is due to arrive in Australia in 2029.

“The timeframe that we’ve announced is the fastest acquisition of a surface combatant into service in the Royal

Australian Navy ever, and so this is a very rapid time-frame,” Marles told reporters. Japan has been accelerating its military buildup while expanding its defence ties beyond its only treaty ally, the United States. It now considers Australia to be a semi-ally.

Marles said Australia welcomed Japan’s relaxation of export controls on defence equipment and technology with “trusted partners like Australia.” “Japan is an industrial powerhouse, and it offers so much opportunity for Australia and the development of our own defence industry as the Mogami project represents.” Marles said. (AP)

US sanctions Colombian mercenary recruiters

SAMY MAGDY ■ Cairo

The US imposed sanctions on three people and two firms over allegedly recruiting and deploying Colombian mercenaries to fight alongside the paramilitary Rapid Support Forces in Sudan’s war, which has entered its fourth year with no end in sight.

The sanctions, announced by the Department of Treasury late Friday, were the latest by the United States on the RSF, which have been at war against the Sudanese military since April 2023.

The group has been accused by rights groups of atrocities amounting to war crimes and crimes against humanity during the war which created the world’s



largest humanitarian crisis. The RSF was born out of feared Arab Janjaweed militias, notorious for atrocities in the early 2000s against people identifying as East or Central African in Sudan’s western region of Darfur.

The Treasury’s Office of

Foreign Assets Control said the sanctioned individuals and firms were involved in “recruiting and deploying former Colombian military personnel to Sudan to fight on behalf of the RSF.”

They include a Bogota, Colombia-based employ-

ment agency, Fenix, which was established last year as a replacement of another firm, A4SI, that the US sanctioned in December also for aiding the RSF. Both firms were founded by Alvaro Andres Quijano Becerra, a retired Colombian military officer, and his wife. They are also on a Sudan-related sanctions list, according to the Treasury’s statement.

Included in the latest sanctions were another Bogota-based recruitment agency, GQAB, and three individuals: Fenix’s manager Quijano Torres, GQAB owner Jose Garcia Batte, and GQAB’s manager and legal representative Omar Garcia Batte. All are Colombian nationals, the Treasury said. (AP)

States eulogise Charlie Kirk with new laws promoting religion, free speech

DAVID A LIEB ■ Jefferson City (US)

A new Kansas law will allow college students to sue their schools for free-speech violations. In Tennessee, a new law will encourage teachers and professors to include “the positive impacts of religion” in American history courses.

The common factor: Both are being done in the name of Charlie Kirk. The laws are among the first of what could become multiple state tributes to the conservative activist who was killed while speaking at a Utah university last year. More than 60 Kirk-themed



ills have been proposed in over 20 states seeking to promote his ideology, establish official days of remembrance or affix his name to roads and public places, according to an Associated Press analysis

using the bill-tracking software Plural. Just like Kirk, who was known for his provocative campus debates, the measures are not without controversy.

Republican lawmakers in Kansas overrode the veto of Democratic Gov. Laura Kelly to enact a law that she said would “cause confusion for courts and schools.”

In Tennessee, where Republicans firmly control state government, some Democrats denounced the pro-Kirk legislation by recounting what they described as racist remarks he made about Black pilots and Black women in government positions. (AP)

Nepal SC recognises Gagan Thapa-led faction as official Nepali Congress



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Kathmandu

The Gagan Thapa-led faction has been recognised as the official Nepali Congress by the Supreme Court, dealing a blow to Sher Bahadur Deuba.

A division bench of Justices Saranga Subedi and Nripa Dhwoj Niroula on Friday ruled in favour of the Election Commission’s (EC) recognition of the current Central Working Committee (CWC) led by Thapa, my Republica newspaper reported.

Thapa, 49, was elected as the Nepali Congress president in a special general convention from January 11 to 14 in Kathmandu, which was challenged by the Deuba-led faction.

Former prime minister Deuba and party’s acting president Purna Bahadur Khadka had challenged the EC’s decision as well as the validity of the special general convention, arguing that the recognition of the Thapa-led leadership was unconstitutional, unlawful and contrary to the party statute. (PTI)

Traditional tribal spirit Mahua, Feni make UK debut as Indian heritage drinks

ADITI KHANNA ■ London

Traditional tribal spirit Mahua and Goan Feni are making their debut in the UK market as part of a new range of Indian heritage spirits from this week.

Maharaja Drinks, a retailer focussed on introducing craft Indian beverages to Britain, has launched three Feni offerings and a Mahua spirit in celebration of indigenous spirits with centuries of distilling history rooted in India.

The specialist retailer is geared towards organic certification, sustainable production methods and environmentally aware manufacturing, packaging and transport of Indian spirits. “India is home to

an extraordinary range of heritage spirits, each rooted in centuries of craftsmanship and storytelling,” said Annabel Jamieson, CEO of Maharaja Drinks.

“Today, there’s a growing appetite among consumers and bartenders to explore these authentic native flavours. That’s why the time feels right to introduce four exceptional expressions to the UK for the first time,” she said.

The company’s new range offers Cashew Feni and Coconut Feni from Goenchi Feni, a spiced Feni named OURO De Goa from the Goa Heritage Distillery and Desmondji Mahua Spirit from Andhra Pradesh’s Desmondji. “Feni remains a rare and



Maharaja Drinks’ newly launched drinks including three Feni offerings and a Mahua spirit. Maharaja Drinks is a retailer focussed on introducing craft Indian beverages to Britain

distinctive presence here, and Mahua is an exciting new discovery, a vibrant, characterful spirit just beginning to make its mark,” added Jamieson.

Goenchi Feni, a family-run brand from Goa founded by

siblings Yash and Tulika Sawardekar, double distill their Feni in small batches using traditional 100 per cent copper pot stills. They claim to follow a “closely guarded family recipe” that uses a single natural ingredient:

either cashew apple or coconut palm sap. “Feni carries a long and proud heritage from Goa, passed down through generations as a true expression of our land and culture,” said Goenchi Feni co-founder Yash Sawardekar.

“Despite this richness, it has often been overlooked on the global stage. By opening international markets like the UK, we aim to change that and reintroduce Feni as a spirit worthy of recognition,” he said.

Goa Heritage Distillery, a third-generation family business run by Ashok Malkarnekar, is located on a biodiverse farm in Goa rich with ginger, turmeric, tulsi, cardamom, cashew, and

coconut trees. The distillery produces OURO De Goa, a premium spiced cashew Feni ideal for the festive season, which Maharaja Drinks feels would be a perfect addition to the UK’s Christmas spirits offerings. “The UK market has a significant Indian diaspora which already has a liking for Cashew Feni. We feel Maharaja Drinks with their focused approach are an ideal partner to make our Feni available to the Indian diaspora in the UK as well as to introduce it to new audiences,” said Malkarnekar.

“We would particularly expect the diaspora to become proud brand ambassadors of their very own heritage spirits like Feni,” he

said. Desmondji Mahua is described as a tribute to the heartland, rooted in centuries of tribal lore and tradition. The Mahua tree, often referred to as the “tree of life”, is behind this once-banned spirit.

Now produced at the country’s only agave distillery in Andhra Pradesh, the spirit is crafted by collecting the naturally sweet flowers of the Mahua tree, then drying, fermenting, and distilling them in artisanal pot stills. “Mahua is a national treasure of India that has been hidden in plain sight. It has an exquisite taste and is the world’s only flower-based spirit,” said Desmond Nazareth, founder of Desmondji Mahua. (PTI)

BRIEFLY

St Pauli concedes penalty to tie with Cologne



Karol Mets scored his first Bundesliga goal and conceded the 1-1 equalizer with seven minutes left as St Pauli missed the chance to snap a six-game winless streak against Cologne. St Pauli had the best of the chances but was beset again by a familiar failing in the final third that has made it the league's lowest scoring club. It wasn't until the 69th minute that Mets put it ahead with a header. The Hamburg side was close to a vital win to avoid relegation until Mets felled Jakub Kaminski inside the box in the 83rd minute and the penalty kick saw Luca Waldschmidt sent the goalkeeper the wrong way. St Pauli stayed third from last in the relegation playoff spot. It was two points behind Werder Bremen. Nevertheless, the Hamburg club did move five points clear of second-to-last Wolfsburg, which is struggling to avoid relegation for the first time since 1997. The bottom two go down automatically and the third-from-bottom club goes into a relegation playoff. Cologne, whose striker Ragnar Ache was forced off with a thigh injury, climbed one spot into 12th.

Lens keeps Ligue 1 title hopes alive



Lens allowed two goals in the first 13 minutes and bounced back in a superb second half to beat Toulouse 3-2 and keep alive slim hopes of a first Ligue 1 title since 1998. It was helped by the 17th minute red card for Toulouse midfielder Yan Ghobo. Lens has matched reigning champion Paris Saint-Germain for much of the season but two defeats in its last two games dented its title aspirations and it needed to take all three points against a team that shipped seven goals in its last two matches. However, it was two goals behind before it knew what was happening. Goalkeeper Robin Rissier fluffed Cristian Casseres' shot after six minutes then Seny Koumbassa's header went in off the crossbar seven minutes later to put Toulouse in the driving seat. Lens was all over the visitors – who did not have another shot on target for the rest of the game – but not until the 61st minute did it turn domination into goals. Saud Abdulhamid scored with a fine header that appeared to break the Toulouse resolve, and six minutes later Adrien Thomasson leveled. Ismaelo Ganiou's 91st-minute goal sent the home fans wild and lifted Lens to within a point of league leader PSG. PSG has two games in hand.

Train fare spikes for WC fans attending matches in New Jersey

PHILIP MARCELO
■ Newark

Sky-high ticket prices won't be the only thing emptying the wallets of soccer fans attending World Cup matches at some US venues this spring.

Fans trying to get to MetLife Stadium from New York City can expect to shell out \$150 for a round-trip train fare for each match, transportation officials confirmed Friday.

That's nearly 12 times the regular \$12.90 fare for the roughly 15-minute, 9-mile (14-kilometre) ride from Manhattan's Penn Station to the stadium in East Rutherford, New Jersey. On-site parking won't be available for most fans, so New



Jersey officials anticipate that around 40,000 fans will use mass transit for each match.

The home stadium for both the NFL's New York Giants and New York Jets is set to host eight World Cup

Fitzpatrick leads Hovland at Hilton Head

DOUG FERGUSONAP
■ Hilton Head Island

Matt Fitzpatrick had one good break and a lot of great golf for an 8-under 63 to take a one-shot lead over Viktor Hovland on a blistering day of heat and big numbers in the RBC Heritage.

Fitzpatrick was cruising along when his tee shot on the par-3 14th turned hard to the left, headed for sand and trees when it caught what appeared to be the edge of a cart path that sent the ball back down a slope onto the green and headed for the water. It was slowed just enough by a sprinkler to stay dry, and he holed a 30-footer for a most unlikely birdie.

Fitzpatrick birdied two of the

next three and completed a bogey-free round.

"Yeah, it was lucky, there's no two ways about it," Fitzpatrick said. "Sometimes you need that in a week, so it's nice to get, and then even nicer to take advantage of it."

Hovland had it far tougher in the afternoon when the wind got stronger, and it doesn't take much around tree-lined Harbour Town for players to get indecisive or catch the wrong gust.

Hovland got the right club on the exposed par-3 17th to 12 feet for his eighth birdie of the day and a hard-earned 65. That included a birdie on the par-5 fifth when he was still 205 yards out for his third shot and wound up holing a 30-footer. "I wouldn't say I



striped it today, but at least I kind of kept the ball in front of me, and that's what you're trying to do on this golf course," Hovland said. Fitzpatrick, who won the RBC Heritage in a playoff over Jordan Spieth in 2023, was at 14-under 128. Harris English got

the wrong gust on the 11th hole and went from scrambling for par to figuring out how to escape with double bogey from a plugged lie in the sand. He overcame that, had a 68 and was three shots behind. Scottie Scheffler, who played alongside Fitzpatrick,

hit all 14 fairways for only the fourth time in his career – two of those were on the runway-wide fairways of Kapalua – and had a steady diet of birdie chances in the 18-foot range. He managed a bogey-free 67 and was seven behind.

Fitzpatrick and Scheffler both hit the ball so well it looked they were playing a Tuesday money game, with birdie chances on every hole and exchanging birdies early on before the wind acted up. On the par-4 eighth, Scheffler hit enough of the left corner of the green that it hopped right to 7 feet. Fitzpatrick followed on the same line and was 6 inches closer, and Scheffler looked back at the Englishman and smiled. But it was Fitzpatrick

who surged ahead with a batch of three straight birdies on the front and three straight birdies on the back. The longest par putt he had was 4 feet on the final hole.

He called it a continuation of good iron play that began when he finished one shot behind Cameron Young at The Players Championship, then won the following week at Innisbrook in the Valspar Championship.

Patrick Cantlay, who took a big step last week with consecutive bogey-free rounds at the Masters after opening with a 77, shot 64 and was four shots behind along with Sepp Straka (67) and Ludvig Aberg, who was closing in on Fitzpatrick until three bogeys on the back nine led to a 71.

Pakistan selectors recall veteran Abbas

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Karachi

Pakistan's national selectors have recalled 36-year-old pace bowler, Mohammad Abbas, and included four uncapped players in their squad for a two-match Test series in Bangladesh next month. The Pakistan Cricket Board (PCB) also named former Test captain, Sarfaraz Ahmed, as the new head coach of the red ball squad which includes uncapped batters Abdullah Fazal, Azan Awaiz, all-rounder Amad Butt and wicketkeeper Ghazi Ghouri. The four players have yet to play for the national team in any format.

The selectors recalled Abbas to the side after January 2025 when he played at Cape Town against South Africa and took three wickets.

Pakistan's last outing in



Tests was a home series against South Africa last October which ended 1-1 and was their first outing in the current ICC World Test Championship cycle.

The selectors have dropped spinners Asif Afridi and Abrar Ahmed, opener Abdullah Shafique, batter Kamran Ghulam and reserve keeper Rohail Nazir from the Test squad that was picked

against South Africa.

Pakistan will tour Bangladesh next month with the first of the two matches – part of the ICC World Test Championship – to be played at Sher-e-Bangla National Cricket Stadium in Dhaka from May 8 to 12, while the Sylhet International Cricket Stadium will host the second game, which will be played from May 16 to 20.

Brian Gay, Scott Hend share lead in Senior PGA Championship

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Bradenton

Brian Gay finally figured out how to play the par 5s at Concession Golf Club, making up ground with an eagle-birdie finish for a 4-under 68 to share the 36-hole lead with Scott Hend of Australia in the Senior PGA Championship.

Hend had five birdies over the last eight holes for a 65, a far more conventional round of eight birdies against only one dropped shot.

They were at 10-under 134, two shots ahead of major champions Stewart Cink (67) and Retief Goosen (69), with

Ben Crane making his senior debut with a 69 to join them.

But it was quite the adventure for Gay. He fanned a 5-iron into the bushes on the par-5 13th after starting the second round on the back nine of Concession. He twice went into the bushes trying to take his drive over the bunkers on the par-5 17th and then lipped out and took double bogey.

Gay made a par on the next par 5 at No. 3, but only after hitting his second shot into a palmetto bush, taking a penalty drop and getting up-and-down. But he got his reward with an eagle on the par-5 eighth and closed with



a birdie. "Another pretty good day. A little volatile," Gay said.

"Pretty similar to yesterday, except I butchered a

couple of par 5s. Two of them with one bad tee ball, two good tee balls, but other than that, I putted well again. Just

a couple of balls in the bushes." Hend knows all about volatile. In the opening round, the Aussie went eagle-double bogey and then later birdie-double bogey on his front nine. He managed to rally with three straight birdies to open with a 69.

It was a much cleaner card Friday. "I was disappointed in yesterday's two double bogeys on the back nine, so I wanted to play that nine a bit smarter and a bit better today, so I didn't short-side myself as much as what I did yesterday," he said. "And it seemed to work out quite well." Hend also took advantage of playing in the morning, the first one

out when the greens were pure and the wind had not arrived along the Gulf Coast of Florida. Cink was within one shot of the lead until a bogey on his last hole. Goosen was bogey-free with just three birdies, only one of them on the par 5s. Justin Hicks had the low score among the club pros and another 69 left him four shots behind, along with Steve Allan, Greg Chalmers and Soren Kjeldsen.

Bernhard Langer, the 68-year-old German who shot his age or lower for the 43rd time in the opening round with a 66, was 10 shots worse on Friday with a 76. That left him eight behind.

Aditi Ashok makes cut in LA

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Los Angeles

An eagle towards the end of the day saw Indian golfer Aditi Ashok make the cut at the JM Eagle LA Championship on the LPGA Tour here. Aditi carded 72 after a first round 70 and at 2-under for 36 hole.

Starting on the 10h, she bogeyed the 10th and 15th but picked one shot on the 16th. A bogey on the 18th was followed by a birdie on the first. The see-saw continued as she bogeyed the second before landing an eagle on the seventh. Sei Young Kim shot her second straight 7-under 65 at El Caballero – in the final event before the first



women's major of the season. First-round leader Chizzy Iwai of Japan was tied for second with Ina Yoon of South Korea. Iwai followed her opening 63 with a 68, making three birdies in a

four-hole stretch on the back nine late in the afternoon.

Yoon had a 64. She played her opening nine holes – the back nine at El Caballero – in 7-under 29 and added a birdie on the par-5 seventh.

Coventry returns to the Premier League

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Blackburn

Coventry City clinched a return to the Premier League for the first time since 2001 after drawing at Blackburn Rovers 1-1 in the Championship.

Frank Lampard's men were second best for much of the game but one point was enough to secure a historic return to the top tier.

Blackburn winger Ryoya Morishita put the home side ahead after 54 minutes but Bobby Thomas equalized six minutes from time to the delight of the visiting fans.

The result put Coventry 11 points clear of second-placed Ipswich Town and 13 ahead of third-placed



Millwall. The top two go up automatically, while the teams from third to sixth take part in a playoff to see which other club will join them. Lampard's side has looked a good bet for promotion for the entire season with what is both the best

attack and the stingiest defense. It was in the top flight for 34 years from 1967-2001 but its only major trophy was the FA Cup in 1987. Friday's result left Blackburn in 16th, three places and five points above the relegation zone.

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Durban

Indian batter Jemimah Rodrigues admitted they were short of runs in the opening women's T20I but said the series presents a valuable opportunity for the batting unit, especially the all-rounders, to prepare for the upcoming World Cup.

India failed to build sustained momentum and finished with 157 for seven, a total that South Africa chased down comfortably to seal a six-wicket win in the series opener here on Friday.

"I feel, starting off in batting, we were around 15-20 runs short. With the kind of start we got, I think Shafali Verma, the way she batted



was great," Rodrigues told reporters. "Then two wickets falling in two overs, but then Harmanpreet Kaur and I getting that partnership back. I think when we had built that momentum and removed the difficult part of it, when time came to capi-

talise, we were not able to capitalise. "And also, the conditions were a little bit tricky in the first innings. There was slight hold on the wicket. But yeah, definitely we were 15 runs short." Harmanpreet Kaur (47 not out off 33 balls) and Rodrigues (36; 29b)

shared a 71-run stand (51b) in the middle overs to steady the innings. However, Rodrigues and Richa Ghosh (5) fell in quick succession, denying India a late flourish.

"I know Harman and I could have gone deep.

"Even Richa, little here and there, it was a six. So, sometimes when you come in, in such a position, you need to back yourself. It is like 1 out of those 10 times where it will go for a catch," Rodrigues said Richa's dismissal.

"But I know 9 out of 10 times, she will hit it in the stands. So, I think we can definitely work on that because coming to the World Cup, we have batting till the end, a lot of all-rounders. "But also, the all-rounders coming later

have not got so much match time and experience. So, I think playing here in South Africa is going to be really great for us as a preparation also for the World Cup and for our entire batting order too."

India were also sloppy with the ball, conceding 14 wides as South Africa overhauled the target in 19.1 overs.

Laura Wolvaardt (51 off 39) laid the foundation for the chase. Annerie Dercksen (44 not out off 34) then powered the hosts home with an authoritative finish.

"Coming in the second innings, I think our bowlers did really well to get it to the last over. Like Shreyanka Patil bowled really well, Shree Charani bowled really well," Rodrigues said.

David Miller takes Delhi home with last-over exploits

G UNNIKRISSHAN
■ Bengaluru

David Miller sort of redeemed himself with two last-over sixes after KL Rahul made a 57 rooted in classicism and Tristan Stubbs produced an equally chic 60 as Delhi Capitals edged Royal Challengers Bengaluru by six wickets in their IPL match here on Saturday.

Considering the slow nature of this particular Chinnaswamy strip and the quality in RCB bowling ranks, the chase of 176 was never going to be straightforward. Miller (22 not out 10b) could not take Delhi home in the outing against Gujarat Titans

when they needed two off 2 balls, inviting sharp criticism. However, he did not make any mistake today, hammered Romario Shepherd for two huge sixes as DC, who needed 15 runs off the last over, scampered home and RCB crashed to their second defeat of the season.

DC found saviours at various times in Rahul (57, 34b), Stubbs (60 not out, 47b) and Axar Patel (24 retired hurt) to make 179 for four, ending a two-match losing streak.

Rahul played an innings of rare quality, a bit un-T20 if you may, to rescue DC from a disastrous start and set the chase in order. He took a par-

ticular liking for Josh Hazlewood, carving him for a total of two sixes and three fours.

In fact, both his sixes were of amazing quality — the first one an inside out lofted shot over covers and the second a flick, which he executed through a last minute snap of wrist.

Rahul fetched his fifty in 30 balls but fell to Krunal Pandya, hitting the spinner into the hands of a diving Virat Kohli at long-on.

By then Rahul and Stubbs added 69 runs for the fourth wicket as DC walked back from a precarious 18 for three in 2.5 overs. Stubbs and Axar added 47 for the fifth wicket



before the latter had to hobble off the field with a niggle. At that time DC were 134 for four in 15.5 overs, needing to score 45 off 25 balls. But Stubbs found an able ally in Miller as they knocked off those runs with a ball to spare.

It would have been hugely satisfying for them as Bhuvneshwar Kumar (3/26) had plucked the wickets of Pathum Nissanka, Karun Nair and Sameer Rizvi in his opening burst, showing virtues of old school swing bowling.

Earlier, despite Phil Salt producing a well-crafted 63, Capitals muffled the big guns in RCB's batting unit to restrict

the defending champions to a sub-par 175 for eight.

After being asked to bat first, RCB's start was anything but smooth as the Capitals bowlers stuck to a good line in the first four overs.

Virat Kohli (19), who added 52 runs for the first wicket with Salt whose fifty came off 38 balls, played a couple of delectable shots off pacer Mukesh Kumar and his partner from England too unfurled a cracking four off Auqib Nabi.

But even then the run-rate remained a tad above eight in that phase. However, Axar's decision to give a third over to Nabi shifted the

momentum in favour of RCB.

Salt feasted on Nabi's medium pace offerings, carting him for two fours and a six in the fifth over that yielded 18 runs.

It helped RCB finish the Power Play at a rather happy note of 59 for 1, despite losing Kohli to Lungi Ngidi.

Salt too seemed to have shed his indifferent form, bringing up his fifty in 30 balls. Salt and Devdutt Padikkal milked 47 runs for the second wicket before the latter skied a simple catch to David Miller at deep off Axar (2/18). It gave DC a chance to gain some foothold in the match and they used it quite brilliantly.

We will focus on positives: Ajinkya Rahane

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Ahmedabad

Kolkata Knight Riders skipper Ajinkya Rahane admitted it was another demoralising defeat but chose to focus on the positives, particularly Cameron Green's return to form, with the all-rounder producing a solid knock after a lean run in the loss to Gujarat Titans on Friday.

KKR are yet to find their winning formula, slumping to a fifth defeat this season. They are languishing at the bottom of the table with just one point — earned from a rain-abandoned game against Punjab Kings.

"It's never easy to come out and talk immediately after losing a game. But I'd like to



focus on the positives. The way we started, losing three wickets early, it was tough,"

said Rahane after the five-wicket loss.

With Green finally finding

his rhythm with a 79 off 55 balls after a string of underwhelming scores, it did put Gujarat Titans under pressure in the middle overs.

"Cameron Green's innings was outstanding, he was under pressure, but the way he counterattacked and took on their bowlers was amazing to see. At 147 for 4, getting to around 180 was slightly difficult for us as a batting unit," he added.

He also praised his bowlers, noting that despite a string of losses, they have stayed motivated — something that was evident in their effort on Friday.

"I still want to credit our bowlers. It's not easy when things aren't going your way, but they kept coming back

and pushing hard."

Asked why Green didn't bowl, Rahane said "He was actually struggling with cramps, which is why he was in and out of the field."

GT skipper Shubman Gill said he would have preferred to finish the game a couple of overs earlier rather than take it deep. Gill struck an elegant 86 and looked set to seal the chase, but was dismissal in the 17th over.

"Ideally we would have liked to finish it at least a couple of overs before. I'd really would have liked to finish at least another couple of overs before and I was quite disappointed with the way I got out. I wanted to be there till the end and finish it," said Gill.

Wounded RR eye rebound as struggling KKR seek spin spark at Eden

TAPAN MOHANTA
■ Kolkata

A bruised Rajasthan Royals will look to bounce back strongly and deepen the misery of a floundering Kolkata Knight Riders when the two sides with contrasting fortunes clash in an afternoon IPL fixture, here on Sunday. The match pits one of the stronger outfits this season against arguably the most out-of-sorts side.

While Rajasthan had surged with four consecutive wins before being halted by Sunrisers Hyderabad, KKR have progressed in the opposite trajectory, still searching for



their first win after six matches. Under Ajinkya Rahane, defeats have been the only constant, often from winning positions, leaving the side short on confidence and momentum.

Their only point has come through a rain

washout against Punjab Kings here. KKR's struggles have been compounded by an understrength pace attack, with Harshit Rana and Akash Deep ruled out due to injuries, while Matheesha Pathirana is yet to join.

From 'desperate' to 'determined': Kagiso Rabada

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Ahmedabad

Kagiso Rabada reflected on a "disappointing" 2025 season but underlined his shift from being "desperate" to "determined" after producing a match-winning spell to guide Gujarat Titans to victory over Kolkata Knight Riders.

Rabada, who had missed a significant portion of the previous edition due to a recreational drug-related suspension, returned with figures of 3/29, his best this season, to set up a five-wicket win on Friday. "I didn't have a season (2025)... It is something that was really disappointing, especially being involved in such a set-up. I think Gujarat is a magnificent set-up, unbelievable," Rabada told reporters after the match.



"There is a part of me that really wants to do well for this franchise, but I don't think you want to be desperate. There is one thing being eager and another thing being desperate. I think desperation is probably the way that you want to go about things. "As always, coming into an IPL season or any

game of cricket that I play, I am incredibly determined to do well for the team and for myself." The pace duo of Rabada (3/29) and Mohammed Siraj (2/23) dismantled the KKR top order, exploiting early movement to restrict them to 180. "...with the new ball, perhaps there was a bit more moisture and there was a bit more two-paced, a little bit of uneven bounce, so the batsmen couldn't really throw their hands at everything, they had to really check their strokes," Rabada said.

"That was the decision and the decision was for myself and Siraj to bowl for the entire power play and on any given day you could have them five down in that power play but we will take three down any day," the 30-year-

old South African speedster said. "And then moving on to the middle overs and the death overs, it is just about executing a game plan that we feel is going to work based on what we have adapted or pre-planned what we wanted to do."

Winning more important than NRR: Gujarat Titans registered their third successive win to move to fourth on the points table, though their net run rate remains only marginally above zero compared to the stronger figures of Punjab Kings, Royal Challengers Bengaluru and Rajasthan Royals.

"Look, the most important thing is to win. The net run rate is something that you want to be good but I don't think it is something that you prioritise," Rabada said.

Co-hosts of Laureus: Djokovic and Eileen

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Madrid

Novak Djokovic and Eileen Gu, two of the most influential athletes of their generation, will co-host this year's Laureus World Sports Awards in a historical first for the greatest show in sports.

Never before have two athletes hosted the most prestigious Awards show on the sporting calendar, to be held this year at Madrid's iconic Palacio de Cibeles on April 20.

The ceremony will bring together the biggest names from across sport, entertainment and culture to celebrate excellence, resilience and inspiration on sport's grandest stage. Broadcast globally to an audience of millions, the Laureus World

Sports Awards light up social media as fans and athletes all over the world interact as the winners are revealed.

Djokovic is a record-equalling five-time Laureus World Sportsman of the Year, an Olympic gold medalist and has won a staggering 24 men's Grand Slam singles titles. Eileen Gu is the most decorated freestyle skier in the sport's history, a multiple Olympic and world champion, the 2023 Laureus World Action Sportsperson of the Year and a Laureus Ambassador.

Together, they will present the prize most coveted by elite athletes. The awards have previously been hosted by Hollywood stars including Bill Murray, Andy Garcia, Samuel L Jackson and Benedict Cumberbatch,



while Lindsey Vonn — the 2011 Laureus World Sportswoman of the Year and a Member of the Academy — became the first athlete to host, in 2025.

Djokovic said: "The Laureus World Sports Awards hold a special place in my heart. They celebrate not just

excellence in sport, but the power of sport to make a difference. I have been honoured with five Laureus statuettes over the years. "It is always a unique opportunity to mix with athletes from other sports" and meet the sporting heroes who make up the Laureus World Sports Academy.

Control the moment is Shreyas Iyer's success mantra

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mullanpur

Last season's runners-up Punjab Kings have made a strong start and are the only unbeaten side so far this IPL season, but skipper Shreyas Iyer insists the focus must remain on staying in the present even as they chase their maiden title.

Reuniting with Ricky Ponting at PBKS, Iyer, who joined the franchise after leading Kolkata Knight Riders to the 2024 title, has been central to their resurgence.

Punjab, who finished runners-up to Royal Challengers Bengaluru last season, have looked formidable with four wins from five matches, while one game

against Kolkata Knight Riders ended in a washout.

"The mission, obviously, is to lift the trophy. But I always feel that the more you stay in the present, the more you stay in control of what is in your hands at that moment and you just have to go full throttle," Iyer said on JioStar.

"You don't have to think too far ahead or dwell on the past. I reiterate the same point to my teammates as well — when we are out there, we are playing for ourselves, not against the opponents. We just want to improve each day and make sure we put our best foot forward. When everything comes together and that synergy builds, everything falls into place." Iyer has



marshalled the middle order with authority, striking three successive fifties in as many innings. His PBKS stint began with a match-winning 97 against Gujarat Titans in IPL 2025, setting the tone for his fine run as skipper.

Reflecting on that innings, where he fell short of a

hundred, Iyer said he prioritised the team's total over personal milestones.

"Honestly, at that moment, I told Shashank Singh not to over think because there were 10 balls left. I thought I would get at least one ball out of those 10. So, I told him, 'You can play freely, don't

think too much'. In the last over as well, I gave him that belief — that it's okay to take it on and not worry about my hundred. "In the back of my mind, I felt I would get at least one ball somehow. But then he played the entire over, and I was happy that we got 240 on the board. To get that score in the first match of the season sets the rhythm."

Iyer also highlighted the importance of trusting players' instincts, recalling how lead pacer Arshdeep Singh suggested bringing in Vijaykumar Vyshak as an Impact Player in that game, where he returned tidy figures. "When you are on the ground, every individual is involved in the game and

everyone's inputs matter. When bowlers come and say they can execute a certain plan, it's important to back them because their instincts can be strong as well. "At the same time, there are situations when they run out of ideas and ask what they should do, and that's when I step in. It goes hand in hand — it's not like I always dictate terms. Even in team meetings, players come up with solid points and you have to value what they bring. "We had discussed bowling wide yorkers to Sherfane Rutherford because wherever else we pitched, he was going bonkers. The plan worked, and Vyshak ended up being the hero."

Gerald Coetzee to replace David Payne

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Hyderabad

Sunrisers Hyderabad announced the signing of Gerald Coetzee as a replacement for David Payne for the remainder of the IPL season ahead of their home match against Chennai Super Kings, here on Saturday.

English left-arm pacer Payne, who played two games for SRH in the ongoing season and picked two wickets, was ruled out of the remainder of the season due to an ankle injury.

"South African right-arm pacer Coetzee was named the replacement and will join



SRH for '2-crore," stated an IPL media advisory. Coetzee has played four Tests, 14 ODIs and 18 T20Is for South Africa and has 67 international wickets against his name. Coetzee, who replaces Payne at SRH, has played 14 IPL games in the past, representing Gujarat Titans (2025) and Mumbai Indians (2024).

Ashish Nehra is like a football coach, says Harbhajan Singh

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

Former India spinner Harbhajan Singh heaped praise on Gujarat Titans head coach Ashish Nehra, likening his hands-on, high-energy approach to that of a football manager and crediting him for fostering unity within the franchise.

Speaking on JioHotstar, Harbhajan said Nehra's constant communication with players and deep understanding of the game have played a major role in Gujarat Titans' success.

"Ashish Nehra is the only person who makes the



atmosphere comfortable anywhere, anytime. Wherever he goes, he makes everyone around him feel at ease," Harbhajan said in a release. Highlighting Nehra's proactive presence during matches, Harbhajan added, "He is like a football coach.

He never sits still. Throughout the entirety of a match, he will find a player and keep talking to him."

Harbhajan said Nehra's biggest contribution has been his ability to keep the group united while also bringing tactical clarity.

"Nehra ji has a great understanding of the game. The work he has done with Gujarat Titans is commendable," he said. During the same interactive session, former India batter Suresh Raina, meanwhile, highlighted the hard work behind the emergence of young pacers Kartik Tyagi and Ashok Sharma in the IPL.

Rampaging PBKS eye another win, injury-hit LSG face uphill task

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mullanpur

Table-toppers Punjab Kings will bank on their strong batting to continue their winning run against a struggling Lucknow Super Giants, who are sweating over skipper Rishabh Pant's injury, in their IPL match here on Sunday.

PBKS, the only unbeaten side so far, have looked ominous this season with four wins from five matches, with one game against Kolkata Knight Riders washed out. The Shreyas Iyer-led side boasts a healthy net run rate of +1.067, thanks to their strong batting displays that have powered clinical chases.

The Kings have won nine of



their last 11 matches while chasing since the 2025 season, underlining their dominance, and it was also seen in their recent win over Mumbai Indians. It will take something special from LSG to halt the home team's

momentum.

Lucknow, currently seventh in the points table, are reeling from back-to-back losses, and Pant's elbow injury in the previous match against Royal Challengers Bengaluru has further dented

their campaign.

Pant looked in visible discomfort and retired hurt after facing just three deliveries. Though he returned later with his elbow heavily strapped, he managed only 1 off 6 balls, and his availability for Sunday's game remains uncertain.

It was a one-sided contest against RCB as LSG could must only 146, with Mukul Choudhary and Ayush Badoni providing some resistance.

Their batting has yet to click, with the side still to cross the 200-run mark this season. In contrast, Punjab have breached that mark twice and were cruising at 198 for 3 in 16.3 overs against MI in their last outing.

Punjab opener

Prabhsimran Singh (211 runs) has been in outstanding touch, while skipper Iyer (203) has been equally impressive, striking at 172.95 and 187.96 respectively. The duo combined effectively in the win over MI. Priyansh Arya and Cooper Connolly have also contributed significantly to Punjab's batting firepower.

On the bowling front, spearhead Arshdeep Singh returned to form with a fine 3/22 against MI.

Can LSG's bowling attack stop PBKS? Prince Yadav has been Lucknow's most successful bowler with nine wickets, followed by Avesh Khan (5) and Mohammed Shami (4), who was taken apart by Virat Kohli and Rajat Patidar the other day.

The Painter's Eye

To mark World Heritage Day, watch artist Soumen Dutta capture Safdarjung Tomb's quiet history long before the city stirs, says **SAKSHI PRIYA**

Stones carry the silence of centuries, holding onto stories that wait patiently for a quiet observer. Looking at the physical world through a painter's eyes shifts reality entirely. A casual glance misses the bruised purple tucked inside a morning shadow or the sharp edge of early light. Most walkers hurry past without a second thought, missing the exact details that make a space alive. Edgar Degas captured this dynamic perfectly when he noted that art involves making others see what is hidden in plain sight. I met artist Soumen Dutta while the capital was still half asleep, standing outside Delhi's Safdarjung Tomb waiting for the dawn to hit the massive beige walls so the process of creation could begin.

Dutta operates with a deep, steady patience. For over five hours, I watched him move his brush across the canvas, translating heavy stone into vivid color. The secret of the mausoleum lies entirely in its numbers, he told me, pointing toward the central dome. The original architects relied on the Navagraha and its nine elements to build a space designed to trick the human mind. The surrounding gardens and fountains present a perfectly mirrored layout from every possible angle, instantly swallowing a visitor's sense of direction at the main gate. Human vision relies heavily on

EVERY SINGLE TIME HE LOADED HIS BRUSH, HE STOPPED. HE WOULD JUST STARE AT THE ACTUAL TOMB, MEASURING THE LIGHT AND THE DISTANCE IN HIS HEAD BEFORE LETTING THE BRISTLES ANYWHERE NEAR THE CANVAS. IT MAKES YOU WONDER HOW ANYONE EVEN TRAINS THEIR EYES TO SEE LIKE THAT

a three-point perspective, making the imposing walls look slightly tilted to the naked eye. Yet, tracing the geometry taking shape in his painting, Dutta proved the actual walls and intricatejali patterns remain completely, mathematically straight.

The monument felt more alive as the sun climbed higher. Peacocks began calling from the upper domes. Squirrels scattered across the paths, ladybugs moved quietly through the grass, and dragonflies drifted near the canvas. Dutta smiled and ducked out of the way of a low flying pigeon. He pointed out that the architecture actually breathes with the nature surrounding it. He insisted that seeing the tomb properly takes a full day. By nine o'clock, the harsh morning sun washes out all the depth and shadows. But catch it right before dusk, and the clash between the bright green lawns and the rough brown stone changes the entire scene.

Seeing this process happen live feels like watching someone anchor history to a page. Dutta has spent the last twenty five years archiving India's historical buildings. He started doing this back in 2002, and since then everything from the ghats of Varanasi to the dry deserts of Rajasthan has found its way onto his canvas. Mixing a new shade of paint, he talked about Jaisalmer Fort, about how that massive structure actually mirrors

the physical map of India, and the way he said it made you feel like he had been carrying that thought around for years, waiting for the right moment to let it out. He remembered sitting down to draw a fort in Alwar years ago when the walls were crumbling and ruined. Conservation is the whole point of this work. He kept his eyes fixed on the tomb while explaining that his paintings track how the culture physically shifts. He even matches old 1980s photographs of Varanasi given to him by his teacher with his own 2022 artwork. He does it to leave a concrete record behind for his son and whoever comes next.

The noise of morning traffic finally began to bleed through the quiet gardens. Delhi is changing incredibly fast right outside those walls. Old heritage bungalows are being flattened for sterile concrete blocks, and those once-quiet neighbourhoods are just getting buried under the endless noise of the new city. Dutta has always said that without old Mughal buildings like this one, the capital would lose it. Following the legacy of eighteenth century British painters William and Thomas Daniell, he spends his days sketching the grand columns of Gole Market or the forgotten gates of Fatehpuri Mosque just to hold onto that fading identity.

But his main focus today was the massive structure right in front of us. Watching him map out Safdarjung was a lesson in pure concentration. He did not just copy the building. He dissected it. He started with faint, precise lines to lock in the impossible symmetry of the dome and the four surrounding fountains. Then came the layers of colour. He spent ages just mixing the paint, trying to find the

precise shade of beige and off-white to match the weathered stone. Every single time he loaded his brush, he stopped. He would just stare at the actual tomb, measuring the light and the distance in his head before letting the bristles anywhere near the canvas. It makes you wonder how anyone even trains their eyes to see like that.

He was capturing the exact view from the entrance. In his painting, you could see the narrow archway framing the courtyard, leading your eye straight to the giant central structure. He painted the harsh shadows the sun was throwing across the delicatejali work and the bright highlights where the morning light hit the highest balconies. He worked carefully around the edges, making sure the green of the gardens pushed hard against the dirt pathways.

By the time the sun had fully come up the artwork was nearly there, and what it caught was something quite specific, that feeling of walking into the tomb where you see only a fragment of it first, just a sliver, before the whole thing suddenly opens out into that vast, perfectly balanced space. Six hours had passed by like nothing at all. Art defines the inner self and shows love through the sheer effort of paying attention. By painting every stone, garden, and dome, Artist Soumen Dutta is building a permanent memory of history and keeping it safe from the heavy hands of time. But as the modern world continues to build over its past and close off ancient gates, who will be left to notice the stories the stones are still trying to tell?

The living archive of Manipuri silk

Discover how a new collection translates the living archive of Khurkhul silk for modern wearers

SAKSHI PRIYA

Have you ever touched a piece of cloth that actually tells the story of an entire community? In the village of Khurkhul in Manipur, wooden looms have been shaping local history for generations. The Meitei culture is completely intertwined with this silk, and the craft relies entirely on the everyday dedication of local weavers. They take raw cocoons and spin them into cloth with a beautiful natural shine that falls effortlessly. The weavers work their own heritage right into the fabric, passing down older techniques with every piece they make. Even the patterns they use act as a direct record of the world around them. The distinctive motifs serve as a living archive of their environment. Patterns such as the energetic Kheiroithek mimic a darting squirrel, while the radiant Kajenlei represents a protective fire halo passed down by hand. This delicate yarn demands an immense gentleness that local families instinctively provide through changing seasons to ensure the legacy of Khurkhul silk remains unbroken.

Founders JayshreeKojiam and Reena Ahanthem established a direct relationship with these weavers to bring this careful craft to the capital through their label 11 Tareng. The new collection, *KABRANG: The Thread, The Myth, and Our Story*, figures out exactly how to pull traditional Manipuri textiles into a contemporary wardrobe. Rather than stripping the silk of its cultural weight, the designers stuck with a handful of local artisans to introduce the fabric to a wider audience properly. Staging the viewing at the Mughal Pavilion in Sunder Nursery was a smart move. The quiet historical backdrop stayed completely out of the way, letting the incredibly detailed loom work do all the talking. The presentation discarded standard runway formats in favour

Remembering Pandit Chatur Lal

SAKSHI PRIYA

"All my life served a single purpose: 'Sangar' both in art and life." Long before the western world discovered the intricate rhythms of India a young tabla player carried the heavy weight of our history across vast oceans to share our soul with strangers. Pandit Chatur Lal translated the complex pulse of his homeland into a flowing language of pure vulnerability and offered a sacred space for the unheard. His music spoke directly for those living with fear in pain and gave a powerful voice to the silent masses who found comfort in his beats. He passed away in 1965 but his pioneering early work with giants like Pandit Ravi Shankar wrote the absolute blueprint for taking Indian classical music to the global stage.

Now marking one hundred years of his magnificent legacy thousands of us gathered under the heavy stone arches of Safdarjung Tomb to honour his birth centenary at this cultural event — the *Pandit Chatur Lal Centenary Festival*. The city came together

ART CORNER

CRAFTING LEGACY THROUGH ART, GOLD, AND MEMORY

TEAM VIVA

Gold is pure. Gold is value. Imagine if you could have your portrait in gold. It would last for eternity. That is the idea behind 'Portrait on Gold', which creates gold portraits. They are not painted in gold; they are made in gold. Each piece is personalised, handcrafted, and unique, created in pure gold so that it shines forever.

In an era where most memories live fleetingly on digital screens, Portrait on Gold is redefining permanence by transforming personal moments into timeless works of art. Operating in a niche yet rapidly evolving segment, the brand has

carved a distinct identity at the intersection of luxury, craftsmanship, and emotional storytelling.

At the heart of Portrait on Gold lies a philosophy rooted in authenticity. According to Dr Amushree Jha, Director of the brand, every creation is designed to preserve life's most meaningful memories in a form that endures across generations. Each portrait is crafted using certified 24K gold and undergoes a meticulous multi-stage process that blends advanced digital refinement with intricate artisan engraving. The brand's structured collections—from Signature Series to Legacy Editions—ensure consistent quality while catering to varied

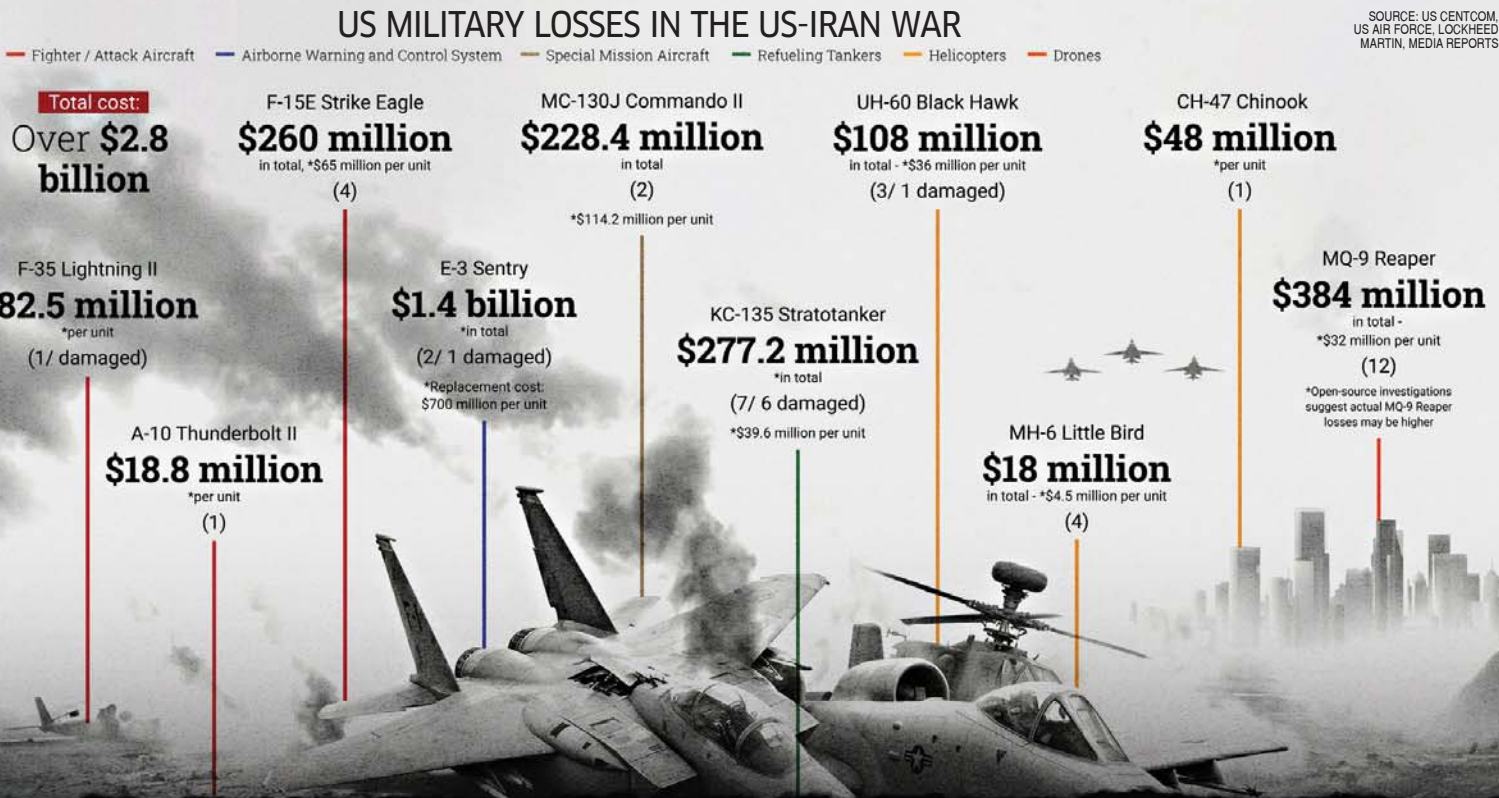
expressions of luxury.

The creation process is both technical and artistic. Customers select and upload an image, which is enhanced digitally at the brand's "Gold Atelier" to achieve clarity and depth. Skilled artisans then etch the portrait onto gold using precision techniques, resulting in photorealistic detailing. The final product is presented in curated formats such as Classic, Luxe, and Legacy frames, reflecting both sophistication and sentiment.

A defining strength of Portrait on Gold is its seamless integration of traditional craftsmanship with modern technology, ensuring both scale and enduring quality.

The Pioneer AGENDA

In wartime, truth is so precious that she should always be attended by a bodyguard of lies.
- Winston Churchill



Trump's war of woes

As the Iran-US-Israel conflict moves into its sixth week, American objectives appear increasingly out of reach. The goal of regime change has not materialised. The situation has not unfolded in Washington's favour: it has struggled to shield key partners such as Saudi Arabia, the UAE, and Qatar from Iranian missile strikes, while allies have grown more cautious and costs have continued to rise. The United States now finds itself entangled in a conflict which it did not need to initiate



Iran-Israel-US war that didn't have to happen

History will record this as one of the most avoidable catastrophes in modern geopolitics. When American and Israeli forces launched strikes on Iranian territory on February 28, they did so with a conviction that Tehran would fold quickly — that a regime under maximum economic pressure, facing internal discontent, and outgunned militarily, would either capitulate or collapse within weeks following a swift leadership decapitation. That calculation was wrong in almost every conceivable way.

The Oman back-channel prior to the war had been quietly effective. Oman's foreign minister has said talks had made progress and Iran agreed to "zero stockpiling" of enriched uranium. A deal was not merely possible - it was close. What torpedoed it was not Iranian intransigence but a decision made in Washington and Tel Aviv that diplomacy was moving too slowly, and that military pressure would deliver faster, cleaner results. It delivered neither.

The Resilience Nobody Prepared For
Iran's ability to absorb punishment and keep fighting has genuinely shocked Western intelligence establishments. The Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps had spent years dispersing critical infrastructure, hardening command-and-control systems, and developing asymmetric capabilities precisely for this scenario. Missiles launched from underground silos, mobile launchers shifted between concealed sites, and layered drone swarms designed to saturate air defences have all complicated attempts to suppress Iran's retaliatory capacity.

Washington had war-gamed a short, sharp



VIKAS SWARUP
Ambassador

campaign. What it has got instead is a grinding confrontation with no clean exit, mounting costs, and no credible path to decisive victory. Trump is now having to defend a deeply unpopular war while Americans face rising gasoline prices, market anxiety, and yet another open-ended Middle Eastern entanglement, a political burden likely to weigh heavily on the midterms.

For Netanyahu it is even worse. He appears to have gambled that sustained military pressure would fracture the Iranian state, trigger regime change, and open the way for a compliant pro-Western government in Tehran. Instead, the Iranian system has held together, nationalist sentiment has hardened, and external attack has rallied many who might otherwise oppose the regime. Rather than delivering strategic transformation, the war risks leaving Israel trapped in a costly conflict while strengthening the very forces it sought to break.

The Gulf States: Paradise Lost

The Gulf monarchies, UAE, Qatar, Bahrain, Kuwait, and Saudi Arabia, built their success on a promise of stability, neutrality, and insulation from regional chaos. Iranian strikes on facilities hosting US forces shattered that image overnight. The message to investors, multinationals, and expatriates was blunt: the Gulf is not immune. Property demand has cooled, insurance costs are rising, and firms are reassessing regional exposure.

Politically, leaders are trapped, dependent on Washington's protection, yet facing questions about why US bases made them targets instead of keeping them safe.

The Strait and the Global Fallout

The closure of the Strait of Hormuz was always the nightmare scenario that previous

US administrations had been careful to avoid triggering. Roughly a fifth of global oil and gas passes through those 33 kilometres. Markets absorbed the initial shock with volatility, but sustained closure has done something far more serious - it has structurally reordered energy supply chains that took decades to build.

Asian economies dependent on Gulf energy imports have been hit hardest. Supply disruptions have fuelled inflation across regions already struggling with post-pandemic fiscal exhaustion. The global economy, which was showing tentative signs of stabilisation, has been knocked sideways. Fuel price spikes have cascading effects on food production, transport, and electricity across developing economies in South Asia, Southeast Asia, and Africa. Countries that had nothing to do with this conflict are paying for it in ways their populations will remember.

The Allies Are Not Hiding Their Frustration

Perhaps the most politically significant development has been the open discomfort among America's closest partners. European capitals were not consulted before the strikes began. The NATO alliance, already under strain, has found itself exposed by the refusal of key members to join the US war effort, with several allies distancing themselves politically and militarily from the campaign. What was once framed as Western unity now looks increasingly hollow, revealing an alliance unwilling to follow Washington into another open-ended Middle Eastern war.

Rival Powers, Watching and Winning

Russia and China stand to be the clearest geopolitical beneficiaries of a United States bogged down in Iran.

WEEK 1

6 WEEKS OF CONFLICT

Decapitation & Escalation (Feb 28 - Mar 6)

FEBRUARY 28: A massive pre-emptive strike by the US and Israel kills Supreme Leader Ali Khamenei and several top officials at his residential compound in Tehran. **RETALIATION:** Iran launches roughly 170 ballistic missiles and hundreds of drones at Israel and US bases in Bahrain, Qatar, and Kuwait. **CIVILIAN TOLL:** A Tomahawk missile strike hits a girls' elementary school in Minab, killing 180 people, sparking international condemnation. **REGIONAL SPILLOVER:** Hezbollah enters the war from Lebanon, launching rockets at Haifa; Israel responds with an intensive bombing campaign in Beirut and the Beqaa Valley.

WEEK 2

Maritime & Energy Crisis (Mar 7 - Mar 13)

MARCH 8: Mojtaba Khamenei is named the new Supreme Leader, though reports suggest he was injured in the initial strikes. **STRAIT OF HORMUZ:** Iran effectively blocks the Strait of Hormuz, targeting commercial vessels and causing global oil prices to skyrocket. **MARCH 13:** US forces strike Kharg Island, Iran's primary oil export terminal.

WEEK 3 & 4

Sustained Combat & Attrition (Mar 14 - Mar 27)

TARGETING LEADERSHIP: Israel kills Ali Larijani (Head of National Security Council) and Gholamreza Soleimani (Basij commander) on March 17. **GROUND WAR FEARS:** The US prepares ground troops for a potential amphibious operation to seize Iranian coastline or islands to reopen shipping lanes. **MARCH 27:** An Iranian strike on Saudi Arabia's Prince Sultan Air Base injures 12 US troops; Houthis rebels join by firing missiles at Israel.

WEEK 5 & 6

Deadlines & Ceasefire (Mar 28 - Apr 8)

THE ULTIMATUM: President Trump issues a deadline, threatening widespread destruction if Iran does not reopen the Strait of Hormuz. **AERIAL COMBAT:** A US F-15E Strike Eagle is shot down on April 3; the pilot is later rescued in a high-risk operation. **THE CEASEFIRE:** A two-week ceasefire is reached through Pakistani mediation. **STATUS TODAY:** A fragile 10-day ceasefire between Israel and Lebanon also took effect on April 16, though Israeli operations in southern Lebanon are not fully complete.

CONTINUED ON >> PII

Challenged by Iran like never before, US blockades Hormuz and India steers carefully

The 21-hour-long marathon peace talks held in Islamabad, Pakistan at the behest of the US, failed, largely because key demands from both sides were not met. US Vice President JD Vance confirmed that negotiations ended without a deal because Iran did not accept US terms. Iranian officials sought a 10-point plan, which included the withdrawal of US forces from the region, the lifting of all sanctions, and recognition of their right to nuclear enrichment. These were not agreed to by the US which demanded a permanent end to

uranium enrichment, dismantling of nuclear facilities, and the reopening of the Strait of Hormuz, which Iran refused. Its reported stance was: "Iran is not in a hurry and until the US agrees to a reasonable deal, there will be no change in the situation of the Strait of Hormuz."

While Iran said that the passage of ships through the Strait of Hormuz will continue to be hampered until an agreement is reached, during the talks, US Department of Defense reportedly said two US Navy guided-missile



ANIL BHAT
Col. VSM (Retd), former
spokesperson, Defence Ministry
and Indian Army

destroyers passed through the Strait of Hormuz as part of a "freedom-of-navigation mission," marking this as the first passage of US ships to transit the Strait since the war began on February 28, 2026.

On April 10-11, 2026, there were reports that a high-value United States Navy high-altitude, long-endurance surveillance drone, named MQ-4C Triton, capable of operating above 50,000 feet as the "eyes over the ocean" for the US Navy, was missing over the Strait of Hormuz.

Despite repeated claims by Trump

that Iran's air force and navy had been completely destroyed, Iran is reported to possess a vast, domestically produced arsenal including a massive inventory of ballistic and cruise missiles, attack drones and naval anti-ship capabilities.

Key systems include Shahab-3 and Sejil medium-range ballistic missiles (MRBMs) with 2,000 km range, Fateh-110 short range ballistic missiles (SRBMs), Shahed suicide drones, Soumar cruise missiles, Ghadir-class midget submarines, Fateh-class medium submarines and an estimated 2,000 to 6,000 sea mines,

ranging from simple contact mines to advanced influence and smart rocket mines. Primarily designed for shallow waters like the Strait of Hormuz, these mines include indigenous models such as the Maham series (3, 7), Sadaf-02, and imported types, aimed at disrupting shipping. Sadaf-02, M-08) float below the surface and detonate upon physical contact with a ship's hull. Bottom influence mines placed on the seafloor are harder to detect and are triggered by a vessel's acoustic, magnetic, or pressure signatures.

CONTINUED ON >> PII

Iran has surprised its opponents. Its resilience has shocked its harshest critics. Iran has demonstrated its reach by striking the US military base at Diego Garcia and carrying out repeated attacks on regional airbases with impunity. Israel's Iron Dome cover has been rendered ineffective as swarms of Iranian drones and missiles have lit up the night skies of several Israeli cities.

Reconfiguring diplomacy in a disorganised global order

The real question is not whether middle-power-style diplomacy works; it is whether the world is still structured in a way that allows it to work

CHAITANYA K PRASAD

Lately, it feels like the world isn't just unstable; it's becoming harder to even manage that instability. Wars aren't staying where they begin. They spill over into everything else, energy markets, supply chains, alliances, and domestic politics. One conflict quietly triggers another crisis somewhere else. And what's unsettling is not just that this is happening, but that there doesn't seem to be any system left that can actually contain it.

For a long time, global politics, however messy, still operated within some structure. Big powers competed, but there were limits. Institutions existed to slow things down, create space for negotiation, or at least prevent things from spiralling too far. Even disagreements had a kind of rhythm to them.

That rhythm is gone. Now, power doesn't necessarily bring control. It often just accelerates events. Military strength can start something, but not always finish it. Economic pressure can hurt but not necessarily change behaviour. Alliances, which once meant predictability, now come with hesitation and second-guessing. You can see it everywhere: partners unsure of each other, responses that feel reactive rather than thought through.

And maybe the biggest shift is this: trust has thinned out. Not disappeared completely, but just enough to make everything harder. In this kind of environment, countries that aren't superpowers but aren't small players either suddenly matter a lot more. What we usually call middle powers.

They don't dominate the system. But they've always had one advantage: they can talk to everyone. They can build bridges, form coalitions, and move across camps without immediately being seen as a threat. In a more stable world, that was useful. In today's world, it's becoming essential. But here's the problem. That role only works when the system allows for flexibility. When you can engage multiple sides without being forced to pick one. When the space for dialogue still exists. Right now, that space is shrinking.

As conflicts harden and positions become more rigid, the expectation to “take a side” becomes stronger. The room for balancing, hedging, or even just staying engaged across divides starts to close. And when that happens, countries that rely on this flexibility are put in a difficult position. India sits right in the middle of this.

On one hand, it has every reason to want stability. Its economy is deeply tied to global flows, energy, trade, and technology. Its diaspora is spread across regions that are directly affected by conflict. Disruptions elsewhere don't stay “elsewhere” for long. On the other hand, India's strength has been its ability to engage widely. It has relationships across competing power centres.



DIPLOMACY IS NO LONGER JUST ABOUT NEGOTIATIONS BETWEEN GOVERNMENTS; IT IS ALSO ABOUT MANAGING PERCEPTION IN REAL TIME. EVERY CRISIS IS PUBLIC, IMMEDIATE, AND CONSTANTLY EVOLVING



It has managed to build partnerships without locking itself too tightly into any one bloc. That's not indecision; it's been a deliberate strategy.

But strategies like this depend on a system staying at least somewhat open. And that's where the tension is growing. As the world becomes more polarised, the cost of staying in the middle increases. Not necessarily because India wants to change course, but because the environment around it is changing. The pressure to align, subtly or directly, is becoming harder to ignore.

What's also changing, quietly but significantly, is the way all of this is communicated and understood. Middle power diplomacy is no longer just about what countries do, but how they

position themselves across overlapping crises. The lines between issues have blurred. Climate is no longer just climate; it is energy, it is development, and it is migration. A war is not just a security issue: it is a food supply, inflation, and humanitarian response. Everything is connected, and everything moves faster than before.

In this kind of environment, new players are stepping in, not necessarily as dominant forces, but as connectors, building smaller, issue-based alliances that cut across traditional blocs. These aren't always formal groupings, and they don't always come with grand declarations, but they reflect a shift in how cooperation is being imagined. Less ideological, more functional.

But this also raises an uncomfortable question: where does that leave South-South cooperation? For years, it has been seen as a space of solidarity and shared priorities. But in a more disorganised global order, even that space is under strain. Countries across the Global South are dealing with very different pressures: debt, climate vulnerability, conflict exposure, and their responses are not always aligned. The idea of a unified voice becomes harder to sustain when the challenges themselves are so uneven.

And yet, this is precisely where its relevance lies. Not as a bloc, but as a flexible platform, one that can adapt to crisis, respond to volatility, and create room for cooperation where formal

systems are failing. Because if the global order is becoming more fragmented, then the ability to communicate across that fragmentation, clearly, consistently, and with intent, becomes just as important as diplomacy itself.

And maybe this is where the real shift is happening: diplomacy is no longer just about negotiations between governments; it is also about managing perception in real time. Every crisis today is public, immediate, and constantly evolving. Narratives form faster than responses. A delayed statement, a poorly framed position, or even silence can be interpreted as alignment, indifference, or weakness. Communication is no longer a follow-up to diplomacy; it is part of the act itself.

For middle powers, this becomes even more critical. Their strength lies in being able to engage across divides, but that balance is fragile. What they say, how they say it, and when they say it can either preserve that space or collapse it. Strategic ambiguity, which once worked quietly in the background, now has to be actively maintained and explained. At the same time, domestic audiences, digital platforms, and global media ecosystems are all feeding into how foreign policy is shaped. Diplomacy is no longer insulated. It is watched, interpreted, and contested in real time. It is about control: of narrative, of timing, and of intent.

So the real question is not whether middle-power style diplomacy works. It's whether the world is still structured in a way that allows it to work. Because if that space disappears, we don't just lose flexibility, we lose one of the few ways the system still holds together. That's why the way forward can't just be about reacting to each crisis as it comes. There has to be a shift in how diplomacy is practised.

One part of that is moving away from rigid, all-or-nothing partnerships towards more focused, issue-based cooperation. Countries don't need to agree on everything to work together on specific problems, whether it's energy security, digital systems, or education. Smaller, targeted coalitions might not look dramatic, but they're often more effective. Another part is thinking less in terms of solving every crisis and more in terms of absorbing them. Because the reality is, not every conflict is going to be resolved quickly. Building resilience, economic, technological, and institutional, becomes just as important as traditional diplomacy.

And then there's the question of shaping the rules themselves. A lot of the future of AI, digital governance, and global education systems is still being defined. Countries that step in early to shape those norms will have far more influence than those who simply adapt later. None of this is a perfect solution. It's not even a clean one. But maybe that's the point. We're no longer operating in a world where everything can be neatly managed.

The idea that there are clear referees, clear rules, and clear outcomes, it doesn't hold the way it used to. And in that kind of world, diplomacy isn't about control anymore. It's about staying connected enough, flexible enough, and prepared enough to keep things from falling apart completely. Because if no one is really in charge of the system anymore, then the responsibility quietly shifts to those who can still move across it without breaking it. And that's a much heavier role than it sounds.

(The author is a commentator and writer on Cinema, branding, media management, and geo-strategic communication. Inputs provided by Zoya Ahmad and Vaishnavi Srinivasan)

FROM AGENDA COVER

Iran-Israel-US war that didn't have to happen

Every carrier group, missile interceptor, and diplomatic hour diverted to the Gulf is attention not spent on Ukraine or the Indo-Pacific. For Moscow, higher oil prices offer fiscal relief while reduced Western focus eases pressure on the Ukraine front. For Beijing, an overstretched America reinforces its narrative of US decline and strategic distraction, while giving China more room to consolidate influence in Asia and present itself as the steadier global power. Just as importantly, the conflict will shape Beijing's calculus on Taiwan, offering a real-time test of how quickly Washington can respond to simultaneous crises, how much domestic appetite it has for prolonged conflict, and how thinly American military power can be stretched across multiple theatres.

The nuclear deal, now inevitable, now more expensive

The deep irony is where negotiations now stand. The finer points of a nuclear agreement - essentially the same agreement that Oman was facilitating before the first strike - are back on the table. Enrichment caps, centrifuge numbers, inspection protocols: these are being discussed again, in more difficult circumstances, with Iran holding more leverage than it had before the war, and the US holding considerably less.

Tehran has not been broken. It has been hardened. Its negotiating position is stronger for having demonstrated that it cannot be bombed into submission. Whatever deal eventually emerges is now likely to cost the West more, in sanctions relief, security guarantees, and political concessions, than the agreement that was within reach before a single bomb was dropped.

The lesson is not complicated: when diplomacy is working, you let it work. The war on Iran was not a calculated risk that went wrong. It was



an unnecessary war launched against the advice of substantial expert opinion, in defiance of a functioning diplomatic process, and in pursuit of a military outcome that was never realistic. The world is paying for that choice, and will be for years.

Vikas swarup is former High Commissioner of India in Canada and has served as spokesperson of the Ministry of External Affairs

Challenged by Iran like never before...

Advanced mines like the Chinese-made EM-52 that rest on the seafloor and on detecting a vessel, launches a rocket at it. Limpet mines are those attached directly to a ship's hull by divers or fast boats to damage or sink them. And there

are also floating explosives designed to move with the current.

Trump said that the US will also begin destroying the mines which he claimed Iran has laid around the strait. He also said: “I have also instructed our Navy to seek and interdict every vessel in International Waters that has paid a toll to Iran.....No one who pays an illegal toll will have safe passage on the high seas.....Any Iranian who fires at us, or at peaceful vessels, will be blown to hell!” Iran has actively countered threats from Trump regarding the superiority of US weapons and military power on the ground through several actions:

Despite Trump's threats to “obliterate” Iranian power plants and reopen the Strait of Hormuz, Iran has maintained a near-total closure of the strategic waterway, using it as a effective economic weapon against the US and its allies. While Trump claimed precisely that Iranian navy's 158

ships were “sitting at the bottom of the sea”, Iran's consulate in Mumbai mocked these claims, posting videos of their fast attack boats still active in the Persian Gulf.

After US-led strikes on Iranian nuclear facilities, which Trump claimed were “completely and totally obliterated,” Iranian officials acknowledged that they were damage but continued to operate, defying assertions that Iran's nuclear ambitions were completely eliminated.

Iran dismissed Trump's 15-point ceasefire plan and 48-hour deadlines as “baseless” and “strategic failures,” choosing to respond with a 10-paragraph counter-proposal for a permanent end to the war. Iranian forces have engaged in, or threatened, unconventional actions, such as using swarms of small speedboats to harass US naval blockades and initiating “human chains” to protect infrastructure and also often responding to high-profile American threats by disrupt-

ing maritime traffic and challenging the narrative of overwhelming US victory. As of April 15, 2026, US Navy's deployment is of over 10,000 personnel and warships to enforce a blockade of Iranian ports in the Strait of Hormuz.

India has adopted a pragmatic policy by maintaining itself as a neutral party that uses its own naval strength to protect its economic interests - shipping and oil. The Indian Navy is actively operating in the region, escorting Indian-flagged tankers through the Gulf of Oman and the Strait. In late March, the Indian Navy initiated Operation Urja Suraksha (protection of energy) with warships like INS Shivalik and INS Nanda Devi deployed to ensure the safe passage of LPG and crude oil tankers.

India is negotiating high-stakes diplomacy, maintaining good relations with the US, Iran, and Gulf Arab nations to secure its energy needs and has continued to get discounted LPG shipments from Iran to avert domestic shortages, while simultaneously ensuring these actions do not invite US sanctions.

Iran has reportedly allowed Indian ships through the blockade as part of a “safe corridor” for friendly nations, often involving direct negotiations with Iranian authorities.

As the largest ship user of the Strait, India has challenges. While its crude imports from Iran were halted in 2019, it is managing this new conflict by receiving its first Iranian cargo in seven years while also aiming to ensure that energy shipments- LNG/LPG - continue to reach Mumbai and New Mangalore.

A risk that India faces is of navigating a US blockade that views some Iranian-linked vessels as subject to seizure, potentially leading to increased insurance costs and a direct need for naval protection of its shipping interests.

(Col Anil Bhat, VSM (Retd), is a strategic affairs analyst and former spokesperson, Defence Ministry and Indian Army)

“COOKING IS AT ONCE CHILD’S PLAY
AND ADULT JOY”
— CRAIG CLAIBORNE

Many New Years, one civilisational palate



ANIL
RAJPUT

There are moments in Bharat’s civilisational journey when diversity reveals itself as a deeper expression of continuity. Last week, we reflected on Baisakhi in Punjab, where the harvest of wheat and the spirit of gratitude, labour, and collective celebration find one of their most vivid expressions. Yet this seasonal turning is not confined to Punjab alone. Across Bharat, mid-April carries a wider significance, marking a shared moment of renewal through regional New Year observances, agrarian transitions, and the gradual movement from spring towards summer. Their names differ from region to region, their rituals are shaped by local customs and languages, and their festive cuisines reflect distinct climates, crops, and histories. Yet beneath this rich variation lies something far older and more enduring than geography. These observances embody India’s timeless ethos of unity in diversity. It is in the kitchen, and around the shared table, that this civilisational continuity moves beyond abstraction and becomes a lived inheritance.

Bohag or Rongali Bihu in Assam, Poila Boishakh in Bengal, Navreh in Kashmir, Vishu in Kerala, Pana Sankranti in Odisha, Baisakhi in Punjab, and Puthandu in Tamil Nadu are not merely parallel festivals coincidentally appearing on the calendar. They arise from a civilisation that has long looked at time through the movement of seasons, harvest, light, and community living. In one region, the wheat stands ready for harvest, in another, the new agricultural cycle begins with spring. Elsewhere, the New Year is welcomed through an auspicious beginning of the lunar calendar or a refreshing preparation suited to the onset of summer. The culinary expressions differ, but the governing instinct remains recognisable. Food must mark renewal, reflect the season, honour labour, and gather the community into a shared experience of gratitude and hope. That is why these observances are best understood not as disconnected celebrations, but as many expressions of one civilisational palate.

In Assam, Bohag or Rongali Bihu expresses renewal through freshness, grain, and springtime warmth. Celebrated as the Assamese New Year and the beginning of a new agricultural cycle, Bohag Bihu carries an atmosphere of renewal and hope. At its heart are offerings drawn directly from the freshly harvested produce and includes combinations of chira (flattened rice), xandoh (roasted and ground rice), akhoi (parched rice grains), and doi (fresh fermented milk), consumed in their simplest form to evoke purity and sufficiency. Alongside these are the many varieties of pitha, rice flour cakes filled with sesame, coconut, or jaggery and laru, small confections of coconut or sesame bound with jaggery, whose rounded form and sweetness signify completeness and auspicious beginnings. Together, these foods represent freshness over embellishment, and continuity over spectacle.

Yet, this simplicity does not preclude depth. The Assamese table during Bihu is equally defined by distinctive preparations such as khar whose defining feature is an alkaline extract traditionally derived from the ash of sun-dried banana peels.

This extract is then combined with ingredients such as raw papaya, pulses, colocasia (arbi), or even certain leafy greens, creating a dish that is mild, cleansing, and subtly earthy in character. Greens and vegetables, reflective of the spring harvest, appear as xaak, a dish made of 101 different varieties of herbs and green leafy vegetables. Alongside this, dishes of fish like masor tenga, a light and tangy fish curry prepared with souring agents like tomatoes, lemon, or dried fruits and meat like duck meat curry, haahor mangxo, often cooked with ash gourd (Kumura) or sesame seeds, provide the highlight of the meal. Bohag Bihu’s food thus reflects and honours the field, welcoming the new cycle, with a freshness that belongs especially to spring.

In Bengal, Poila Boishakh brings a more formal sense of beginning, shaped by ceremonial order, hospitality, and the cultural confidence of a society long accustomed to making refinement part of festivity. The Bengali New Year table often unfolds with discernible complexity. It may begin with shukto, whose composed bitterness and soft vegetable textures prepare the palate rather than overwhelm it. From there the meal broadens into a richer procession. Fish, central to Bengali identity, assumes a place of prominence, particularly preparations like ilish maach, prized for its richness and cultural significance. Luchi paired with potato preparations such as alur dom or aloo posto retains its place as a beloved festive combination. Rice-based dishes such as basanti pulao express prosperity and regional identity with equal force. Bengal’s New Year cuisine is celebratory, but never careless. Even its indulgence carries a refined structure with its deserts deepening that impression. Payesh, slowly thickened from rice and milk, carries affection and auspiciousness in equal measure. Mishti doi offers coolness and gentle richness. Sandesh brings restraint and delicacy through chhana. The table thus becomes not only a celebration of the new year, but also a statement of cultured balance, where appetite is welcomed but shaped by order and aesthetic care.

Navreh marks the arrival of the New Year in Kashmir, a moment rooted in the ancient lunar tradition. It marks not merely the passage of time but a conscious reorientation towards order and clarity. At its centre is the ritual of the thaal, an arrangement of symbolic and edible items such as rice, curd, bread or wheat cakes, cooked rice, and walnuts, placed alongside the almanac, coins, flowers, and mirror, and viewed at dawn as the first sight of the year. Each element signifies prosperity, nourishment, continuity, and self-reflection. Alongside the ritual thaal, many households also prepare festive dishes such as kheer and tahar, while some tables may further be enriched with preparations like modur pulao, dum aloo, or nadru yakhni. Kashmiri cuisine is never complete without its legendary meat and fish preparations that may be common through the year but assume significance during the festive season. Dishes such as Rogan Josh, comprising lamb in a rich, aromatic gravy, and Yakhni, where meat is simmered in a yoghurt-based sauce, bring depth and warmth to the table. Riverine influences appear in preparations like Fish Curry, typically featuring local fresh-water fish in lightly spiced gravies. Navreh thus expresses renewal not through an elaborate feast alone, but through a ritual grammar of

auspicious foods that brings together local produce with nourishment.

Kerala’s Vishu offers perhaps one of the most explicit examples of how food, symbolism, and philosophy remain inseparable in Indian festive life. Vishukkani, the central ritual of the Kerala New Year festival, is an auspicious arrangement of symbolic items prepared the night before and viewed at dawn as the first sight (kani) of the New Year. It typically includes rice (paddy), fruits, vegetables, a metal mirror (valkannadi), coins, flowers, especially golden konna blooms and sacred texts or images of Lord Krishna. Each element represents abundance, prosperity, and continuity. Grains, fruits, vegetables, flowers, and vessels are brought together on the occasion so that prosperity is first encountered visually as balance and auspiciousness.

This sensibility continues at the meal through the vishu sadya, the grand vegetarian feast served on a banana leaf. This comprises rice, parippu, sambar, rasam, and side dishes such as avial, a medley of seasonal vegetables bound with coconut and yogurt and thoran, finely chopped vegetables paired with grated coconut. Olan, a gentle preparation of ash gourd and cowpeas in a light coconut milk base, and kalaan, a thicker dish of yam and raw banana in a yoghurt and coconut base, create a complete meal that satiates different tastes without losing composure. A defining element of the Vishu table is the deliberate inclusion of contrasting tastes, most notably vishu kanji in some households, and the symbolic vishu sadya itself, where sweet, sour, bitter, and savoury coexist. Preparations such as pachadi and kichadi introduce nuanced flavours, while the meal concludes with desserts like payasam, made from rice, lentils or vermicelli with milk and jaggery. Kerala’s festive logic reveals a culinary philosophy in which order itself becomes celebratory. Prosperity is not only what is possessed but how it is arranged and presented, shared, and received with awareness.

Odisha’s Pana Sankranti adds yet another dimension to this civilisational palate by showing how festive food also responds directly to climate. With summer intensifying, the day centres on pana, especially bela pana, the cooling drink prepared from bael fruit pulp with jaggery and other seasonal ingredients suited to the heat. Alongside it, chhatua, prepared from roasted gram or grain flour and often mixed with jaggery, banana, or water, offers nourishment in a form at once simple, sustaining, and culturally resonant. The festive meal may also include kanika, a fragrant sweet rice



preparation that lends the table a note of auspiciousness and quiet celebration. Complementing these are dishes such as dalma, a wholesome combination of lentils and seasonal vegetables, and lightly spiced preparations that is renowned for its simplicity and nutrition. Odisha’s seasonal wisdom is unmistakable here. The festival does not oppose the climate. It listens to it.

Baisakhi in Punjab carries both agrarian fulfillment and profound spiritual memory. Falling with the wheat harvest, it marks abundance, a reward for efforts and labour, and, for the Sikh community, the historic formation of the Khalsa by Guru Gobind Singh in 1699. The food of Baisakhi therefore does not begin in indulgence, but in sanctity and shared service. Kada prasad, prepared at homes and Gurudwaras alike, is made from wheat flour, ghee, and sugar or freshly made jaggery, and remains central to the day’s spiritual atmosphere. At the Gurdwara, langar extends the same ethic into the social sphere, where simple yet nutritious fare such as dal, sabzi, roti and kheer is shared in a spirit of equality and humility. Nourishment is offered not as display, but as an act of seva.

In the home, however, the meal expands into a warmer festive feast that is in tune with the season. Meethe chawal, fragrant with ghee and often coloured with saffron or turmeric, expresses joy through sweetness and carries the glow of harvest in its golden appearance. Kadhi chawal, with its yogurt-based tang and comforting texture, brings balance to the table and is especially fitting in a season when heavier winter fare begins to recede. Amritsari chole, slow-cooked until richly spiced and deeply coloured, are often paired with breads like puris and kulchas that lend the meal a sense of celebratory generosity. Lassi and chaach offer both hospitality and relief as the weather begins to warm. The sweet lassi is flavoured and carries aromatic notes of cardamom, rose or kewra water or saffron strands (kesar). Chaach, on the other hand, is enriched with roasted cumin powder, along with crushed black pepper or fresh green chillies and fresh coriander (cilantro) leaves or mint leaves (pudina). Ginger, finely grated or pasted, is commonly added for extra zest. The Baisakhi table is unmistakably Punjabi, abundant and welcoming, and aligned faithfully with the climate and mood of April

rather than with the depth of winter.

Tamil Nadu’s Puthandu carries a similarly profound insight, though expressed through a different culinary language. The most symbolic dish of the festival is mango pachadi, whose ingredients bring together sweet, sour, bitter, and spicy elements through raw mango, jaggery, neem flowers, and chilli. Interestingly, these represent the different moods and emotions of life itself and serve as a reminder that food is a means of reflecting and sustaining life itself. Around this central preparation gather other festive dishes such as avial, rasam, rice, vegetable accompaniments, vadai, and festive sweets prepared in different households. The festive spread is further enriched by elements that lend texture and contrast. Poriyal, comprising vegetables tempered with spices and coconut, and payasam, brings the meal to a gentle close. Here too the meal is vegetarian, seasonal, and structured by inherited taste logic rather than random assortment. Puthandu demonstrates that cuisine can serve not only as sensory pleasure, but as ethical instruction. It welcomes the new year by reminding the household that resilience begins in acceptance, and that balance is not an abstract virtue but something that can be placed on the plate and shared at the family table.

Across Bharat, as the New Year arrives under many names, it reveals a pattern that is both varied and continuous. Each region, shaped by its own ecology and culture, gives form to new beginnings through distinct rituals and seasonal foods, yet the underlying impulse remains shared. As the season shifts and gives rise to new cycles, it marks the turning of time with balance, gratitude, and hope for the future. I believe that the differences are not incidental but are the very means through which a deeper coherence of our country is sustained. In an age of constant motion, when pause and reflection are becoming increasingly rare, it is all the more important that we not only preserve these civilisational traditions, customs, and cuisines, but also consciously pass them on to future generations, so that the rich and beautiful journey of our cultural inheritance may continue with the same vitality and meaning. It is our collective responsibility, therefore, to recognize, honour and preserve this rich heritage, its customs and cuisines and the affirmation of a civilisational order that has long understood how to hold diversity with harmony.

(The writer is Secretary, Cuisine India Society)

The longevity reset: Why healthspan is the new goal

From protein trends to sleep tracking and supplements, longevity is trending. Experts say ageing well depends on mastering the fundamentals early, with a focus on metabolic health, muscle, nutrition, and sleep

TARVENE SHAHPURI

Scroll through social media today, and longevity is everywhere. From morning sunlight routines to protein-focused meals and supplement stacks, the idea of “living longer” has quietly evolved into something far more nuanced — and far more urgent.

But beneath the aesthetics of wellness lies a deeper shift. As Vishakha Shivdasani, a physician specialising in longevity and disease reversal, explains, what we are witnessing is not just a trend — it’s a turning point in how we think about health.

“Traditionally, medicine has focused on treating disease after it appears,” she says. “Longevity medicine is about extending healthspan — the number of years you live free of chronic disease. Lifespan only matters if healthspan improves.” This reframing is critical. Because the real goal is no longer just to live longer - but to live well for longer.

From reaction to prevention

For decades, healthcare systems — and even individuals — have largely operated in a reactive mode. Symptoms appear, tests are run, and treatment follows. What longevity brings into focus is the idea that disease doesn’t begin when symptoms show up. It begins much earlier. “More and more people are now asking how to prevent diabetes, heart disease, dementia and metabolic illness decades before they appear,” says Shivdasani. “Because that is when the disease process actually starts.”

This shift toward preventive health is one of the most encouraging aspects of the current wellness movement. People in their 30s and 40s — once considered “too young” to worry about chronic illness — are now paying attention to markers like insulin resistance, inflammation, and metabolic health. And rightly so. According to Shivdasani many of the biological processes that



determine how we age begin silently, long before diagnosis. Fatty liver, hormonal imbalances, micronutrient deficiencies - these are not late-stage concerns. They are early signals.

The good news? Most of these conditions are modifiable — and in some cases, even reversible — if caught early.

Cutting through the noise: What longevity is not

With social media amplifying the conversation, longevity has also become increasingly misunderstood. “I see a lot of misinformation,” Shivdasani notes. “Longevity is often portrayed as biohacking, ice baths, expensive testing, or taking dozens of supplements.” While these elements may have their place, they are not the foundation.

The strongest scientific evidence, she emphasises, continues to point to a far simpler set of drivers: metabolic health, nutrition, sleep, muscle mass, and inflammation control.

In other words, the basics still matter most. Another common misconception is that longevity is something to think about later in life. In reality,

ageing is a continuous biological process that begins much earlier. By the time symptoms appear, the groundwork has often been laid for years.

Food as information, not just fuel

If there is one pillar that consistently emerges in longevity science, it is diet. “Food is one of the most powerful determinants of how we age,” says Shivdasani. “It directly influences metabolism, inflammation, gut health and muscle mass.” In fact, she describes food as something far more dynamic than calories. “The food on your plate can literally switch genes on or off.”

Yet, in today’s hyper-connected world, nutrition advice often swings between extremes. On one end are global trends — high-protein diets, gut health protocols, superfoods. On the other is a nostalgic return to traditional eating. The real answer lies somewhere in between.

Traditional Indian diets, Shivdasani points out, already include many longevity-supporting elements: diverse plant foods, spices, and fermented preparations. What needs updating is

not the foundation, but the balance.

“Most people need to modernise protein intake and fibre diversity,” she explains. “Meals should support muscle health, gut microbiome diversity and stable blood sugar as we age.” It’s less about abandoning tradition — and more about evolving it.

Why muscle is the new health marker

For years, fitness was largely equated with weight loss. Today, the conversation has shifted toward something more fundamental: strength.

“Muscle is literally a metabolic organ,” says Shivdasani. Healthy muscle improves insulin sensitivity, supports bone density, and protects against conditions like type 2 diabetes, frailty, and falls. Yet, after the age of 30, muscle mass naturally begins to decline - a process that accelerates significantly after 40 if not actively addressed.

This is where strength training becomes essential. “Even two to three sessions a week — even 20 minutes - is enough to make a difference,” she says. The goal is not extreme workouts or aesthetic transformations. It is functional fitness — the ability to move well, stay strong, and remain independent over time. Paired with regular walking and mobility work, strength training forms a critical pillar of long-term health.

The supplement question

Few areas of wellness have grown as rapidly — or as confusingly — as supplements. From collagen powders to omega-3 capsules, social media is filled with recommendations, routines, and “must-have” lists.

But according to Shivdasani, this is where caution is essential. “Supplements are not universally beneficial,” she explains. “What works for one person may be unnecessary — or even inappropriate — for another.” In her clinical practice, she often sees individuals taking multiple supple-

ments without addressing underlying issues such as insulin resistance, gut dysfunction, or micronutrient deficiencies. The solution lies in personalisation. “The most reliable approach is evidence-based supplementation guided by clinical assessment and relevant blood tests.” In other words, supplements should be strategic — not trend-driven. For those navigating health information online, her advice is clear: look for credibility. Seek out professionals who base their recommendations on research, clinical experience, and transparency — not just popularity.

The foundations that actually matter

With so much information available, it’s easy to feel overwhelmed. But when it comes to longevity, the fundamentals remain surprisingly consistent. If someone were to begin their health journey today, Shivdasani recommends focusing on a few key habits:

- **Prioritise metabolic health through nutrition** : A balanced diet rich in whole foods, adequate protein, fibre, and healthy fats helps regulate blood sugar, reduce inflammation, and support gut health. “Do not fear good fats,” she adds.
- **Build and maintain muscle** : Strength training, combined with daily movement, supports everything from insulin sensitivity to bone health and long-term mobility.
- **Optimise sleep and manage stress** : Poor sleep and chronic stress disrupt hormones, increase inflammation, and accelerate ageing.
- **Support gut health** : “Most disease processes begin in the gut,” she notes, emphasising its central role in overall well-being. These are not quick fixes. They are long-term investments.

A more personal future of health

Perhaps the most exciting aspect of the longevity movement is its shift toward



personalisation.

No two individuals age in exactly the same way. Genetics, lifestyle, environment, and medical history all play a role. What works for one person may not work for another. This is why the future of healthcare, as Shivdasani sees it, lies in tailored, preventive approaches — ones that identify risks early and intervene before disease takes hold.

Beyond the trend

Longevity may be trending — but its implications are far from superficial. At its core, this movement is about understanding that the way we eat, move, sleep, and recover today shapes the quality of our lives tomorrow. And perhaps most importantly, it is about redefining what it means to be healthy. Not just symptom-free. Not just productive. But physically strong, mentally sharp, and metabolically resilient — well into the later decades of life.

Because in the end, longevity is not about adding years to life. It is about adding life to those years.

(The writer is a Content Lead at India Food Network)

Rekindle The Sense of Sacredness for The Planet

People should be encouraged to treat the planet as sacred, to treat trees and rivers as sacred, to treat people as sacred, and to see God in nature and in people

GURUDEV SRI SRI RAVI SHANKAR

In many ancient cultures across the world, every morning, before placing their foot on the ground, people would honour the Earth and express gratitude before moving on with their day. This is a very good practice that makes you recognise that the boundary between you and the Earth is an illusion. You are made of the same substance.

Only life can sustain life. According to ancient scriptures, human beings have five sheaths: the environment, the physical body, the mind, the intuitive sheath, and the blissful sheath. The environment is our first body. Historically, nature-mountains, rivers, the sun, the moon, trees, and animals has always been honoured. It is only when we start moving away from nature that we begin polluting it. We need to revive the ancient practice of honouring and conserving the balance of nature.

But this was not always the case. If you observe indigenous and aboriginal cultures, reverence for nature has always been deeply embedded in their practices. When I travelled through these regions, I saw how much they valued purity in nature, how well they maintained their surroundings, and kept their environment clean. You will not find litter or pollution in these villages. This discipline and care offer an important lesson for modern society.

Ancient cultures across the world considered nature to be alive and expressed gratitude for all its bounties. Natural elements were not seen as inert objects but as living expressions of existence. Everything in nature was considered sacred. Rivers, mountains, the sun, and the moon were all worshipped. This was part of daily life. If you observe children, they talk to the moon; they form a bond with it. Trees, too, were revered as the lungs of our planet. Knowing their importance, ancient Vedic philosophy stated that if one wished to cut a tree, one had to first seek its permission and promise to plant five more of the same kind. The peepal or banyan tree, which releases oxygen throughout the day, was regarded as especially sacred.

A popular belief is that damage to ecology is an inevitable by-product of technological progress. This is a misconception. Science and technology should not be regarded as inherently anti-environment. The purpose of technology is to harness nature and bring information and comfort to human beings. When spiritual and human values are ignored, technology leads to pollution and destruction instead of comfort. We need to find ways to maintain harmony with the environment while advancing science and technology. This is the greatest challenge of this century.

Sustainable development is that which considers the long-term effects and benefits of any programme. Ravaging natural resources without a long-term vision will destroy the ecology, which is the very source of life. The purpose of development should be to support and sustain life. With the bigger picture in mind, all development plans must factor in ecology, social impact, and the effect on the lives and minds of the local population. Then, the process of development becomes a conscious endeavour to preserve the planet and its resources.

When we revere nature, it begins to reveal its hidden wisdom. For example, the five elements appear to oppose each other-water extinguishes fire, fire transforms air-yet they coexist in perfect harmony. Similarly, there are many species in nature-birds, reptiles, and mammals that may seem hostile to one another, yet they remain in balance. A forest, with all its diversity, remains self-sustaining and free from pollution. We need to learn how nature digests waste and transforms it into something beneficial.

Human beings, however, have not yet mastered the art of living in harmony



“IN NURTURING THE PLANET, WE NURTURE LIFE; AND IN SUSTAINING LIFE, WE FULFIL OUR OWN PURPOSE” — GURUDEV



with nature. This reflects a disconnect from natural intelligence. To restore balance, we must learn from nature not just through observation, but through a shift in consciousness-from selfishness to a sense of belonging with the whole planet. When there is a sense of belonging, care and responsibility arise naturally.

The Earth has been changing constantly, but what humankind has done to the planet is deeply unfortunate. Many of the natural disasters we witness today reflect the imbalance in nature caused by human neglect; what we now call climate change is a manifestation of this deeper disconnect. It is a lack of reverence for nature that has resulted in such insensitivity. A mind that is disconnected, insensitive, or driven by greed inevitably leads to actions that harm the Earth.

Destroying the environment, cutting down trees, dumping toxic waste, and using non-recyclable materials are crimes against the environment, and we need to recognise them as such. The greatest pollutant is not industrial waste alone, but human greed. It hinders the preservation of ecology, placing quick profit and immediate results above sustainable, planet-friendly ways of living. We need to discover ways to protect this beautiful planet Earth. For that to happen, human consciousness must rise above greed and exploitation. Exploitation has two phases: first, the exploitation of others; second, the exploitation of the Earth. This must be checked. For that, human beings need a broader vision and a

deeper understanding of life, and of themselves in relation to the cosmos.

Human beings are the only species that pollute the elements of nature. We must stop polluting the Earth with plastic, poisonous fertilisers, and chemicals. There are also many dangers associated with genetically modified food. There is an urgent need to return to natural farming. In India, there is a long tradition of honouring rivers-the water element. Yet today, hardly any river is fit for drinking, even a hundred kilometres from its source. We must stop discharging industrial waste, sewage, and garbage into our rivers. Nor does a river ask for flowers and fruits to be offered to it; what it requires is cleanliness and care. To protect the air element, we need clean energy that can sustain this beautiful creation. The space element, though subtle and beyond our grasp, can be polluted by negativity in the mind. When you free your mind from negativity, you fill that space with joy, confidence, and positive energy.

Who can stop polluting the Earth? Someone who is aware, someone who respects the planet. Respecting the Earth requires a big heart, and respecting inanimate objects requires an even greater one. A certain level of awareness and awakening is essential for this to happen. It is insensitivity that makes a person act carelessly towards the environment. If a person is sensitive, they will nurture the environment and, in doing so, reduce pollution and prevent the degradation of the planet.

Addressing environmental issues, therefore, requires more than policies and regulations. It calls for a transformation in human awareness. When compassion and care are awakened within the self, they naturally reflect in our actions. A sense of sacredness begins to arise towards the Earth, nature, and life itself. When we start seeing the divine presence in trees, rivers, and all forms of existence, our relationship with the Earth changes fundamentally.

The Earth sustains life, and life must, in turn, sustain the Earth. Nature nourishes us, and we must care for it. A healthy future for coming generations depends on how we treat our environment today. Let us rekindle the sense of sacredness that once guided us to live in harmony with nature.

In nurturing the planet, we nurture life; and in sustaining life, we fulfil our own purpose.

How Science Embraces Spirituality: When President Kalam Met His Ultimate Teacher

The architect of our sophisticated space and missile technology, and a rare scientist whose vision was to develop society upon the foundation of values, Bharat Ratna APJ Abdul Kalam came calling upon HDH Pramukh Swami Maharaj, with his fellow scientist YS Rajan. This special meeting on June 30, 2001, in New Delhi, turned out to be a beautiful fusion of science and spirituality



GYANANANDAS SWAMI

“It was a hot summer evening on June 30, 2001 when I met Pramukh Swamiji for the first time. Resplendent in saffron robes, the gentle, fair-complexioned Pramukh Swamiji was radiating divinity.” With these timeless words, APJ Abdul Kalam begins his remarkable and widely celebrated book Transcendence, setting the tone for a deeply spiritual and reflective journey.

During the construction of the world-renowned Akshardham Mandir, Pramukh Swami Maharaj came to Delhi to personally guide and review the progress of this monumental project. It was during one such visit that Kalam came to meet him. When he entered the serene room of Swamiji, the attendant sadhus respectfully offered him a sofa befitting the great scientist of India. But Kalam, with his characteristic simplicity, gently declined. Instead, he chose to sit cross-legged on the floor among the devotees.

After warm greetings, Kalam posed a question: “Swamiji, five hundred members like me are thinking about what should be the next vision for India. How do we transform a developing country into a developed country in the next 30 years? We have identified five important areas to transform India: education and healthcare, agriculture, information and communication, infrastructure, and critical technology.”

He added further, “Swamiji, our problem is that we may present this before the Government, but how do we create people with values to carry out such a big vision? What we need is a cadre of value-based citizens. For this, you are an expert. We need your advice.”

Swamiji answered, “Along with these five, add a sixth-faith in God and developing people through spirituality. We need to first generate a moral and spiritual atmosphere. With these character-based people, problems will be solved and we shall be able to achieve what we dream.”

In further conversation, Swamiji explained that material advancement and spiritual growth are not separate paths, but parallel forces that must move together. Drawing from India's timeless wisdom, he emphasised the harmony of Apra Vidya (worldly knowl-



edge) and Para Vidya (spiritual knowledge): one empowers, the other guides; one builds capability, the other shapes character. Science gives us tools; spirituality gives us direction. Science builds capability; spirituality builds character. In that moment, the two worlds-science and spirituality-did not collide, but complemented each other.

From that day on, Kalam did not merely remember Pramukh Swami; he wished to meet him again and again, as a seeker returns to a source. Then came a defining moment. Having risen to the highest office in the nation, he got the opportunity to visit Ahmedabad on August 13, 2002.

In a move that surprised many, the President of India arrived at the BAPS Swaminarayan Mandir, seeking not ceremony, but guidance and blessings from Pramukh Swami. What followed was not just a meeting; it was a revelation waiting to unfold.

Swamiji welcomed the President with deep love and care. On this occasion, the Chief Minister of Gujarat, Shri Narendrabhai Modi, Vadibhai Patel, Secretary YS Rajan, Secretary Shri Sheridan, and other dignitaries accompanying the President were also garlanded. In the meeting, their dialogue extended to the theme of national unity. The President asked, “Unity of thought is important for our country and its progress. How can this unity be attained?”

Pramukh Swamiji replied, “Our Indian tradition teaches us that we are all the children of God, and God resides within all of us; thus, we are all one. We should

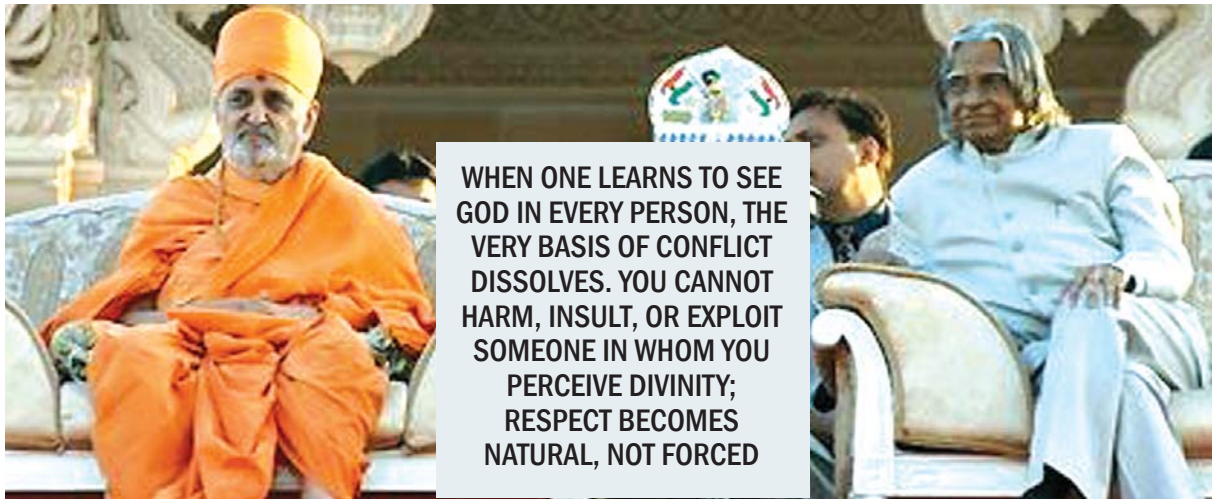
live together and work for the progress of the country.”

It was the fundamental source of unity. When one learns to see God in every person, the very basis of conflict dissolves. You cannot harm, insult, or exploit someone in whom you perceive divinity; respect becomes natural, not forced. This vision shifts reactions from ego to empathy, reducing anger at its root. Whether in a family disagreement or a global dispute, it replaces “defeat the other” with “understand the other”. Thus, from street quarrels to world conflicts, this principle offers a deeply logical path to lasting peace.

In this way, APJ Abdul Kalam met Pramukh Swami Maharaj several times. Each encounter deepened his admiration and inner connection. Profoundly touched by Swamiji's purity, wisdom, and quiet spiritual power, Kalam felt an irresistible urge to share this experience with the world.

This inspiration eventually took shape as the book Transcendence. On June 20, 2015, in a moment of deep reverence, Kalam personally travelled to Sarangpur, Gujarat, to present the very first copy of the book to Swamiji — an offering of gratitude from a scientist whose heart had been deeply touched by the Guru, whom he himself admired as “my ultimate teacher”. He added, “I have learned a great lesson from him: how to remove 'I' and 'me' (I-ness and my-ness).”

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Fleeting Emotions, Meandering Lives: ‘Ek Tarengan, Do Tarengan’

Author-Diplomat Anju Ranjan's ‘Ek Tarengan, Do Tarengan’ is an evocative ensemble of stories deeply anchored in human emotions

RAO NARENDER YADAV

Life abhors linear narratives; it likes meandering curves. And by doing so, in a way, it prepares us to face uncertainties, away from the comfortable and familiar rhythm of daily life. Alas! We always remain unprepared. Yet, the journey gives rise to a web of emotions that defines not just our personality but also our relationship with family as well as society. Author-diplomat Anju Ranjan's characters in her deeply intimate collection of stories *Ek Tarengan, Do Tarengan* live in different geographies, cultures, and life phases, oscillating

between enduring melancholy and sensory elation.

The collection of 10 stories gives us not just a peek into the lives of the characters but also enough opportunity to be part of their individual journeys. Evocatively expressed through the eyes of female protagonists, the stories unravel deeper layers of emotion, resilience, and quiet strength.

What makes Ranjan's storytelling deeply personal and engaging is the introduction of each and every character. Irrespective of the temporal and spatial existence of the story, the characters look familiar and personal, charming-



Title: *Ek Tarengan, Do Tarengan*
Author: Anju Ranjan
MRP: ₹295
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ly inviting the reader into their inner selves. Their lives are far from perfect, marred by contradictions, swinging heavily between the freedom to dream and the pressure to compromise. Her female characters are strong-even when they choose death or are forced to die. Love, longing, trust, aspirations, and a deep desire to remove the shackles of societal imposition give characters like Reema, Rekha, Meeta, Sarika, and Swati a distinct voice and the confidence to take decisions they have been contemplating in their inner selves.

“The Funeral Service” lays threadbare the incongruity of emotions in an intimate relationship between a husband and wife of forty years. The hollowness of social ceremonies, together with the pain of self-inflicted detachment, makes

Swati a vulnerable soul and leaves a deep scar on the reader. In “Aansu na Behne Dena”, the lives of Reema, Amit, Akash, and Swati are so deeply interconnected that it becomes difficult to identify who should be blamed. In contrast, “Parem ki Khatir” makes it impossible for the reader to resist rebuking and punishing Bhuvan for stifling the vivacious life of Rekha. Amidst this raging anger for Bhuvan, the ‘sin’ committed by Pahun of bringing Rekha into an illicit relationship remains away from memory.

From Glasgow to Barcelona and Hazaribagh, the deep-rootedness of the stories in societal contexts, as well as diverse emotions, makes the reader actually enter the family and community of the characters. So immersive is the experience that

sometimes knowing the name of the character does not seem important for the continuity of the narrative. As happens in “Love in Hazaribagh”, where the social complexity in the relationship between an Oraon tribal boy and a Rajput girl has been so vividly expressed that the name of the girl, ‘Sushma’, appears only once, quite late in the story. Yet, as readers, we seem to have known her since the beginning.

Ranjan's female characters are not just individuals drifting into the unexpected, alone and helpless, but each time they emerge as the ones steering the direction of their lives. Be it Mukti in Mukti or Sarika in Golden Jubilee Talak. Stories like “Mushroom Picking” and “Bread-jam” show how revenge-instant or long-drawn-is a deeply human

impulse, born out of hurt, distrust, and injustice. For Meeta, the decision not to eat bread-jam becomes the best form of revenge; it turns into a driving force that she wants to keep alive. In “Tumhe Kaisa Na Karun”, Ranjan tries to bring in the impact of social media, weaving a story of romance, tragedy, and hope. Meanwhile, in “Aisa Kyon Hota Hai?”, the sense of unease, moral disquiet, and the hollowness of social engagements, as reflected in the lives of Fatima and Yakub, compel the reader to pause and reflect. *EkTarengan, Do Tarengan* not only leaves readers with deep thoughts but also gently urges them to explore the intricate web of their own emotions.

(The book reviewer is the Director of the African Centre of India, an independent think tank)